

CM launches cleanliness campaign, best wards to get up to `1 crore monthly

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
n New Delhi

Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Monday launched the “*Delhi Ko Kude Se Azadi, Swachhta Abhiyan 2026*” at Kedarnath Sahni Auditorium, announcing a ward level cleanliness competition.

In the competition, the best-performing ward each month will receive `1 crore, with top performers eligible for up to `12 crore in incentives over a year.

The campaign, which will run till October 2, 2026, aims to strengthen the city’s sanitation system, promote scientific waste management and encourage public participation in cleanliness efforts.

A campaign brochure was released at the launch,

attended by Union Minister of State and Delhi BJP president Harsh Malhotra, Urban Development Minister Ashish Sood, Mayor Pravesh Wahi and Chief Whip Abhay Verma.

The Chief Minister announced that a cleanliness competition will run at the ward level for 12 months. The cleanest ward each month will receive `1 crore, and wards that continue performing well in subsequent months could receive an additional `2 crore, potentially totalling `12 crore in CMDF funds over the year.

She said ward performance would be assessed through reports from an independent agency, official submissions and public complaints, including those made on social media.

The Chief Minister warned that any ward found with garbage complaints could be disqualified from the competition.

The Chief Minister said cleanliness was a shared responsibility rather than the task of any single department, and that the campaign aimed to bring together Government department, local bodies, RWAs, market associations, schools, industries and citizens.

The Chief Minister outlined a focus on four elements of waste management: collection, cleaning, conversion, and the circular economy, calling for waste segregation at the source, proper collection, scientific processing, and swift action wherever dirt accumulates.



Delhi CM Rekha Gupta, Delhi Minister Ashish Sood and Delhi BJP President Harsh Malhotra during the launch of the 'Cleanliness Campaign 2026 to Make Delhi Garbage-Free' in New Delhi on Monday

The Chief Minister announced a series of scheduled activities under the campaign. Special drives in slum clusters will be held on August 23, 30, and September 6 and 13.

Public toilets will receive focused cleaning every Saturday and Sunday. A campaign to clear green waste from parks will run from September 1 to 10. Government hospitals will see special cleanliness drives on September 17.

From September 17 to October 2, the “*Mera School, Sabse Sundar*” competition will focus on school upkeep alongside a zero waste campus initiative.

She said 70 mechanical sweeping machines, additional litter picker vehicles

per ward and 125 secondary collection centres for construction and demolition waste are being developed.

Malhotra said the campaign sought to make cleanliness part of people’s everyday thinking and behaviour, drawing a comparison to Mahatma Gandhi’s association of cleanliness with the freedom movement and Prime Minister Narendra Modi’s Swachh Bharat call.

He said the Delhi Government had strengthened the Municipal Corporation financially, enabling faster sanitation work.

Sood said the campaign was about changing citizens’ habits and approach toward cleanliness, not just cleaning roads.

6,000 join Tiranga Yatra in Connaught Place, CM calls it resolve for Viksit Bharat

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
n New Delhi

The New Delhi Municipal Council organised a Tiranga Yatra in Connaught Place on Monday, with around 6,000 students, employees and citizens joining the march as part of the ‘Har Ghar Tiranga’ campaign.

Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta flagged off the yatra from Janpath Radial at the Inner Circle of Connaught Place, where participants marched with the Tricolour and raised patriotic slogans.

Addressing the gathering, the chief minister said the yatra was not merely a march with the national flag but a collective expression of patriotism and a resolve to contribute to building a ‘Viksit Bharat’.

“The Tiranga Yatra is not merely a march



Delhi CM Rekha Gupta and NDMC Vice Chairperson Kuljeet Singh Chahal during the 'Tiranga Yatra' organized as part of the nationwide 'Har Ghar Tiranga' campaign in New Delhi on Monday

with the national flag in hand, but a journey of resolve towards building a Viksit Bharat,” she said.

Students and teachers of New Delhi Municipal Council (NDMC) schools, parents, employees, representatives

of resident welfare associations and market associations, as well as citizens from different walks of life, participated in the event, the statement read.

The chief minister said the participation of children and

young people reflected the country’s “new energy and strength” and stressed that building a developed India would require citizens’ contribution, along with Government efforts.

She highlighted the role of young people in education, innovation, technology, manufacturing and artificial intelligence, and said India’s development could gain greater momentum when its youth contribute to nation-building.

The chief minister said the ‘Har Ghar Tiranga’ campaign was helping take the message of national unity to citizens and linked it with the vision of ‘Viksit Bharat @2047’. She expressed confidence that the ‘Saptadharma’ envisioned by the Prime Minister will give fresh momentum to India’s development journey, and that

every citizen of the country will become a witness to and a contributor to this historic transformation.

NDMC Vice Chairman Kuljeet Singh Chahal said the march completed one full round of Connaught Place’s Inner Circle before concluding. Singh said the participation of schoolchildren and college students gave special significance to the yatra.

The NDMC said the event also brought together people from different sections of society under the Tricolour, highlighting its shared significance as a symbol of India’s identity, aspirations and unity. The civic body urged citizens to participate in the ‘Har Ghar Tiranga-2026’ campaign and display the national flag as part of the celebrations of freedom and national unity.

AC electric buses to connect 21 heritage and spiritual sites across 4 tourism circuits

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
n New Delhi

Delhi is set to introduce two air-conditioned electric buses for tourism, with the vehicles planned to connect four curated circuits covering 21 heritage, spiritual and cultural sites across the capital, according to documents issued by the Delhi Tourism and Transportation Development Corporation Limited (DTTDC).



The DTTDC has invited bids for supplying two nine-metre air-conditioned electric buses for tourism purposes, according to the tender document.

The estimated cost of the procurement is `2.10 crore and the buses will be added to DTTDC’s existing tourism fleet, which operates guided tours, hop-on-hop-off services, heritage circuits and shuttle services connecting key tourism destinations, it said.

The move is aimed at promoting environmentally responsible tourism mobility and is in line with the Delhi Electric Vehicle Policy 2.0 (2026-2030), under which new intra-state buses inducted by Government transport authorities are required to be electric, according to the document.

The proposed buses will support four curated tourism circuits — ‘The Soul of Delhi’, ‘The Heritage of Delhi’, ‘The Sacred Harmony’ and ‘Echoes of Delhi’ — designed to present the capital’s spiritual, historical, architectural and cultural attractions as connected travel experiences.

The first circuit, ‘The Soul of

Delhi’, covers Gurudwara Bangla Sahib, Sacred Heart Cathedral, Agrasen Ki Baoli, Lotus Temple and Akshardham Temple. The route brings together places associated with different faiths and architectural traditions, stretching from central Delhi to the eastern part of the city, an official said.

The second, ‘The Heritage of Delhi’ includes Birla Temple, Jhandewalan Mata Mandir, Jantar Mantar, Yogmaya Mandir and Jagannath Temple. The circuit links religious and historic locations across Mandir Marg, Connaught Place, Mehrauli and Hauz Khas, offering visitors a mix of heritage and living traditions.

The third circuit, ‘Delhi’s Sacred Harmony’, includes Praacheen Hanuman Mandir, Digambar Jain Lal Mandir, Ambedkar Memorial, Purana Qila and Hazrat Nizamuddin. It connects sites in central, northern and southern parts of Delhi, highlighting the city’s diverse religious and historical landscape, the official said.

The longest circuit, ‘Echoes of Delhi’, has six stops —

Gurudwara Rakab Ganj Sahib, Buddhist Temple, Church of Redemption, Mehrauli Archaeological Park, Chhatarpur Mandir and Linga Bhairavi Sannidhanam. The route brings together religious institutions, archaeological remains and cultural landmarks spread across several parts of Delhi, he added.

The four tourism circuits were unveiled at the Spiritual and Heritage Tourism Conclave-2026 held at Akshardham Temple. The conclave focused on presenting Delhi as a destination centred on spirituality, heritage and experiences, with the circuits offering visitors structured routes across the capital’s cultural landscape.

The proposed tourism bus service is expected to complement existing heritage and sightseeing operations by providing dedicated electric mobility for curated routes. With 21 sites included across the four circuits, the initiative seeks to offer visitors a wider and more connected experience of Delhi, he added.

Hundreds of sanitation workers protest over Kalyanpuri killing, demand compensation

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
n New Delhi

Hundreds of sanitation workers and auto-tipper drivers from across Delhi protested at Lal Bahadur Shastri Hospital on Monday over the killing of a on-duty sanitation worker in Kalyanpuri, and demanded `1 crore compensation and a permanent government job for a member of his family.

The protesters refused to allow the body of MCD sanitation worker, Anil, to be taken from the hospital mortuary for last rites, as they threatened

to keep auto-tippers off the roads across Delhi until their demands are met.

A 52-year-old man who was allegedly heavily drunk and angry over his wife’s daily phone calls with another person was behind Anil’s stabbing in east Delhi, police said on Monday. The accused, Nihal, was arrested from beneath a flyover near the Ghazipur border area, they said.

Delhi Police and paramilitary personnel were deployed at the hospital as sanitation workers raised slogans and demanded immediate action against those responsible for



Sanitation workers stage a protest at the Municipal Corporation of Delhi headquarters following the murder of a sanitation worker in Kalyanpuri in New Delhi on Monday

the killing. “We are demanding `1 crore compensation for the family and a permanent job in MCD for one

member of the family,” said Karan Singh Mahroliya, a member of the Delhi Sanitation Workers Union.

“We will not allow the last rites until our demands are met. Auto-tippers will remain off the roads across Delhi,” he said, adding that operations had already stopped in several areas on Monday as part of the protest.

Several visuals from the site showed hundreds of sanitation workers, auto-tipper drivers and helpers gathered outside the hospital for the protest. Sanitation workers present at the site said the family had not agreed to the compensation being offered by the private company that had engaged Anil.

PUBLIC NOTICE

Be it known to all that my client, Sh. Ramesh Gulia, S/o Sh. J.S. Gulia, R/o House No.661, Sector-17, Gurgaon, Haryana-122001, has disowned and debarred his wife Sunita Gulia from all his movable and immovable properties. He has also severed all relations with her due to her misconduct. Any person dealing with him shall do so entirely at his/her own risk, and my client shall not be responsible in any manner whatsoever. **PRAVEEN RASTOGI** (Advocate)
ENRL No.D-244/06

Public Notice

I, Mohd. Shehzan Ansari (MOHD. SHEHZAN ANSARI), son of Shri Mohammad Juned Ansari (MOHAMMAD JUNED ANSARI), resident of J-161, J-EXTN., Laxmi Nagar, East Delhi-110092, have voluntarily adopted Vedic (Hindu) Dharma and have changed my name from "Mohd. Shehzan Ansari" to "Rudra Pratap Singh Rathore". Henceforth, I shall be known, recognized and addressed by the name "Rudra Pratap Singh Rathore".

THE MAHARAJA BHUPINDER SINGH PUNJAB SPORTS UNIVERSITY, (MBSPSU), PATIALA
Village Sidhuwal, Near Rajiv Gandhi National University of Law, Bhadson Road, Patiala-147001

Advertisement No. 03/2026

1. Online applications are invited for the Direct Recruitment, Superannuated/On Deputation of the Registrar post in, The Maharaja Bhupinder Singh Punjab Sports University, Patiala

2. Online registration of application for these posts will start w.e.f. **16-08-2026** and end on **26-08-2026**.

3. Last date for submitting the hard copy of the online submitted application and supporting documents (4 sets of hard copies of online application form along with self-attested copies of all the certificates by courier or by hand) is **26-08-2026**.

4. For further details visit University Website <https://mbpspu.ac.in/en/jobs>

PATIALA
14.08.2026

-sd-
REGISTRAR

2228/12/2026-27/14320 Dated CHD :- 17/08/2026

PUBLIC NOTICE

General public is hereby informed that my client, Meenakshi Chauchry W/o. Shri Rakesh Kumar Chauchry, D/o. Late Shri Om Prakash Arora, R/o. 8/288, Sunder Vihar, Delhi-110087, have lost the original document mentioned hereinafter in respect of Freehold Property No.76, Situated at Ambica Vihar, Paschim Vihar, New Delhi-110087, a Perpetual Lease Deed executed in favour of Shri Om Parkash Arora son of Shri Tharu Ram, Vide Perpetual Lease Deed registered as Document No.3068, in Additional Book No.1, Volume No.3103, on pages 131 to 143, dated 19/06/1978, with the office of Sub-Registrar, Delhi, which was crucial and important document and the FIR have been registered for the loss of above said document, vide LR No.538972/2026, dated 14/08/2026. Public is hereby cautioned to not to carry any transaction on the basis of aforesaid missing document. Any person(s) claiming any right, interest, having an objection or found in possession of original document is hereby required to communicate the same to the undersigned at my office at Chamber No.4, Old S.D.M. Office, Opposite Nangloi Metro Station, New Delhi-110041, within 7 days from the date of publication of this notice.

KARTIK SRIVASTAVA
Advocate, Delhi High Court
D-2802/2020

SECUR INDUSTRIES LIMITED
Regd Off: Off. No. 707, Seventh Floor, Devika Tower, Chander Nagar, Ghaziabad, Uttar Pradesh, India, 201011,
CIN: U74120UP1989PLC019383
Email: agar.bol.net.in@gmail.com, Website: www.securindustriestld.in,
Contact: 0120-4107504

INFORMATION REGARDING 37TH ANNUAL GENERAL MEETING

Notice is hereby given that the 37th Annual General Meeting ("AGM") of the Members of **Secur Industries Limited** will be held on **Saturday, 19th September, 2026 at 12:00 P.M. (IST)** through **Video Conferencing ("VC")** Other **Audio-Visual Means ("OAVM")**, without the physical presence of members to transact the businesses as set out in the notice convening the AGM of the Company. The venue of the Meeting shall be deemed to be the Registered Office of the Company i.e. Off. No. 707, Seventh Floor, Devika Tower, Chander Nagar, Ghaziabad, Uttar Pradesh, India, 201011.

In accordance with General Circular No. 14/2020 dated 8th April, 2020 and 20/2020 dated 05th May, 2020 and subsequent circulars issued in this regard, the latest being Circular No. 03/2025 dated September 22, 2025 issued by the Ministry of Corporate Affairs ("MCA"), the Notice of the AGM and the Annual Report for the financial year ended 31st March, 2026 will be sent **only through electronic mode** to those Members whose email addresses are registered with the Company, **Beetal Financial & Computer Services Private Limited (RTA)**, or their respective Depository Participants (DPs). The Notice and Annual Report will also be available on the Company's website www.securindustriestld.in, and on the website of **CDSL**.

Shareholders whose email addresses are not registered are requested to update the same with their respective Depository Participants (DPs) to receive the AGM Notice, Annual Report and to participate in e-voting and the virtual AGM.

Secur Industries Limited
Sd/-
Ashutosh Agrawal
Managing Director
DIN: 00421089

Place: Ghaziabad
Date: 17.08.2026

Karnataka Bank Ltd.
Your Family Bank. Across India.

Asset Recovery Management Branch
8-B, First Floor, Rajendra Park,
Pusa Road
New Delhi-110 060

Phone : 011-40591567(Ext-231)
E-Mail : delhiarm@ktk.bank.in
Website : www.karnatakabank.bank.in
CIN : L85110KA1924PLC001128

SALE NOTICE OF IMMOVABLE PROPERTY

E-Auction Sale Notice for Sale of Immovable Assets under the Securitisation and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act 2002 read with provision to rule 9(1) of Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002.

Notice is hereby given to public in general and in particular to Borrower (s) and Guarantor (s) that the below described immovable property mortgaged/charged to the secured Creditor, the **Physical Possession** of which has been taken by the Authorised Officer of Karnataka Bank Ltd, the Secured Creditor on **27.02.2026**, will be sold on “As is Where is”, “As is What is” and “Whatever there is” basis on 08.09.2026, for recovery of **Rs.1,09,63,766.13 [Rupees One Crore Nine Lakhs Sixty Three Thousand Seven Hundred Sixty Six and Paise Thirteen Only]** i.e. (i) **Rs.49,02,360.77 under Overdraft A/c No.544700100088201** along with future interest from 01.05.2023, (ii) **Rs.22,17,054.36 under PS Term Loan A/c No.5447001800041101** along with future interest from 30.04.2023, (iii) **Rs.38,44,351.00 under PS Term Loan A/c No.5447001800041201** along with future interest from 30.04.2023 plus cost, due to the Karnataka Bank Ltd, New Delhi-Savitha Vihar, Plot No. 13, Near Sai Mandir, Main Road, Savitha Vihar, Delhi- 110092, the Secured creditor from (1) **M/s Hymex Jeans, Represented by its Proprietor, Mr. Mujahid Hussain**, addressed at: IX/6888, Malhotra Gali, Near Mahavir Chowk, Gandhi Nagar, Delhi-110053, (2) **Mr. Mujahid Hussain S/o Mr.Zahid Hussain (3) Mr.Zahid Hussain S/o Abdul Karim, (4) Mr. Tahir Hussain S/o Mr. Zahid Hussain**, All No.(2) to No.(4) residing at:B-172, B Block, JJ Colony, Welcome Seelampur, Delhi-110053, being borrowers/guarantors/ co-obligants.

DESCRIPTION OF THE IMMOVABLE PROPERTY:

All that Part & Parcel of commercial property, consisting of 3 storied building, bearing property No.IX/6888, Kharsa No. 108, measuring 21.33 sqyds situated at Kapoor Basti, Abadi known as Gandhi Nagar, Village Seelampur illaga Shahdara, Delhi-110031, belonging to **Mr.Hazi Zahid Hussain & Mr.Tahir Hussain**
Boundaries:East:Other Property West: Gali North: Part of Property South:Part of Property Reserve Price / Upset Price below which the property may not be sold: **Rs. 1,23,00,000.00 (Rupees One Crore Twenty Three Lakh Only)**
Earnest money to be deposited/tendered: **Rs.12,30,000.00 (Rupees Twelve Lakh Thirty Thousand Only)**
(The borrower/s / mortgagor/s attention is invited to the provisions of Sub-section (8) of Section 13 of the Act, in respect of time available to redeem the secured asset).

(This Notice shall also serve as Notice under Sub Rule (1) of Rule (9) of Security Interest Enforcement Rules-2002 to the Borrower/Guarantors)

For detailed terms and conditions of sale, please refer to link in Karnataka Bank's Website i.e., www.karnatakabank.com under the head "Mortgaged Assets For Sale".

The E-auction will be conducted through portal <https://bankauctions.in/> on **08.09.2026 from 11:30 A.M to 12:30 P.M** with unlimited extension of 05 minutes. The intending bidder is required to register their name at <https://bankauctions.in/> and get the user Id and password free of cost and get online training on E-auction (tentatively on 07.09.2026) from M/s.4closure, 605A, 6th Floor,Maitrivanam,Ameerpet,Hyderabad-500038, Contact No.040-23836405, Mobile 8142000030, E-mail: info@bankauctions.in.

Date: 14.08.2026
Place: New Delhi

For Karnataka Bank Ltd
Chief Manager & Authorised Officer

PUBLIC NOTICE

Invitation for Proposal/Bids
Nepal Airlines Corporation
Appointment of Online General Sales Agent (G.S.A.) (Passenger and/or Cargo) in Republic of India

First Date of publication: 18th August, 2026

1. Nepal Airlines Corporation (NAC) invites Request for Proposal/Bids from all eligible Aviation Enterprises/ Entrepreneur for the Appointment of Online General Sales Agent (G.S.A.) (Pasenger and/or Cargo) in Republic of India.

2. Eligible Aviation Enterprises/ Entrepreneur may obtain Proposal/Bid documents from Nepal Airlines Corporation, Kantipath, Kathmandu or may visit Nepal Airlines official Website www.nepalairlines.com.np or may enquire on given email address/ contact number for further information, if required.

Email Address:
dydir_com@nac.com.np,
agencycmd@nac.com.np,
Phone No: +977-01-4220757,
Extn: 2316, 2498 or may visit Nepal Airlines official Website www.nepalairlines.com.np.

3. An Aviation Enterprises/ Entrepreneur must submit the Proposal/Bid along with all the requirement documents on sealed envelope as specified to above mentioned address via hand or courier within 12:00 hrs. of 21st September, 2026 and same will be opened at 14:00 hrs. of the same day.

Note: For more details of the notice, please visit our website www.nepalairlines.com.np (notice section).

इंडियन बैंक

Indian Bank

ALLAHABAD

CBD Belapur Branch : Balaji Bhavan, Sector 11, Near Railway Station, CBD Belapur, Navi Mumbai, Thane-400 614. E-mail : cbdbelapur@indianbank.bank.in Website : www.indianbank.bank.in

(Under Rule – 8(1) of Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002)

POSSESSION NOTICE (For Immovable & Movable Property)

WHEREAS, The undersigned being the Authorized Officer of the Indian Bank under the Securitization and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act 2002 and in exercise of powers conferred under Section 13 (12) read with Rule 8 and 9 of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002 issued a Demand notice dated **06.06.2026**, calling upon the borrowers 1. **M/s. Bridgeview Ships and Ports Private Limited (Borrower)**, 2. **Mr. Vivek Anand (Guarantor)**, 3. **Ms. Neetu Rashmi (Guarantor)**, 4. **Mr. Arvind Kumar Agarwal (Guarantor / Mortgagor)**, 5. **Ms. Seema Agarwal (Guarantor / Mortgagor)** and 6. **M/s. Bridgeview Maritime Pvt. Ltd. (Guarantor)** with our CBD BELAPUR Branch to repay the amount mentioned in the notice being **Rs. 4,34,01,831/- (Rs. Four Crores Thirty Four Lakhs One Thousand Eight Hundred and Thirty One Only)** within 60 days from the date of receipt of the said notice by further interest and incidental charges w. e. f. **06.06.2026**.

The borrower having failed to repay the amount, notice is hereby given to the borrower and the public in general that the undersigned has taken possession of the property described herein below in exercise of powers conferred on him / her under Section 13 (4) of the said Act read with Rule 8 and 9 of the said rules on this day of **14th Day of August of the year 2026**.

The borrower in particular and the public in general is hereby cautioned not to deal with the property and any dealings with the property will be subject to the charge of the Indian Bank for an amount of **Rs. 4,46,75,710/- (Rs. Four Crores Forty Six Lakhs Seventy Five Thousand Seven Hundred and Ten Only)** and interest thereon.

“We draw attention to the provisions of Section 13(8) of the SARFAESI Act and the Rules framed there under which deals with your rights of redemption over the securities”

DESCRIPTION OF THE IMMOVABLE PROPERTY

➤ Property No. 1 : (Owned by 4th and 5th Parties) : Unit No. 105, 1st Flr., Plot No. H-6, Aggarwal Tower, Netaji Subash Palace, Dist. Central Wazirpur, New Delhi, **admeasuring 24.75 Sq. Mtrs.**

➤ Property No. : (Owned by 4th Party) : Flat Bearing No. Sun 0301, Tower Sun 8, 3rd Floor, total super area approximately 129.97 Sq. Mtr., Migsun Twinz, Plot No. GH-018 (1), situated at Sector-ETA-II, Greater Noida, District Gautam Budh Nagar U. P.

Date : 14.08.2026
Place : Gautam Budh Nagar, U. P./ New Delhi

Sd/-
Authorised Officer
(Indian Bank)

NOTICE

Locker Hired by **MR. RAJ KUMAR SHARMA** having address at **124 R K PURAM OPP SUBZI MANDI DELHI ROAD 250002** with **KOTAK MAHINDRA BANK** Situated at **24, CHHIPI TANK, BEGUM BRIDGE MEERUT** remains unoperated for the last 9 years and 6 months, and rent due for the last 4 years and 1 month.

All the 3 letters earlier sent to **MR. RAJ KUMAR SHARMA** calling him, to clear dues and to operate the locker has returned unserved and he is not contactable.

It is hereby informed that despite this notice, if dues not cleared and locker is not operated by **MR. PUNEET GERA** within 90 days from the date of this notice, break open of the said locker will be done on **November 16, 2026** at around **12p.m.**

NOTICE

Locker Hired by **MR. PUNEET GERA** having address at **554 NEW DEV PURI MEERUT** with **KOTAK MAHINDRA BANK** Situated at **24, CHHIPI TANK, BEGUM BRIDGE MEERUT** remains unoperated and rent due for the last 10 years.

All the 3 letters earlier sent to **MR. PUNEET GERA** calling him, to clear dues and to operate the locker has returned unserved and he is not contactable.

It is hereby informed that despite this notice, if dues not cleared and locker is not operated by **MR. PUNEET GERA** within 90 days from the date of this notice, break open of the said locker will be done on **November 16, 2026** at around **12p.m.**

NOTICE

Locker Hired by **MR. VIJAY KUMAR ARORA** having address at **C-40 BLOCK- C HASTINAPUR MAWANA UP 250401** with **KOTAK MAHINDRA BANK** Situated at **24, CHHIPI TANK, BEGUM BRIDGE MEERUT** remains unoperated for the last 10 years and 6 months, and rent due.

All the 3 letters earlier sent to **MR. VIJAY KUMAR ARORA** calling him, to clear dues and to operate the locker has returned unserved and he is not contactable.

It is hereby informed that despite this notice, if dues not cleared and locker is not operated by **MR. VIJAY KUMAR ARORA** within 90 days from the date of this notice, break open of the said locker will be done on **November 16, 2026** at around **12p.m.**

DU suspends PhD scholar for slapping professor, bans entry

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
n New Delhi

Delhi University suspended a Faculty of Law PhD scholar and barred his entry into university premises on Monday. The action was taken after the PhD scholar allegedly slapped a professor at Umang Bhawan, university officials said.

The scholar, identified as Shubham Singh, was admitted to the Faculty of Law in the 2024-25 academic session, Phase-II. According to a notice issued by the university's Office of the Proctor, the action followed CCTV footage received by the university showing the incident, which occurred around 10.30 am at Umang Bhawan.

DU Proctor Manoj Kumar Singh confirmed the scholar could be seen slapping a professor in the footage.

"The incident took place on Monday morning, and the student can be seen slapping a professor. A committee has been formed to look into it," he said.

The notice stated that Singh has been suspended from the Faculty of Law with immediate effect.

It further said his entry into the University of Delhi premises has been banned under Ordinance



XV-B of the Delhi University Act, 1922.

The university has constituted an independent three-member committee to investigate the alleged misconduct and submit a report.

The committee is headed by Rajeev Gupta of the Department of Chemistry, with Vipul Singh of the Department of History and Sudha Singh of the Department of Hindi as members. A separate notice issued by the Proctor's Office on Monday tasked the committee with investigating the matter and submitting its findings.

The incident drew a sharp response from the Delhi University Teachers' Association (DUTA), which wrote to the Vice

Chancellor calling the physical assault on a teacher completely unacceptable. DUTA demanded that the administration ensure the safety, dignity and security of teachers going forward. DUTA president Prof VS Negi condemned the incident in strong terms, describing it as extremely unfortunate and reprehensible. He said the assault on a respected professor at the Faculty of Law had shocked the teaching community and that no compromise on the dignity, respect or safety of teachers would be tolerated.

Negi said DUTA had urged the university administration to take immediate cognisance of the incident, conduct a fair investigation and take strict action

against those found responsible.

The suspension and campus ban took effect immediately after the university reviewed the CCTV footage, with officials indicating that the case would be examined further by the newly formed enquiry committee before any additional action is decided.

The committee's findings are expected to determine the scope of disciplinary measures beyond the immediate suspension already imposed.

The incident has put a spotlight on campus safety concerns at Delhi University, with the teachers' association pressing for stronger protective measures following the assault. University officials have not indicated a timeline for when the enquiry committee is expected to submit its report.

The case marks a rare instance of a research scholar facing immediate suspension and a campus entry ban over an assault on a faculty member, with the university invoking a specific ordinance under the Delhi University Act to enforce the ban with immediate effect, even as the formal enquiry into the incident continues.

National Capital scraps multi-NOC system, rolls out single-window cinema licensing

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
n New Delhi

The Delhi Government has scrapped the multi-NOC system for cinema licences and introduced a single-window, online process with fixed timelines, under which a district-level committee will take the final licensing decision and inspections will be conducted through an integrated mechanism.

The Rekha Gupta Government has notified a new Standard Operating Procedure (SOP) to make the process of issuing, renewing and inspecting cinematograph licences for cinema halls and multiplexes in the capital more transparent, accountable and time-bound.

Under the new Standard Operating Procedure (SOP), cinema halls and multiplexes will no longer need to obtain separate clearances from multiple departments, including police, Fire Department, engineering authorities, Delhi Jal Board and health officials, for obtaining a cinematograph licence. Instead, applicants will submit applications, pay fees, undergo inspections, track decisions and receive licences online through the e-District Delhi portal.

According to Chief Minister Rekha Gupta, the new system was designed to eliminate delays caused by



poor coordination between departments and provide applicants with a clear, accountable and technology driven mechanism. Two dedicated committees have been set up to oversee the process. The Chief Minister said the SOP had originally been finalised in 2015 but was never implemented by the previous Government. Headed by the Deputy Commissioner (Revenue) or District Magistrate, the committee will include senior officers from the police, Fire Department, engineering wings of the municipal corporation and DDA, Delhi Jal Board and the District Medical Officer, among other departments. The new SOP replaces the earlier Delhi Police Standing Orders that previously governed cinema licensing.

Previously, applicants needed separate NOCs from agencies including the police, Fire Department, municipal corporation, Delhi

Jal Board, electricity distribution companies and the Health Department. Under the new SOP, the DLC will make its decision based on a single joint inspection report rather than multiple sequential clearances.

The second body, the District Inspection Committee (DIC), will jointly inspect each cinema hall with officers from concerned departments. The DIC will prepare an integrated, e-signed and geotagged verification report, uploaded directly to the e-District portal, replacing the earlier practice of separate department wise NOCs.

The DIC will be headed by the SDM, with clearly defined responsibilities for each member, while technical and safety-related duties of the police and other departments will continue as before.

The new SOP fixes time limits for every stage. Initial scrutiny of applications must

be completed within seven working days, the DIC must complete its inspection within 45 days, and the DLC must issue a decision within 30 days of receiving the inspection report. If the DLC fails to decide within this period despite the DIC report confirming full compliance with statutory and safety requirements, the licence will be automatically generated on the portal. This provision will not apply where mandatory safety standards have not been met.

Officials said the simplified process does not come at the cost of safety standards. The new system includes annual joint inspections, surprise inspections and two mock drills every year involving the police, Delhi Disaster Management Authority and cinema hall management.

The SOP introduces a portal-based grievance redressal system, with each district assigned a nodal officer and fixed timelines for resolving complaints. Serious or recurring issues can be escalated to the Divisional Commissioner. Under the revised process, police will no longer have authority to issue cinematograph licences.

She said the SOP has been issued as part of the process of complying with the directions of the Supreme Court relating to the Uphaar Cinema tragedy.

DU warns DUSU candidates of nomination cancellation over rule violations

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
n New Delhi

The Delhi University on Monday warned candidates and student organisations contesting the upcoming DUSU elections against campaign-rule violations and raised concerns over the use of luxury vehicles for election-related activities.

According to university directions, the Proctor's Office will provide all contesting candidates with authorised stickers for their vehicles. Vehicles without these stickers will not be permitted to enter the university campus or colleges, the DU Proctor said, adding that only one vehicle per candidate will be allowed for

campaigning. The warning was issued at a meeting held at the university's Proctor's Office with the Chief Returning Officer, DUSU office-bearers, representatives of various student bodies and police officials, including those from the North District and Maurice Nagar police station.

The DUSU elections are scheduled for September 18, with vote counting on September 19. The last date for filing nominations is September 10, and candidates can withdraw them until noon on September 11.

The Proctor said students had failed to comply with regulations laid down by the Delhi High Court and the Lyngdoh Committee,



resulting in disorder on the university campus.

The university also raised concerns over unauthorised parking by candidates along Chhatra Marg and University Road, which it said caused severe traffic congestion on the campus. The directions

reiterated that candidates must not park vehicles on either side of the road in a way that causes traffic congestion or on footpaths, as this inconveniences pedestrians. Vehicles must be parked only in designated and authorised parking areas, it

said. The university further prohibited candidates from using pamphlets or other printed material during the election campaign if that use could damage public property or litter public spaces. It also warned that the candidate's nomination would be cancelled if any student or supporter is found consuming alcohol or using any intoxicating substance in a vehicle or anywhere on the university campus, including parking areas and roadsides.

The Proctor issued a broader warning that the nomination of any candidate found flouting these rules would be cancelled and the candidate would be barred from contesting the

election. The entire election could also be cancelled in serious circumstances, it said.

The university said the elections will follow the DUSU Code of Conduct, the DUSU Constitution and directions issued by courts, including the Supreme Court's Lyngdoh Committee recommendations and subsequent orders from the Delhi High Court and the National Green Tribunal.

DU reiterated that all candidates, student organisations and other stakeholders must follow directions issued by competent authorities and ensure that election-related activities are conducted in a peaceful, orderly and responsible manner.

Govt to redevelop 3 colonies into high-rise buildings for officials under TOD policy

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
n New Delhi

The Delhi Government has announced plans to redevelop three colonies in the city as high-rise buildings to house officials. The residential complexes will come up in Gulabi Bagh, Bahapur, and Kalyanwas areas. Public Works Department (PWD) Minister Parvesh Sahib Singh said the Government will demolish the existing flats and construct multi-storeyed flats in line with the Government's Transit-Oriented Development (TOD) policy.

Gulabi Bagh in North Delhi, Kalyanwas in Mayur Vihar and Bahapur near Defence Colony are likely to be the first colonies taken up under the plan. It will be on the lines of the Centre's General Pool Residential Accommodation (GPRA) and will be self-financed. As part of the policy, high-density corridors will be developed along the rail and metro lines, providing close connectivity along with residential buildings.

"The idea is to provide new, well-equipped living spaces to our officials. The tender for the projects will be floated soon. All of them will be high-rise towers. We plan to recover the redevelopment cost by offering at least 10 per cent of the total flats for commercial

purposes; these flats are currently in poor condition," Singh said. The Government has identified 32 acres of land in Kalyanwas and around 70 acres of land in Gulabi Bagh where Type II, Type III, and Type IV category flats will be developed, he added. "The revenue generated from these projects will also be used to finance the development of the new Delhi Secretariat complex at ITO," Singh said.

The work will begin in Bahapur, where the requirement is immediate. The Bahapur residential complex project, expected to cost around Rs 400 crore, will soon be placed before the Expenditure Finance Committee (EFC) for approval.

"The design for the project is ready. Around 160 Type V and Type VI flats will be developed for officials. In the other two areas of Gulabi Bagh and Kalyanwas, we will invite public sector undertakings (PSU) companies and the central Government to take the flats if required," the PWD minister added.

The redevelopment project will be on the lines of the Centre's General Pool Residential Accommodation (GPRA) and will be self-financed. Besides these locations, seven more sites have been identified for redevelopment under the model to optimise land use.



Govt to add 300 MBBS, 108 PG seats in medical education push

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
n New Delhi

The Delhi Government plans to expand medical education capacity across the city with 300 additional undergraduate seats and 108 postgraduate, DNB and fellowship seats, Health Minister Dr Pankaj Kumar Singh announced. The initiatives are announced as part of a phased plan to strengthen the healthcare workforce.

The expansion follows a three-pronged approach comprising new medical colleges, capacity expansion at existing institutions, and growth in postgraduate and advanced medical programmes, aimed at addressing the shortage of doctors and dental professionals in Government hospitals.

Under the new colleges component, 150 MBBS seats each are proposed at under-construction medical col-

leges attached to Indira Gandhi Hospital in Dwarka and Guru Gobind Singh Hospital, adding 300 new undergraduate seats in total. At existing institutions, MBBS capacity at Dr BSA Medical College and Hospital is proposed to rise from 125 to 200 seats, while the Maulana Azad Institute of Dental Sciences (MAIDS) will increase its BDS intake from 50 to 70 seats.

On the postgraduate side, MAMC's PG seats are proposed to grow from 260 to 295, an addition of 35 seats, while MAIDS will add 20 seats, taking its PG capacity from 22 to 42. A new PG programme with 24 seats is also proposed at BSA Medical College. The road map includes 103 additional PG and DNB seats spread across Delhi's Government medical institutions.

This includes 24 MD/MS seats at Dr BSA Medical



College, 35 MD/MS seats at MAMC, 18 DNB seats at IGMC, 8 DNB seats at Deep Chand Bandhu Hospital, 2 DNB seats at GTB Hospital, 4 MD/MS seats at UCMS and GTB Hospital, 2 DNB seats at Guru Gobind Singh Government Hospital, 4 DNB seats at Sanjay Gandhi

Memorial Hospital, 2 DNB seats at Bhagwan Mahavir Hospital and 4 MD seats at Delhi State Cancer Institute. Together, this accounts for 67 MD/MS seats and 36 DNB seats.

Five fellowship seats are also proposed, three at GTB Hospital and two at Delhi

State Cancer Institute, taking the total proposed addition in advanced medical seats to 108.

Singh said the expansion reflected the Delhi Government's commitment, under Chief Minister Rekha Gupta's leadership, to build a healthcare system backed

by adequate and well-trained human resources. He said expanding medical education was not simply about increasing seat numbers but about creating a sustainable pool of doctors, specialists and super specialists to serve the city.

Singh said the Government was pursuing a planned, phased expansion of medical education capacity while ensuring that infrastructure, faculty strength and patient care requirements grew in tandem with the additional seats.

The Government is also working on expanding super specialty programmes, including DM and MCh courses, along with structured post doctoral fellowship programmes, to widen opportunities for advanced medical training within Delhi's public healthcare institutions, according to the health department.

2 killed in godown fire after suspected e-rickshaw battery blast

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
n New Delhi

Two persons, including a 17-year-old boy, were killed after a suspected blast in an e-rickshaw battery triggered a fire at a godown in west Delhi's Raghurib Nagar early Monday, police said. The deceased have been identified as Mohammad Sufed (17) and his maternal uncle Sahmad (38), both residents of Bhagalpur in Bihar who were living in the building on rent. The duo was killed in the fire that broke out while they were charging e-rickshaw batteries on the premises, according to police.

The Delhi Fire Service (DFS) received a call at 4.42 am about the blaze that broke out on the first floor of the

five-storey building-cum-godown in Raghurib Nagar.

Domestic articles stored on the first floor caught fire following the suspected battery blast, the fire department said. The blaze was brought under control at around 5.30 am, a fire officer said. According to police, a team reached the spot after receiving a PCR call about the fire and shifted Sufed and Sahmad to the Guru Gobind Singh Hospital, where doctors declared them dead.

Sufed lived in the building with his father, Mohammad Naseeb, and Sahmad. All three were e-rickshaw drivers and used to charge their vehicle batteries at the rented accommodation, police said.

The family members of the deceased reached the spot



2 people died after the battery of an e-rickshaw exploded in a godown at Raghurib Nagar in New Delhi on Monday

on being informed about the incident at around 6 am.

They alleged that Sufed and Sahmad shouted for help, but no one came forward to rescue them. Sahmad's brother Mohammad Rehman said the deceased used to sleep in the same area where the fire broke out. "When the fire broke out, Sahmad and Sufed shouted a lot for help. But no one came forward to help them. Both died in the fire," Rehman said.

However, Santosh, an eyewitness, claimed he rushed to the spot after seeing the fire and hearing the cries for help. "One person was badly injured, while the other also sustained critical injuries, but they were alive when I pulled them out. But both died soon.

Delhi BJP seeks probe into fake photo of Nitin Nabin holding flag upside down

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
n New Delhi

The Delhi unit of the BJP has filed a police complaint demanding a thorough investigation into a photograph circulating on social media that allegedly shows party national president Nitin Nabin holding the national flag upside down, calling the image fake.

A delegation of Delhi BJP leaders, acting on instructions from state president Harsh Malhotra, met Special Commissioner of Delhi Police Devesh Srivastava on Monday and submitted a formal complaint.



The delegation sought a detailed probe into the matter and demanded the arrest of those responsible for circulating the image online. Malhotra alleged that the opposition, which he described as defeated and frustrated after losing power

in state after state, was continuously attempting to misuse social media to disturb the atmosphere in the country. He said BJP workers would not allow such attempts to succeed, calling the circulation of the photograph a malicious effort to target the party leadership.

The Delhi BJP chief demanded that police investigate both the creation and the spread of the photograph, and register a case against those found responsible for producing and sharing it.

The complaint comes amid heightened political activity around Independence Day, with the BJP treating the cir-

culcation of the image as a deliberate attempt to embarrass the party's national leadership at a time of heightened public attention on flag-related symbolism and national sentiment.

Party leaders in the delegation urged police to trace the origin of the photograph and identify the individuals or groups behind its circulation on various social media platforms. The complaint specifically calls for action against those who created the image as well as those who shared it further, treating both as complicit in what the party has termed a fake and malicious campaign.

IN FOCUS



Vehicles remain submerged in floodwater as the Chandrabhaga river swells following rain in Rishikesh, Uttarakhand on Monday

PTI

TN CM apologises over Karunanidhi honorific row

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE

n Chennai

Tamil Nadu Chief Minister C Joseph Vijay offered an immediate apology in the Assembly on Monday after a minister referred to former CM M Karunanidhi directly by name omitting the traditional honorifics.

State Forest Minister RV Ranjith Kumar's remarks on the DMK stalwart's name without affixing "Kalaigarn" (scholar) as is the tradition in addressing him in the

Assembly, drew spontaneous protest by the opposition DMK.

The CM intervened to defuse opposition protest over the breach of decorum, conceding that addressing the late leader in such a manner was wrong and offered an explicit apology on his minister's behalf. "I apologise on his behalf," Vijay said in the Assembly.

The trouble began when Ranjith Kumar, during a debate on the demands for grants for the Health and Revenue departments, criticised past cash-for-votes strategies.

Kapil Mishra meets Nigerian minister, discusses agriculture

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE

n New Delhi

Delhi Minister Kapil Mishra held a meeting with Nigeria's Minister of State for Agriculture and Food Security, Dr Aliyu Sabi Abdullahi, at the Delhi Secretariat on Monday. The meeting aims to explore possible cooperation between India and Nigeria in agriculture and food security.

Mishra, who holds the Art, Culture and Languages, and Tourism portfolios in the Delhi government, welcomed the Nigerian minister and his delegation. The meeting focused on agricultural development, farmers' welfare, food security and management of agricultural produce.

The discussion opened with brief introductions from both sides, followed by a presentation from the Delhi Government's Development Department on the current state of the capital's agricultural sector and the various schemes run by the Delhi and Central Governments for farmers' welfare.

The Delhi Agricultural Marketing Board (DAMB) also gave a detailed presentation during the meeting, outlining how the supply and marketing chain for grains, vegetables, fruits and flowers is managed through mandis. The presentation covered how agricultural produce moves through the system to reach markets



and explained the functioning of the mandi network.

Speaking at the meeting, Mishra said there was significant potential for cooperation between India and Nigeria in agriculture and food security. He said sharing Delhi's experience in farmer welfare schemes, agricultural initiatives and mandi management could benefit both countries.

Mishra said technology, better management practices and a strong market system were essential for protecting farmers' interests and strengthening food security. He described the meeting as a meaningful platform for identifying new areas

of cooperation between the two countries in agricultural development and food security.

Abdullahi thanked the Delhi government for organising the meeting and the presentations, calling the information shared useful and informative. He expressed appreciation for Delhi's support in efforts to strengthen agricultural development and food security in Nigeria. Both sides discussed plans to continue exchanging knowledge, experience and expertise in the agricultural sector, along with maintaining dialogue on potential areas of future cooperation between the two Governments.

Yamuna bank to get Sabarmati-style makeover, Delhi minister says

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE

n New Delhi

The Delhi government will develop the Yamuna bank on the lines of Sabarmati Riverfront in Gujarat, Water Minister Parvesh Sahib Singh said on Monday. Singh is on a study visit to Gujarat with offi-

cials from the Delhi Irrigation and Flood Control (I&FC) Department and Delhi Jal Board (DJB).

The minister said that the Delhi government is also working to build a grand Chhath Ghat along the Yamuna in Kalindi Kunj. "We saw that all the issues that

existed in the Sabarmati Riverfront 25-30 years ago are the same issues we face in the Yamuna in Delhi currently. We are also working on the Yamuna riverfront in Delhi just like the Sabarmati Riverfront," Singh said at a press conference.

The minister said the gov-

ernment is planning to build "big, beautiful parks", cycle tracks, and sports grounds along the river. "The Sabarmati model will be studied closely and the best practices adapted to Delhi's needs to create a clean, green and world-class Yamuna Riverfront. Maa Yamuna will

regain her glory. Delhi will get the riverfront it deserves," the minister said on X.

At present, several projects are in work at Yamuna, including a DJB project to reduce the sewage treatment gap, and another to treat the dairy waste entering the river.

The minister said Yamuna and Sabarmati once shared the same problem of dhoibhats, and the Gujarat government solved that issue by shifting the ghats and replacing them with mechanised laundry machines, which is under consideration here as well.

FROM PAGE - 1

graffiti and poster campaigns to lakhs for targeted hits.

Earlier probes by the Delhi Police Special Cell, National Investigation Agency (NIA), and State ATS units had already exposed modules in Delhi-NCR, Punjab, Haryana, Rajasthan, Uttar Pradesh, Assam, and Maharashtra. The network was also tied to prior incidents, including grenade attacks on police stations and residences in Punjab and Haryana.

Sources in the security establishment said multi-agency teams, guided by real-time technical and human intelligence, struck simultaneously at sleeper cells and logistics nodes spanning northern, western, and eastern States. The timing—days before Independence Day—was deliberate. Officials believe the network intended to stage low-intensity but high-visibility attacks to create panic and undermine national celebrations. Recovered materials point to the cross-border supply chain. Digital forensics from seized phones revealed voice notes, chat logs, and instructions for reconnaissance of police stations, military camps, crowded public spaces, and even religious sites. Some operatives had been tasked with filming sensitive installations or pasting TTH propaganda to amplify fear.

Bhatti had boasted on social media of hundreds of associates. Indian agencies responded with sustained pressure—NIA raids in Punjab and Haryana, Rajasthan ATS statewide sweeps, and Delhi Special Cell "Gang Bust" operations—culminating in the August offensive that effectively neutralised the structure.

Investigators continue to map financial trails involving hawala and bank accounts used to launder proceeds from drugs and illegal arms. "This is not merely an operational victory; it is a strategic message that India will not allow any space for ISI-sponsored terror modules on its soil," one senior official said.

AI drug tests flag two more pilots

The airline's decision followed an August 4 incident involving an Airbus A320neo operating from Phuket to Delhi. The aircraft experienced a sudden loss of about 300 feet in altitude while flying over Odisha, leaving several passengers and crew members injured before the aircraft landed safely in Delhi.

The pilot-in-command subsequently tested positive for marijuana in a confirmatory laboratory test. His preliminary screening had initially indicated the possible presence of a psychoactive substance, prompting further testing.

Following the incident, AI expanded drug screening to cover all its pilots, including those employed by Air India Express. Testing is being carried out during training sessions, after flights and at designated locations, including the airline's Gurugram academy and pilots' home bases. The latest preliminary results have emerged amid heightened scrutiny of pilot fitness and aviation safety. The two newly flagged pilots are expected to undergo the prescribed confirmatory testing process.

The Directorate General of Civil Aviation (DGCA) has previously proposed a two-stage testing process for aviation personnel. Under the procedure, personnel who test positive during preliminary screening may be removed from safety-sensitive duties until confirmatory test results are available.

The Aircraft Accident Investigation Bureau is separately investigating the August 4 Phuket-Delhi incident. The probe is examining technical, operational and other factors that may

have contributed to the aircraft's sudden loss of altitude.

SIT told to finish Ram temple probe

It permitted the petitioners seeking a court-monitored investigation by an independent agency or the CBI, and other public-spirited persons to submit suggestions to the office of the Solicitor General of India (SGI) on any aspect that should be probed by the SIT in connection with the allegations of donations theft.

"We also permit the petitioners or any other bona fide public-spirited person to give their suggestions to the office of the Solicitor General with respect to the aspects that may be required to be thoroughly investigated by the SIT.

"The office of the Solicitor General shall forward the suggestions to the SIT. We have no reason to doubt that the same shall be objectively considered," it ordered.

The bench said after examining the report of the SIT, the court may issue certain directions for reforms in the management of donations made by the devotees visiting the Ram temple.

On July 27, the SC took note of the setting up of the four-member SIT headed by IGP Kiran S to probe the alleged embezzlement of donations at the Ram temple. It had asked the Uttar Pradesh Government to also include a forensic auditor in the probe team.

Observing that "remedial actions will have to be taken", the Bench had said that steps will be taken to "ensure transparency".

After allegations of irregularities in the management of donations surfaced at the temple, several petitioners, including RJD MP Sudhakar Singh, moved the SC seeking a probe by the CBI and a forensic audit of the finances of the temple trust.

Meanwhile, the SC refused to entertain a separate plea of the Nirmohi Akhara seeking a direction to the Union Government to reconstitute the Shri Ram Janmabhoomi Teerth Kshetra Trust, which manages the affairs of the Ram temple in Ayodhya, as a "public trust".

The Nirmohi Akhara, an ancient Ramanandi Hindu monastic order devoted to Lord Ram, had played a major role in the Ayodhya Ram Janmabhoomi legal dispute. It was one of the main litigants in the title dispute, claiming rights to manage Ram Lalla and the site. The Akhara recently approached the top court seeking changes to the Shri Ram Janmabhoomi Teerth Kshetra Trust, including greater transparency and public-trust status, and a role for itself in the temple administration.

Delhi top cop's home burgled, thief held

Police registered a case under Sections 305 and 317(2) of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita at the Tughlak Road police station and began investigating immediately. Since the victim is a serving DCP who leads the Cyber Cell, the case was handled with extra urgency from the start.

Investigators checked CCTV footage from the area and used technical surveillance to find the suspect. These leads pointed police to Imran, also known as Sawan, son of Mohammad Sharif Ali Sharif, who lives in Nala Jhuggi, Taimur Nagar, New Delhi. He was caught soon after.

Police said they recovered the stolen Apple iPhone 15 Pro, the OnePlus phone, the diamond ring, and other items from him. Officials also found that the accused had six previous cases of similar burglaries, showing a pattern of targeting homes.

Tiger cub found dead in Bhopal forest, territorial fight suspected

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE

n Bhopal

The carcass of a nearly one-year-old tiger cub found in the Samaradha forest near Bhopal on Sunday was cremated on Monday after a postmortem examination. Preliminary findings indicate that the cub was likely killed by an adult tiger during a territorial fight.

The carcass was found near the forest outpost at Haripura village on the Raisen Road. Forest officials noticed injury marks on the cub's neck, prompting suspicion that it had been involved in a conflict with another tiger.

Wildlife veterinarians Dr Prashant Deshmukh and Dr Amit Odh conducted the postmortem in the presence of Forest Department officials. The examination found all the internal organs of the deceased cub intact.

DFO Lokpriya Bharti said the carcass was cremated after the postmortem in accordance with the prescribed procedure. The preliminary assessment pointed towards a territorial fight with an adult tiger as the likely cause of the cub's death.

Tiger expert Rashid Noor



said such a case of a tiger being killed in an apparent territorial conflict had not previously been reported in Bhopal. He described it as the first such known incident in the city.

According to Noor, the adult tiger involved in the attack may have entered the area from the forests of Raisen. He said illegal tree felling and construction activities in the Raisen forest region could be contributing to the movement of wild animals towards the Bhopal boundary.

The expert said it was possible that the adult tiger entered the area to establish or defend its territory and encountered the cub. A territorial confrontation may then have resulted in the cub's death.

PM Modi congratulates BJP's newly appointed office-bearers

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
n New Delhi

Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Monday congratulated the newly appointed national office-bearers of the BJP, saying the team brings together organisational experience, energy and grassroots connect. His Cabinet colleagues, including Rajnath Singh, Amit Shah, JP Nadda, Nitin Gadkari and Kiren Rijiju, also congratulated the team.

The BJP has announced its new national team under party president Nitin Nabin, appointing 13 vice presidents, including Ram Madhav, Lok Sabha MP D Purandeshwari and former Uttarakhnd chief minister Tirath Singh Rawat. "Congratulations to the newly appointed national office bearers of the BJP and those who have been given various responsibilities in the party. This newly appointed team brings together organisational experience, energy and grassroots connect," Modi said on social media.

The prime minister said he was confident the new team will give their best in strengthening the BJP and focusing on public service. "My best wishes to them," he said.



In a post, Defence Minister Rajnath Singh said the new team would play an important role in further strengthening the organisation while remaining fully committed to public service and the welfare of the poor.

He expressed confidence that the team would work with full focus and dedication towards building a developed India, with renewed energy and enthusiasm.

Home Minister Shah expressed confidence that the team would take the spirit of 'Nation First' to every individual.

"Heartiest congratulations to all the newly appointed national office-bearers of the BJP. I am fully confident that under the leadership of Prime Minister Shri @narendramodiji and National President Shri @NitinNabinji, the new

team will work with full energy to further strengthen and expand the organisation, to take the spirit of 'Nation First' to every individual, and to realise the resolve of 'Developed India,' Shah said on social media.

Nadda, the Union Minister of Health and Family Welfare and Chemicals and Fertilisers, said the team, under the guidance of Modi and Nabin, would take the BJP to new heights.

"I extend my heartiest congratulations to all the newly appointed national office-bearers of the Bharatiya Janata Party. The guidance of the Hon'ble Prime Minister Shri @narendramodiji and the able leadership of the National President Shri @NitinNabinji will take the entire organisation to new heights.

"At the same time, they will play a pivotal role in implementing the Modi Government's policies for national and public welfare on the ground, in line with the vision of 'Developed India-2047,'" he said.

Gadkari, the Minister of Road Transport and Highways, said, "Under the guidance of Prime Minister Narendra Modi and the leadership of National President Nitin Nabin, I am confident that this dynamic team will bring renewed energy, strengthen the organisation at every level and contribute meaningfully to the vision of a Viksit Bharat."

Union Minister for Education, Consumer Affairs, Food and Public Distribution, and New and Renewable Energy Pralhad Joshi said the new team brings renewed strength and momentum to the BJP, with experience, energy and a deep commitment to the organisation.

Shivraj Singh Chouhan, Manohar Lal, Sarbananda Sonowal, Virendra Kumar, Giriraj Singh, Jyotiraditya Scindia, Kiren Rijiju and Annpurna Devi, among other Union ministers, also congratulated the new team and wished them success in strengthening the party.

Protesting farmers stopped at Haryana border

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
n Khanauri

Punjab farmers stayed put at the Khanauri border point on Monday, a day after Haryana Police stopped them from proceeding to Delhi as part of their 228-kilometre "Kisan Bachao Padyatra".

Police had erected multi-layer barricades at the border point on Sunday.

Speaking to reporters here, Jagjit Singh Dallewal, leader of Samyukt Kisan Morcha (Non-Political) which is spearheading the foot march, said only a small gathering of farmers will continue to sit at the Khanauri border point.

"We have put up small tents as protection from the



sultry weather. But having a Pucca Morcha here is not our agenda," he said.

Dallewal said farmers will try to organise a protest march in different parts of the country on August 20. They would burn effigies and ask the Government whether they do not even have the right to peacefully march to the national Capital even on foot.

"The Government has built

a narrative that farmers are blocking the roads, but as everyone can see, we are sitting on the side of a service road, while Haryana authorities have blocked the highway with concrete slabs," Dallewal said.

"They used to say farmers will not be allowed with tractors and other vehicles, but they won't let us go even on foot now. This time, there are less than 300

President assents to Bill renaming Kerala as Keralam

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
n New Delhi

President Droupadi Murmu has given assent to a bill to rename Kerala as Keralam, with the legislation now becoming a law. The Lok Sabha passed the Kerala (Alteration of Name) Bill, 2026, on Tuesday, followed by the Rajya Sabha the next day.

In the Rajya Sabha, Minister of State for Home Affairs Nityanand Rai said the Kerala Assembly passed



a resolution in 2024, urging the Centre to bring a law to change the name of the

State to Keralam.

"The bill provides that the State of Kerala will be known as the State of Keralam, and hence there is a proposal to rename the State of Kerala to Keralam," he said.

The Kerala Government had forwarded a resolution passed by the state assembly regarding the name change to the Centre in June 2024.

Subsequently, President Murmu referred the Bill to the State legislature for its views, following which the Assembly adopted a unani-

mous resolution agreeing with the Bill.

The Kerala (Alteration of Name) Bill provides for the alteration of the state's name and contains necessary amendments to the Constitution and consequential provisions, according to the Bill's statement of objects and reasons.

Amendments will be made in the First Schedule to the Constitution by modifying the name of Kerala as Keralam in accordance with Article 3 of the Constitution.

BJP protests in Jammu & Kashmir



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
n Jammu

Facing the political heat in its strong bastion, the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) leaders, led by their State unit Chief and senior parliamentarians and Leader of the Opposition, on Monday took out a protest march in the walled city of Jammu against the Omar Abdullah-led National Conference Government for betraying the mandate of the people and pushing Jammu & Kashmir into a phase of administrative paralysis.

Several senior party leaders demanded the resignation of Chief Minister Omar Abdullah, alleging large-scale corruption and complete failure of governance.

In Srinagar, the Chief Minister shrugged off the BJP protest, claiming they are in the Opposition. Let them protest. What can I do about it?

Protesters also set ablaze effigies of the NC-Congress Government, while police and paramilitary personnel were deployed in large numbers along the march routes and the Civil Secretariat. Women workers of the BJP Mahila Morcha

also participated in the demonstration.

"Thousands of BJP workers, MPs, legislators and common people are on the roads to express their anger against the NC-led Government. The elections were held after a long gap, and the National Conference came to power after making several promises before the elections. But now, when it is time to actually work, they keep raising the issue of Statehood to mislead the public," the J&K BJP president Sat Paul Sharma said.

He claimed that since the Government has failed to meet the public's expectations, it's using the Statehood issue merely to distract people.

Addressing the gathering, several other senior BJP leaders issued a stern warning to the NC Government to end its politics of excuses and start fulfilling its commitments to the people.

Leader of Opposition (LoP) in the Jammu and Kashmir Assembly, Sunil Sharma said the National Conference Government has become synonymous with broken promises and administrative failure. He said that instead of

solving people's problems, the Government is busy creating political narratives to hide its own incompetence. He said every section of society, including youth, sportspersons, farmers, employees, traders and common citizens, feels betrayed because none of the major commitments made before the elections have been honoured. He warned that if the Government continues to ignore public sentiment, it will face an even stronger democratic movement across Jammu & Kashmir.

Nirmal Singh said the NC Government has disappointed every region and every section of society by failing to provide effective governance.

NC chief spokesperson and MLA Tanvir Sadiq said the BJP had every democratic right to protest but should first fulfil its "long-pending" commitment to restore statehood to Jammu and Kashmir.

"Give us Statehood and then see the results," Sadiq told reporters in Srinagar.

He asked the BJP to explain to the people of Jammu and Kashmir why it had not fulfilled commitments made after the abrogation of Article 370.

Pinarayi Vijayan slams Kerala Gov over summons to police chief

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
n Thiruvananthapuram

Leader of Opposition in the Keralam Assembly Pinarayi Vijayan on Monday termed it "undemocratic" for Governor Rajendra Vishwanath Arlekar to reportedly summon the State police chief without consulting the CM or home minister.

Vijayan was referring to reports that Arlekar had summoned State Police Chief Ravada A Chandrasekhar to the Lok Bhavan in connection with a student protest at Kalady University recently.

In a Facebook post, Vijayan claimed that the governor's move amounted to direct interference in the administration of the state without respecting the elected Government.

He termed the UDF Government's silence in the face of such "overbearing tendencies and constitutional violations" as "extremely shameful".

He claimed it was a blatant

violation of constitutional principles and a public challenge to the democratic system, while accusing the UDF Government of being afraid to speak out against it.

He contended that there was no justification for such "wrong" moves by the governor and accused him of trying to establish a parallel administration by turning the Government into a mere spectator.

"The governor must act according to the aid and advice of the Cabinet," the Marxist veteran said in his post.

The former CM said the Supreme Court had made it clear that Article 163 of the Constitution did not grant the governor unlimited powers and that he did not have the authority to take unilateral decisions.

The governor can act only after consulting the CM or the concerned departmental minister, but in the case of the Kalady University incident, no such consultation



took place, he contended.

Vijayan contended that it was wrong for the governor to directly deal with the State police chief and alleged that it would lead to the state's police administration being "pawned off" to the RSS.

He questioned whether Chandrasekhar had met Arlekar with the permission of State Home Minister

Ramesh Chennithala.

Vijayan said that as students and the general public strongly opposed the interference of governors in higher education and universities, the conciliatory stance of the Government was allowing the governor to interfere in other departments as well.

"The governor sees the

Government's silence as tacit compliance. He is effectively challenging the constitutional federal powers of the Government," he contended.

He contended that such an accommodation between the State Government and the governor would have far-reaching consequences.

Vijayan said the UDF Government was also silent when the Governor had called senior bureaucrats to the Lok Bhavan in connection with the Yoga Day celebrations.

He claimed that during the LDF Government's tenure, strong constitutional defences had been raised against similar "encroachments" from the Lok Bhavan.

He said that, as the then CM, he had written a letter to the Lok Bhavan on the issue and warned the officials.

"The surrender by the current elected UDF Government, by pledging its sovereignty and rights, is an insult to the voters," Vijayan contended in his post.

Deposit return systems move beyond pilots as states test new models

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
n New Delhi

India's efforts to improve packaging waste recovery are moving beyond policy, with Goa, Tamil Nadu, Uttarakhand and Himachal Pradesh testing different versions of Deposit Return Systems (DRS).

The principle is straightforward. Consumers pay a refundable deposit when buying a product and receive it back when they return the empty container. The four states are testing the model across very different settings, from a tourism-driven economy to retail outlets and high-footfall pilgrimage routes.

Goa is preparing a technology-enabled DRS for beverage containers, scheduled to launch on April 1, 2027. The system is being

designed for use across the state, where tourism generates large volumes of beverage containers through hotels, restaurants and retail outlets.

The scheme has a dedicated institutional framework through the Goa DRS Authority, created under the Goa Non-Biodegradable Garbage (Control) (Amendment) Act 2026.

Tamil Nadu is testing DRS at the collection point. Following directions from the Madras High Court to address pollution from discarded liquor bottles, TASMACH has introduced an automated bottle collection unit at its Egmore outlet in Chennai.

Customers scan and deposit the bottle and then scan a QR code to receive the refund through a UPI-linked account. The unit can hold up to 3,000 bottles, sort them by size and

alert collection agents through SMS and WhatsApp when it approaches capacity.

Similar units are expected to be introduced across the state in phases, depending on the outcome of the trial.

Uttarakhand has operated a Digital Deposit Refund System along the Char Dham Yatra route since 2022. It began in Kedarnath and was later expanded to Gangotri and Yamunotri.

Pilgrims pay a deposit on plastic bottles and multi-layer packaging, tagged with QR codes, and receive the money back through UPI after returning the material at collection points or reverse vending machines.

The three Dhams have recovered about 58,175 kg of plastic waste over four years, with Kedarnath accounting for nearly 85 per cent of the recovered



material, according to the figures cited in the source material.

Himachal Pradesh's cabinet approved a Deposit Refund Scheme in 2025 covering glass bottles, plastic containers, cans, liquid cartons and multi-layer packaging. It is to be introduced on a pilot basis before being scaled statewide.

A deposit return system has also been introduced along the Manimahesh Yatra route in Chamba district. The initiative is being run by the district administration with technology and NGO partners. The route was declared a plastic-controlled zone during the yatra, with the initiative reporting a 99 per cent recovery rate through digital traceability.

The four initiatives are testing DRS under very different conditions. Goa is preparing a

statewide system, Tamil Nadu is experimenting with automated collection at a retail outlet, while Uttarakhand and Himachal Pradesh are using pilgrimage routes.

The common element is the refundable deposit, which gives consumers a direct financial incentive to return packaging.

For India's Extended Producer Responsibility framework, these experiments focus on a practical challenge: getting packaging back after it has been sold and used.

The next test will be whether the systems can maintain recovery rates, preserve material quality and remain viable as they expand. The experience of these four States could help determine how widely deposit return systems are adopted across India's circular economy.

States Focus



CID RAIDS JHARKHAND STAFF SELECTION COMMISSION OFFICE

The Criminal Investigation Department (CID) on Monday began conducting raids at the Jharkhand Staff Selection Commission office in connection with its probe into alleged irregularities in recruitment exams, an officer said. Job aspirants have been protesting for 24 days now against the alleged anomalies in various recruitment tests in Jharkhand. "We are conducting raids at the JSSC office in connection with alleged irregularities in various examinations," CID ADG Manoj Kaushik said. The protesting students have been demanding cancellation of the JSSC-CGL exam conducted in September 2024, claiming that "out of 135 questions, 120 were leaked". (PTI)



BENGAL CM LAYS STONE FOR `4,000-CRORE STEEL PROJECT

West Bengal Chief Minister Suvenudh Adhikari on Monday laid the foundation stone for Amit Metaliks Ltd's `4,000 crore greenfield integrated steel manufacturing project at Raghunathpur in Purulia district. The project, which is expected to generate over 5,000 jobs, will expand the company's manufacturing capabilities and feature integrated steelmaking operations supported by advanced manufacturing technologies and sustainable infrastructure. The proposed facility is expected to create significant employment opportunities in the region, the company said. Amit Metaliks is the flagship company of Amit Alliance, a group with about `2,000 crore in revenue and interests spanning steel, mining and infrastructure sectors. (PTI)

9 killed in hotel blaze in West Bengal's Tarapith

SAUGAR SENGUPTA
n Kolkata

At least 9 people were charred to death, and some others sustained burn injuries when a massive fire broke out in a four-storey hotel at Tara Peeth, a famous pilgrim centre dedicated to Goddess Tara (another form of Mother Kali), in Birbhum district, police said.

The victims, mostly pilgrims, choked to death before they were literally singed helplessly as they could not come out of the hotel as the doors were locked, police said, adding the fire might have broken out from a short circuit. The incident occurred in the small hours of Monday.

Out of the nine dead, five are from Meghalaya and



Rescue personnel carry out operations after a fire broke out at a private hotel in Tarapith, West Bengal on Monday PTI

Union minister Rijiju slams Congress over Chidambaram's *dimagi* Naxal remark

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
n New Delhi

Union minister Kiren Rijiju on Monday fired a fresh salvo at the Congress over its MP P Chidambaram's swipe at Prime Minister Narendra Modi for his "*Dimagi* Naxal" remark, saying the party must apologise to the family of ex-Prime Minister Manmohan Singh, who had said the Maoist problem was the single biggest internal security challenge ever faced by India.

On Sunday, Rijiju had reacted to Chidambaram's "I am proud to be a *Dimagi* Naxal" comment, which followed after Modi, in his Independence Day speech, said "we have succeeded in getting rid of armed Naxals, but 'Dimagi Naxals' (intellectual Naxals) are looking for opportunities to create violence, unrest..."

Speaking from the ramparts of the Red Fort, Modi said the country had succeeded in removing armed Naxalism from the forests but warned that its ideological supporters were seeking opportunities to promote violence and anarchy.



Chidambaram had also said that the term '*Dimagi* Naxals' was the new variant of the old BJP accusations of "Urban Naxals", "*Andolanjeevi*" and "*Tukde Tukde* gang".

"Who were the Urban Naxals? Who were the *Andolanjeevis*? Who were the '*Tukde Tukde*' gang? The old abuses were directed against the members of the Opposition. *Dimagi* Naxals is a new variant of those abuses," Chidambaram said. Rijiju on Monday said that Manmohan Singh had highlighted the

Naxal problem as the prime minister in 2006. "It would not be an exaggeration to say that the problem of Naxalism is the single biggest internal security challenge ever faced by our country," Singh had said on April 13, 2006," Rijiju said.

"The Congress must apologise and say sorry to the family of Dr Manmohan Singh ji," the Parliamentary Affairs Minister said in a post on social media.

On Sunday, Rijiju said that by '*Dimagi* Naxals', Prime Minister Modi did not refer to the opposition leaders but only to those who support Maoists and separatists and reject the Indian Constitution.

"Very unfortunate and highly damaging statement by the respected former Home Minister of India. PM Narendra Modi ji didn't say that opposition leaders are 'Dimagi Naxals'.

"Only the following are 'Dimagi Naxals': 1. Who support Maoists and reject the Indian Constitution; 2. Who stand with separatists and support Article 370; 3. Who want to cut the chicken neck to separate North-East from India," Rijiju had said in a social media post.

Sukhu urges Centre to approve industrial parks, Rail links

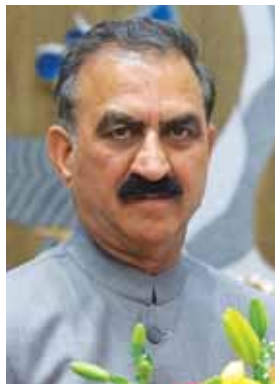
PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
n Shimla

Himachal Pradesh Chief Minister Sukhvinder Singh Sukhu on Monday urged the Centre to accord early approval to industrial parks and to strengthen railway connectivity in the State.

He was participating in the third meeting of the Apex Monitoring Authority of the National Industrial Corridor Development and Implementation Trust organised in New Delhi via virtual mode from Shimla.

The meeting was chaired by Union Minister for Finance and Corporate Affairs, Nirmala Sitharaman.

During the meeting, Sukhu apprised the state government's efforts to develop world-class industrial infrastructure to accelerate industrial development and attract large-scale



investment in Himachal Pradesh.

He said that under the first phase of the Bharat Audyogik Vikas Yojna (BHAVYA), the State Government had already submitted two proposals to the National Industrial Corridor Development and Implementation Trust for developing investment-ready industrial parks.

MP gets 8 leaders in BJP's new national team

GIRISH SHARMA
n Bhopal

Madhya Pradesh has secured a strong representation in the BJP's new national organisational team, with eight leaders from the State being assigned important responsibilities across the party's national structure. The appointments cover key areas including organisation, social outreach, farmers' affairs and media, underlining the importance being given to the State in the BJP's national setup.

Lal Singh Arya has been appointed national vice-president of the BJP. A senior Dalit leader, Arya has previously served as an MLA from Gohad and as a minister in the Madhya Pradesh Government. He has also served as national president of the BJP Scheduled Caste Morcha.

Khargone MP Gajendra Singh Patel has been appointed national general secretary. Patel, 51, is serving his second consecutive term as a Lok Sabha member. He has held several organisational positions, including responsibilities in the BJP Scheduled



Lal Singh Arya, Gajendra Singh Patel



July 2025 and is currently serving his second term as Lok Sabha member from Khajuraho. He has also had a long association with the Akhil Bharatiya Vidyarthi Parishad and BJP organisation.

Soudan Singh has been appointed national co-organising general secretary, with Chandigarh as his headquarters. He was earlier serving as a national vice-president of the party. Another senior organisational leader, Shiv Prakash, will continue in the same position with Mumbai as his headquarters.

Rajya Sabha member Tarun

Chugh has been appointed national office in-charge. He was earlier serving as a national general secretary and will now oversee responsibilities related to the BJP's central office.

Rajya Sabha MP Bansilal Gurjar has been appointed national president of the BJP Kisan Morcha. Gurjar has held several organisational positions and previously served as president of the Madhya Pradesh BJP Kisan Morcha. He became a Rajya Sabha member from Madhya Pradesh in 2024.

Ashish Usha Agarwal has been appointed national co-convenor of the BJP's media team. He has been active in the Madhya Pradesh BJP's media organisation and has handled party communication-related responsibilities at the State level.

Of the eight leaders from Madhya Pradesh, four are serving MPs. Their appointments give the State representation in several influential segments of the BJP's national organisation, including senior leadership, organisational affairs, the Kisan Morcha, media and social outreach.

Jarange demands Kunbi certificates for 58 lakh Marathas

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
n Chhatrapati Sambhajnagar

Quota activist Manoj Jarange on Monday alleged that the Maharashtra Government wants to slash the number of Kunbi caste certificates for eligible members of the Maratha community and demanded that certificates be issued as per the data of 58 lakh records.

He appealed to the Maratha community to become aggressive in pursuing its demands and raise its voice against injustice. "They should not come under pressure from any political party or individual," he said.

Reiterating his call for a protest, Jarange said he would embark on a tour of Marathwada and parts of the Vidarbha region from August 20 to 25. He had announced an indefinite fast from August 29, seeking OBC quota for eligible members of the Maratha community.

"The agitation will take place for pending demands of the Maratha community. The Government should issue all the certificates based on the 58 lakh records found earlier. The



Government wants to curtail this figure of 58 lakh, but I will not let it happen," he told reporters in Chhatrapati Sambhajnagar.

He demanded that the (Kunbi) caste certificates issued so far should be validated.

His other demands include a GR of Satara, Kolhapur, Aundh and Bombay gazettes, revocation of cases against Maratha protesters, and wrapping up the process to grant Government appointments for candidates selected under SEBC and EWS quotas before August 29.

"The Government should release pending dues and complete the process to appoint kin of those who sacrificed their lives for the

Maratha quota. Reimbursements through Annasaheb Patil Mahamandal and student scholarships should be settled by August 29," Jarange added.

Chhatrapati Shahu Maharaj Research, Training and Human Development Institute (SARTH) is an autonomous institute of the State Government.

Jarange demanded that the schemes halted through SARTH be restarted and that adequate funds be released for them.

"We have presented all these demands to the Government in writing. No demand should remain pending by August 29," he said.

He also demanded that

the Government issue caste certificates based on the 58 lakh records identified earlier.

Jarange also spoke about a meeting held on Sunday at Antarwali Sarati village in Jalna, where he interacted with scholars from the Maratha community.

"I had called scholars from the Maratha community and those working on reservation to discuss the changes the community wants in the Government orders. However, I came across a few people who, despite being Marathas, were speaking against the community. They appear to be more loyal to their political parties than to the Maratha community," he claimed.

He also took a dig at political leaders from the ruling parties, accusing them of provoking members of the Maratha community.

"Ministers Sanjay Shirsat and Chandrashekhar Bawankule, and MP Sandipan Bhume have decided to damage the Maratha community. They are encouraging people to approach the courts," Jarange alleged.

Narco-terror accused held in J&K

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
n Jammu

The State Investigation Agency (SIA) has achieved a significant breakthrough in its sustained efforts to dismantle the active narco-terror ecosystem in Jammu and Kashmir with the arrest of an absconding operative who had been evading arrest for nearly four years.

The arrest is an important development in the investigation of a wider narco-terror conspiracy allegedly backed by Pakistan/PoK-based operatives of the terrorist organisation Hizbul Mujahideen (HM).

According to the SIA spokesman, the operative has been identified as Pankaj Kumar Bhat @ Pintu, S/o P.K. Bhat, R/o Rehari Colony, Bakshi Nagar, Jammu.

The accused was wanted in connection with FIR No. 13/2022 of SIA Kashmir, regis-



tered on June 3, 2022, concerning the smuggling of narcotics from across the LOC and the alleged channelisation of proceeds from their sale towards financing terrorist activities.

The SIA spokesman said that Manoj Kumar Bhat alias Pintu has been evading arrest for almost 4 years since the case was registered.

The arrested accused is alleged to have played a role in facilitating the sale and distribution network of narcotics in the Jammu division, thereby contributing to the

financial pipeline of the larger narco-terror network.

The investigation has also established linkages with Pakistan/PoK-based terrorist handlers, including Imtiyaz Ahmad Kandoo @ Kandoo, S/o Ab. Khaliq Kandoo, R/o Kraiteng, Sopore, and Manzoor Ahmad Khan, S/o Late Ab. Majeed Khan, R/o Braman Panzala, Baramulla.

These individuals have arranged and facilitated the trafficking of narcotics from PoK, which were subsequently collected, distributed and sold through the network operating within J&K.

By targeting the entire chain- from cross-LoC narcotics trafficking and local distribution to the financial proceeds generated there — SIA Kashmir is pursuing the broader objective of financially strangling and dismantling the support structures that sustain terrorism.

Karnataka Assembly stalled over demand to sack minister Nagendra

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
n Bengaluru

The Karnataka Legislative Assembly proceedings witnessed disruption on Monday, with the Opposition staging a protest demanding the removal of Minister B Nagendra, who is facing charges in connection with the alleged embezzlement of crores of rupees at a State-run corporation, from the Cabinet.

As soon as the Speaker G S Patil called for question hour, the Opposition BJP and JD(S) raised the issue.

Leader of Opposition R Ashoka and BJP MLA Sunil Kumar raised the issue and questioned how they can participate in question hour with a "corrupt



Karnataka minister B Nagendra

minister" here.

Demanding that Nagendra should be removed, Ashoka declared that, "We will not let the house function until he is dropped. The CM should remove him from the Cabinet immediately."

The BJP has already announced that it would not allow the proceedings of the Monsoon Session if he is not sacked.

Nagendra is now the Minister for Planning and Statistics.

Nagendra, who resigned from the previous Siddaramaiah-led Cabinet following the allegations of embezzlement of taxpayer money at the Karnataka Maharshi Valmiki ST Development Corporation, was inducted into the D K Shivakumar-led Ministry on August 3.

"When Siddaramaiah was CM, he had taken Nagendra's resignation; why has he been taken into the Cabinet now?" Ashoka asked.

ED arrested Nagendra in the Valmiki Corporation scam case in July 2024, and a Special Court in Bengaluru in October that year, granted bail to the MLA from Ballari.

Did PLA block Indian Army patrols, Owaisi asks Govt

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
n Hyderabad

AIMIM president Asaduddin Owaisi on Monday posed several questions to the NDA Government over the "situation" on the China border in Arunachal Pradesh, including the PLA.

He asked whether the People's Liberation Army (PLA) blocked army patrols from accessing the area where they have been patrolling so far.

In a post on 'X', he asked whether the PLA destroyed a temporary structure created by our army patrol in an area in India's territory.

"Has the PLA pitched tents in the area where our patrols were going earlier and is clearly Indian territory?" he asked.

He further asked whether



the Government is pushing the army not to press too strongly for patrolling rights in the area where China is creating trouble because it is keen to portray normalcy to facilitate Chinese President Xi Jinping's visit to Delhi next month.

He asked whether the Modi Government decided to keep the people of the country in the dark about what happens with China on the border, "as it tried in Doklam in 2017 and in Ladakh in 2020".

Sonia, Rahul spreading anarchy, Chidambaram pure naxal: Himanta

TONY DAS n Guwahati

Assam Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma on Monday accused Congress leaders Sonia and Rahul Gandhi of openly “engaging in anti-national” activities and trying to “spread anarchy” in the country in an attempt to return to power.

Sarma also took a swipe at former Union Home Minister P Chidambaram over his ‘dimagi Naxal’ remark, claiming that the senior opposition leader is a “pure Naxal” and an enquiry should be done to find out if he knowingly didn’t take steps against Maoists when he was in the Union Cabinet.

“Sonia Gandhi and Rahul Gandhi are nearly on a mission to oppose the nation. Whether it is by instigating protests in the name of Gen Z, they have vowed to spoil the atmosphere of the country,” Sarma said at a press conference.

Asked about the two



Assam CM Himanta Biswa Sarma addressing the media PIONEER PHOTO

Congress leaders purportedly opposing full rendition of ‘Vande Mataram’ during Independence Day celebration, the CM said, “Sonia Gandhi’s behaviour shows that if the Congress returns to power by some mistake, what will the condition of the country be?”

“They are openly engaging in anti-national activities and provoking people to agitate, sit on dharna, all for the sake of anarchy.

The ‘Ma-Beta’ (mother-son) attempt to stop the ‘Vande Mataram’ manifests what will be the country’s future if the Congress comes to power,”

the BJP leader asserted.

On Chidambaram calling himself a “dimagi naxal” after PM Narendra Modi used the term during his Independence Day speech, Sarma mentioned that it was during his tenure as Union Home minister that senior Congress leader VC Shukla and others were killed in an attack in Chhattisgarh, and “still Congress did nothing to eradicate Naxalism”.

“With Chidambaram calling himself ‘dimagi naxal’, there should be an enquiry whether he knowingly didn’t take steps against Naxals when he was the Home minister,” Sarma said. “I think Chidambaram is not just a ‘dimagi naxal’, he is a ‘pure naxal’ who wants anarchy in the country,” he claimed.

Sarma maintained that it is under PM Narendra Modi and Union Home Minister Amit Shah that a “naxal-mukt” India has been possible and there is all-round peace, including smooth national day celebrations in Assam.

BJP spokesperson Shehzad Poonawalla quits party

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
n New Delhi

BJP national spokesperson Shehzad Poonawalla on Monday said he has resigned from all positions and primary membership of the party. Poonawalla stated that he has submitted his resignation letter to BJP national president Nitin Nabin, requesting that he accept it.

He also posted his resignation letter on social media, which stated that he had written to Nabin, offering “to resign unconditionally” from all positions and primary membership of the BJP on July 30 due to “pressing financial and personal circumstances.”

In his letter to Nabin, Poonawalla expressed how moved he was by the party’s reluctance to accept his resignation promptly, as they requested him to reconsider his decision.

“But after long and hard contemplation, I have arrived at a final decision that I would like to press for relieving me from my role as National Spokesperson and active primary membership of the BJP. The events of the last few days, courtesy of certain individuals about whom I have told you in great detail, have forced me to reinforce and stand by my earlier decision”, he added.

On July 31, Poonawalla updated his bio on social media, omitting any



mention of the BJP, which sparked speculation about his potential departure from the party. But there was no official confirmation from the party at that time.

In his latest resignation letter submitted to the BJP chief on Monday, Poonawalla said, “As stated earlier, due to pressing emergency financial and personal circumstances, I will move into the private sector, but wherever possible and in whatever format possible, I will continue to support the vision and work of Prime Minister Modi and the BJP. “As I said, I am only leaving the Vyavastha, not

the Vyakti or Vichar,” he added.

In a post, Poonawalla also expressed gratitude towards Prime Minister Narendra Modi, Home Minister Amit Shah, Defence Minister Rajnath Singh, Union Minister Nitin Gadkari, the BJP president and all senior leaders of the party and the “Sangh Parivaar” for their “guidance, love, respect”.

“In no other country and no other party would a story like mine, of a young, Pasmanda Muslim, non-dynast, even be possible,” he said.

Poonawalla joined the BJP in December 2017 after quitting the Congress.

TN CM announces full waiver of cooperative farm loans upto `75,000

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
n Chennai

Tamil Nadu Chief Minister C Joseph Vijay on Monday announced full waiver of cooperative farm loans up to `75,000. Also, he announced a waiver up to `75,000 for loans ranging up to `one lakh. The waiver beyond `1 lakh will be `35,000.

The latest waiver will entail an additional expenditure of `953 crore to the exchequer, CM Vijay said.

Emphasising that agriculture is the backbone of the State and that the prosperity of the nation depended on supporting farmers, he said that despite the State facing financial constraints, his Government decided to extend the additional support worth over `900 crore to farmers. Making an announcement under Rule 110 in the Assembly, Vijay said the Government previously waived agricultural loans up to `50,000 within 15 days of taking office in May.



This was later expanded to provide full waivers for loans up to `75,000, and a `35,000 waiver for loans exceeding `75,000, benefiting over 14.44 lakh farmers.

Following consultations with agricultural unions on August 7, 2026, the Government decided to provide additional relief despite current financial constraints and Reserve Bank of India guidelines that required rapid settlements with cooperative banks, the chief min-

ister said, announcing additional benefits.

As per his announcement, cooperative farm loans up to `75,000 will now be provided with a 100 per cent waiver.

“This initiative will provide additional support to over 1.38 lakh farmers, representing an additional financial commitment of approximately `953.06 crore by the Government, with a total waiver amount reaching `6,220 crore for 13.34 lakh farmers,” the CM said.

ABVP slams NTA over UGC-NET errors, demands action

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE n New Delhi

The ABVP on Monday said the National Testing Agency (NTA) must be accountable for serious factual, typographical, translation and language-related errors in the UGC-NET question papers, asserting that students’ future cannot be compromised. In a statement, the Akhil Bharatiya Vidyarthi Parishad (ABVP) expressed serious concerns over the re-examination of the English, Commerce and Sociology papers of UGC-NET 2026.

The student wing of the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS) said such serious errors in a national-level examination raise questions over the quality and credibility of the entire process, and asked the NTA to explain how the errors occurred and why those were not detected during the preparation of the question paper and the review process.

“Serious errors in a national-level examination like UGC-NET are deeply concerning. Students should not have to pay the price for NTA’s lapses. Playing with the future of students must stop,” ABVP national general secretary Virendra Singh Solanki was quoted as saying in the statement. “NTA must ensure proper examination-centre allocation and



Members of the Krantikari Yuva Sangathan raise slogans and hold placards from inside a bus after being detained during a protest outside Shastri Bhawan in New Delhi PTI

adequate travel arrangements for students appearing in the re-examination, so that they do not face additional financial or mental stress,” he added.

Solanki said the agency must also ensure that such lapses are not repeated and fix clear accountability for every stage of the examination process. The ABVP firmly cautions that if students’ concerns are not addressed within a stipulated time and necessary reforms are not implemented, it will strongly raise these issues with students across the

country, he said. Solanki asserted that the ABVP is committed to the students’ demands and will continue its efforts until a credible, transparent and reliable examination system is ensured.

The ABVP said students are being made to bear the cost of repeated examinations in terms of their time, money and academic plans. It further said merely conducting a re-examination cannot be the solution and the NTA must strengthen question-paper preparation, expert review, translation, proofreading and final quality checks, while fixing clear accountability for lapses.

The organisation said it is gathering suggestions from students, academicians and other stakeholders for examination reforms.

“Meetings have already been held in Chandigarh, Delhi and Patna, and the suggestions will be placed before the high-level committee constituted for examination reforms. ABVP stands firmly with students and will continue to raise their concerns until they are resolved,” it said.

The NTA on Sunday announced a retest for three papers — English, Commerce and Sociology — of the UGC-NET examination that was held in June, following complaints of several errors in these papers.

CPI(M) DEMANDS SCRAPPING OF NTA, NEP 2020

New Delhi: The Polit Bureau of the Communist Party of India (Marxist) on Monday reiterated its demand to scrap both the National Testing Agency (NTA) and the National Education Policy (NEP), 2020, terming them the “root cause of the decay in the education system.”

The left party’s demand comes in the wake of errors discovered in three UGC-NET examination papers recently conducted by the NTA. In a statement issued from its central committee office, the CPI(M) said the “disgraceful episode” has once again exposed the entrenched rot in the country’s education system and laid bare the NTA’s “abject incompetence” to conduct national-level examinations.

Deplored the response of the ruling establishment, the CPI(M) alleged that instead of remedying the disastrous consequences of the NEP, the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) and its affiliates are targeting those who question the system. Highlighting a recent incident in West Bengal, the party pointed to the murder of Janab Mafik in Bankura district — who was allegedly killed for drawing attention to the lack of infrastructure in a local school — calling it the “epitome of their intolerance.” (PNS)

Defence ministry inks `1,943 cr drone lease



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
n New Delhi

Ministry of Defence on Monday signed a contract with US defence major General Atomics Aeronautical Systems to lease two MQ-9B Sea Guardian high-altitude long-endurance unmanned aircraft for the Indian Navy. The deal is worth `1,943 crore. The Navy already operates two Sea Guardian drones, which were leased a few years ago.

The ministry said it signed a contract with General Atomics Aeronautical Systems for the remotely piloted aircraft for a period of

30 months.

The MQ-9B Sea Guardian remotely-piloted aircraft are equipped with advanced systems, state-of-the-art sensors and sophisticated payloads. They will significantly enhance the Indian Navy’s maritime domain awareness capabilities, the ministry said in a statement.

The systems will provide persistent intelligence, surveillance and reconnaissance coverage over vast areas of the maritime domain, strengthening India’s ability to monitor and respond to developments across the Indian Ocean Region.

TG-SAFE launch to ensure food, drug safety in Telangana: CM

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE n Hyderabad

Telangana Chief Minister A Revanth Reddy on Monday said the creation of TG-SAFE reflects the State Government’s commitment to ensure safety, security and overall well-being of citizens in every aspect of life.

“Today, as Telangana Standards Authority for Food and Essential Drugs (TG-Safe) comes into force, with a single department to ensure safety and standards in our food & medicines, I hope all citizens join me in welcoming and taking its services for a safe Telangana,” he said in a post on X.

According to a Government Order (GO) issued recently, the Food Safety Department and the Drugs Control Department share common objectives relating to public health, consumer safety, quality assurance and effective regulatory enforcement.

A unified administrative framework is required to improve surveillance, intelligence, enforcement, legal support and regulatory outcomes, it said.

Therefore, the Government has decided to establish a unified administrative structure for the Food Safety Department and the Drugs Control Department. The order further said the Food Safety Department



and the Drugs Control Department would be merged under a unified administration known as the TG SAFE.

The unified administration shall preserve the statutory provisions under the Food Safety and Standards Act, 2006 and the Drugs and Cosmetics Act, 1940. The Commissioner, TG SAFE, shall function as unified administrative control for the Food Safety and Drug Control Departments, it said. Senior IPS officer Avinash Mohanty, who was earlier posted as Director General, Drugs Control Administration, has been posted as Commissioner, Telangana SAFE, in addition to his normal duties, an official release said on August 16.

Andhra CM defends Mega DSC-2025 teacher recruitment

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
n Amaravati



Andhra Pradesh Chief Minister N Chandrababu Naidu on Monday defended the Mega DSC-2025 teacher recruitment drive, asserting that the selection process was conducted with transparency.

Addressing the Assembly, the Chief Minister said every candidate’s selection is traceable and accountable.

“Everything was transparent... every candidate selection is traceable and accountable,” he said, adding that there was zero compromise while conducting the

examination. Naidu said the teacher’s recruitment through ‘Mega DSC’ fulfilled one of the core poll promises. He said 3.3 lakh aspirants had applied for the

DSC examination, which offered 15,941 Government teacher jobs. Noting that the entire examination procedure was completed in 148 days, the CM said 89 test ses-

sions were conducted, and 42,000 questions were compiled from 13 subjects.

Naidu said the people who bagged jobs were happy and underlined that their stories were moving, adding that some aspirants had prepared for seven long years.

The CM said the southern state had implemented a sports quota in DSC – 2025, adhering to the guidelines implemented by the Centre.

Hitting out at YSRCP supreme YS Jagan Mohan Reddy, Naidu accused the previous YSRCP Government of having “failed” to fill a single teaching post.

According to the CM,

between 10 lakh and 12 lakh students had quit Government schools under the previous administration while one lakh students transitioned from private to Government schools under the current political dispensation.

Though there was no deviation from the teacher recruitment notification, he accused the Opposition party of filing more than 300 cases against DSC-2025.

Moreover, Naidu expressed astonishment that YSRCP was the “only” party which did not attend the House for more than two years.

India, Thailand to hold joint military drill

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE n New Delhi

A bilateral military exercise involving troops of the Indian Army and the Royal Thai Army, aimed at enhancing combined capabilities to execute joint counter-insurgency and counter-terrorist operations in jungle and semi-urban environments under the United Nations Charter, will be held from August 18 to August 31, officials said on Monday. Exercise Maitree will be conducted at Vibhavadi Rangsit Camp, Surat Thani in Thailand.

The Indian Army contingent left for Thailand on Monday to participate in the 15th edition of this India-Thailand joint military exercise, the defence ministry said in a statement. The Indian Army and Royal Thai Army contingents comprise 85 personnel each.

“The Indian Army contingent is represented primarily by troops from 9 Gorkha Rifles,



Personnel of the Indian Army contingent pose for a group photograph in front of an Indian Air Force aircraft before departing for Thailand to participate India-Thailand Joint Military Exercise PTI

while the Royal Thai Army contingent comprises personnel from the 3rd Battalion, 25th Infantry Brigade, 5th Division,” the statement said. The exercise will involve company-level joint training focused on operations in jungle and semi-urban terrain, the officials said. The aim of Exercise Maitree is to foster military cooperation between India and Thailand.



Indira Gandhi Delhi Technical University for Women
Kashmere Gate, Delhi-110006
(Established by Govt. of Delhi vide Act 09 of 1912)
NAAC A+ Grade University
Women Education | Women Enlightenment | Women Empowerment

SPECIAL SPOT ROUND COUNSELLING 2026-27
B. TECH., B. TECH. + MBA (DUAL DEGREE) AND B. ARCH. PROGRAMS

IGDTUW was established by Govt. of NCT of Delhi in 2013 is a Technical University exclusively for Women with the mission to foster an environment for attaining excellence in Professional Education and promoting active participation in the field of Engineering, Science, Management, Architecture and Technology.

Special Spot Round Counselling will be conducted for admissions to B. Tech., B. Tech. + MBA (Dual Degree) and B. Arch. Programs of IGDTUW against a few vacant seats on 21st August 2026 at IGDTUW campus.

Also, Counselling will be done for two supernumerary seats reserved under Sports Quota. For eligibility criteria and other details for admission under the Sports quota, please visit the University website: <https://www.igdtuw.ac.in>

WHO CAN APPLY
Girl candidates already registered in JAC-2026 but could not secure any seat at IGDTUW along with fresh candidates (by paying the registration fee of Rs. 1500/-) are eligible for the Counseling.

For further guidelines, candidates are advised to visit the University Website: <https://igdtuw.ac.in>
Email id: ugadmissions@igdtuw.ac.in
DIP/Shabdarth/Classified/0186/26-27
Registrar



Editor's
TAKE

Vande Mataram does not deserve political slugfest

The song united Indians in the freedom struggle. Today, however, its legacy risks becoming another fault line in a deeply divided political discourse

On August 13, all six stanzas of *Vande Mataram* were sung inside the Lok Sabha for the first time in parliamentary history, as the Monsoon Session drew to a close. Two days later, from the ramparts of Red Fort, the full song was heard for the first time at an Independence Day ceremony - the 80th since 1947. The timing was crucial: 2025-26 marks 150 years since Bankim Chandra Chattopadhyay composed the song, later woven into his novel *Anandamath*, and it comes days after a new law made insulting or disrupting *Vande Mataram* a criminal offence, on par with the National Anthem.

Few songs carry this kind of weight. It was a rallying cry from Bengal's 1905 partition through the Quit India movement, sung by revolutionaries who faced lathis and prison for it. Yet its journey was never simple. In 1937, the Congress Working Committee - Gandhi, Nehru, Patel, Subhas Bose and Maulana Azad among them - resolved that only the first two stanzas, evoking the motherland's rivers and orchards, would be sung at national gatherings. The later verses invoke the goddess Durga; Tagore, consulted on the matter, advised that the opening stanzas could stand alone as a national song without carrying that religious charge into a plural nation. It was accommodation, not erasure - a considered decision to hold a diverse freedom movement together.

That history is exactly what is being contested now. Inaugurating the anniversary commemorations in November, Prime Minister Modi said the 1937 trimming had "sowed the seeds of Partition" - a charge Congress calls a distortion that insults both the Working Committee and Tagore himself. The row has since curdled: a Kerala Congress MP's intemperate vow never to sing the full version; a disputed video from a Congress Independence Day event that the BJP seized on as proof Sonia Gandhi and Mallikarjun Kharge had tried to cut the song short - something Congress disputes; a public demand from Amit Shah for an apology; police complaints in Delhi and Karnataka.

Even as MPs from the NCP, Shiv Sena and YSRCP urged that the song not be reduced to a political football, that is precisely what it has become. Would the country not be better served letting this song simply be sung and revered, without a running scorecard? A hymn that moved millions across faiths during the freedom struggle needs no statute to secure its place in the national imagination - it earned that, unaided, over 150 years.

Legislating reverence, and mining history for a partisan point, both cheapen a symbol that once asked only for love of country, nothing more. The flag, the anthem, this song - none of them belong in any single party's custody. The most patriotic thing today's politicians could do is stop competing over who loves *Vande Mataram* more, and simply let it keep doing what it has always done best: unite, rather than divide, without anyone needing to be told to sing it.

The Makkah triangle and the Iran test

The Makkah Agreement is best understood as an ambitious strategic triangle with enormous potential but incomplete strategic convergence. And Iran sits precisely where those interests collide



BHOPINDER SINGH

The temptation to describe the Makkah Joint Defence Agreement as an "Islamic NATO" is understandable. Signed by Saudi Arabia, Türkiye and Pakistan on August 7, 2026, the agreement declares that an armed attack against one member will be regarded as an attack against all. It brings together Saudi Arabia's financial and energy power, Türkiye's formidable conventional military and defence-industrial capabilities, and Pakistan's nuclear deterrent.

Yet the NATO analogy is premature. The greatest reason is Iran.

Iran represents the ultimate test of whether the Makkah Agreement can evolve from a strategically impressive partnership into a genuinely integrated collective-defence alliance. The problem is that the three members have fundamentally different relationships with Tehran.

For Saudi Arabia, Iran has traditionally been the principal regional strategic competitor. Riyadh remains concerned about Iranian missiles, drones, regional networks and the vulnerability of Gulf energy infrastructure. Türkiye's relationship with Iran is far more complicated. Ankara and Tehran compete for influence across Syria, Iraq, the Caucasus and the wider Middle East, but also maintain diplomatic and economic ties. Türkiye has generally preferred managed rivalry rather than permanent confrontation, preserving its strategic flexibility. Pakistan's position is more constrained still. It shares a border with Iran and has strong incentives to maintain workable relations with Tehran, given sectarian tensions (Pakistan hosts the second-largest Shia population in the world). Islamabad must consider its western frontier and the danger of creating another security problem alongside its longstanding confrontation with India.

This creates the fundamental question hanging over the Makkah Agreement: What happens if Iran attacks Saudi Arabia?

On paper, the answer appears straightforward. If an attack on one is an attack on all, an Iranian attack on Saudi Arabia should trigger collective defence. In practice, however, would Pakistan enter a direct war with Iran? Would Türkiye deploy combat forces? Or would the two instead provide intelligence, air-defence support, weapons and diplomatic backing? That distinction matters because the agreement establishes the principle of collective defence without yet possessing NATO's



IF TEHRAN
ATTACKS ONE
MEMBER AND THE
OTHER TWO
RESPOND
DECISIVELY, THE
MAKKAH
AGREEMENT WILL
GAIN CREDIBILITY
THAT NO
DIPLOMATIC
DECLARATION CAN
PROVIDE

The writer is a former Lieutenant Governor of the Andaman and Nicobar Islands and Puducherry, and a military veteran

decades-old command structures, intelligence architecture, interoperability and military planning.

Iran therefore exposes the difference between collective defence as a declaration and collective defence as an operational doctrine.

The problem becomes even greater if "Islamic NATO" is interpreted literally. NATO was built around a relatively clear strategic threat: the then Soviet Union. The Makkah grouping has no equivalent single adversary. Saudi Arabia is primarily concerned with Gulf security; Pakistan remains heavily focused on South Asia and India; Türkiye's strategic concerns extend across the Middle East, Black Sea, Caucasus, Eastern Mediterranean and NATO. Iran matters to all three, but not in the same way.

An explicitly anti-Iranian alliance could make the pact more militarily coherent but would create serious problems. Pakistan would face complications with its neighbour, Türkiye would lose strategic flexibility, and Saudi Arabia could become locked into permanent confrontation with Tehran. Yet avoiding an Iranian focus creates another problem - weaker credibility in precisely the scenario most likely to test the pact.

There is also a conceptual contradiction. Iran is itself a Muslim-majority country. Calling the arrangement an "Islamic NATO" therefore risks transforming a defensive partnership into the perception of a Saudi-Turkish-Pakistani bloc confronting Iran. The

three governments have consequently been careful to describe the agreement as defensive rather than directed against any particular state.

The more the Makkah pact develops into a military bloc, however, the harder it becomes to maintain that ambiguity. Conversely, explicitly defining Iran as the threat would expose the very differences among the three members that the alliance is supposed to overcome.

There are also competing external alignments to consider. Türkiye is a NATO member; Pakistan maintains a particularly close strategic relationship with China; and Saudi Arabia retains deep defence ties with the United States. These relationships are not necessarily incompatible with the Makkah Agreement, but they demonstrate that the three states operate within different strategic ecosystems. A

common defence framework must therefore coexist with, rather than replace, their existing alliances and partnerships.

The most realistic future may therefore be a flexible strategic-security framework rather than an Islamic NATO: deeper intelligence-sharing, joint exercises, missile and drone defence, maritime security, interoperability and defence-industrial cooperation, without requiring identical foreign policies. The pact does not need to become 'NATO' to be consequential. Its strength lies in combining three complementary forms of power: Saudi financial capacity, Turkish conventional and industrial capability, and Pakistani strategic deterrence. But Iran remains the unavoidable stress test.

If Tehran attacks one member and the other two respond decisively, the Makkah Agreement will gain credibility that no diplomatic declaration can provide. If the members instead revert to separate national calculations, the limitations of the "Islamic NATO" concept will become equally clear.

For now, therefore, the Makkah Agreement is best understood as an ambitious strategic triangle with enormous potential but incomplete strategic convergence. And Iran sits precisely where those interests collide. The ultimate test is therefore brutally simple:

If Iran attacks one, will the other two truly fight? Until that question has a credible answer, "Islamic NATO" describes the pact's potential and not its reality.

PIC TALK



Wrestlers compete during a traditional mud-wrestling match on 'Nag Panchami' festival, in Prayagraj, Uttar Pradesh. PHOTO: PTI



SAKSHI SETHI

2ND OPINION

There was a time when boredom was simply part of existence. People waited at bus stops, stood in lineups, ate meals, travelled short distances and even sat alone without needing to be entertained every second. Today, screen time, attention spans, the death of reading - parents raise these issues at every meeting, and they are not wrong to worry. But the conversation almost always points in one direction, from adult to child, as though the problem were something children caught on their own, like a cold, and the adults were merely trying to cure it.

The truth is less comfortable. Children do not learn their relationship with the phone from the phone. They learn it from their parents. A child asked to put the device away at the dinner table, while a parent checks a message 'just

once', receives two lessons at the same time and picks the one that is demonstrated rather than the one that is stated. Parents should understand that they are the first screen a child studies.

Long before they hold their own phone, they have watched, hundreds of times, what a face does when it hears a notification; how conversation pauses, how attention lifts and travels somewhere else, how the person in the room quietly becomes less important than the person on the screen. That is the curriculum which parents deliver every day without meaning to. Digital platforms are built around this precious commodity termed attention. Infinite scrolling makes no natural stopping point; autoplay removes the need to make another decision; continuous notifications pull users back, while likes, messages and new content offer small and unpredictable rewards. One may assume they are casually checking their phones, but the reality is that their attention is being competed for, seized and monetised.

Doomscrolling makes this interaction even more difficult. During stress, loneliness, anxiety or boredom, the phone offers immediate escape. We scroll hoping to feel better, informed or connected, yet often emerge more restless than before. Bad news sends us searching for more bad news.

Social media provides other people's lives as exciting, productive and happy, feeding the fear that something important is happening somewhere without us. Perhaps the most worrying consequence is not the number of

hours spent online, but what those hours displace. Parents scroll while children seek their attention, and children copy what they see.

Friends sit beside each other, yet their minds are far away in other digital rooms. Many of us surrender our first waking moments and our final sleepy minutes to a mobile screen. Nostalgia is not the answer. The pre-digital world was not perfect and is not coming back. Technology has transformed education, employment, healthcare and communication in remarkable ways.

What one needs is not digital rejection but digital discipline. Small boundaries can restore surprising amounts of control. One does not have to check their phone right when they wake up. Meals can be eaten without looking at screens.

Reading a book, writing a list by hand or sipping a cup of coffee in peace can reclaim moments which these devices have gradually occupied. We often ask what smartphones are doing to children. Adults/parents must ask what their own habits are teaching them. Digital behaviour is shaped as much by example as by instruction. Remember, technology was created to make life easier, not to become life itself. The real challenge of the digital age is no longer learning how to use technology; rather, it is learning when to stop and remember that real life still happens beyond the screen.

The writer is an educator and a councillor

RAHUL GANDHI PRAISES STUDENTS' COURAGE AGAINST PAPER-LEAK PROTESTS

Congress leader Rahul Gandhi on Sunday praised young people who protested against alleged examination paper leaks, saying their courage and resilience in demanding accountability deserved recognition.

He shared a video of his interaction with students who had protested last month seeking the resignation of then Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan over the allegations.

The students had faced alleged police excesses during the July 20 protest and later spoke about what they described as police "brutality" and harassment after raising their voices.

Gandhi said the youngsters had demonstrated courage by standing firm against what he called Prime Minister Narendra Modi's "violent regime". He said

the students had raised their concerns peacefully, with "peace, love and humour". Gandhi also announced that "Chhatron ki Goonj", an event where he interacts with students, would be held in Pune on August 22 and would be exclusively for girls.

On August 5, Gandhi had addressed a press conference after meeting the students.

Five appeared alongside him, including model Rhiya Ahir, whose photograph blocking a police van during protests in Mumbai had gone viral.

Ahir has also approached police alleging online harassment. The students are not doing anything illegal. Protest in a democracy is a valid political-social tool!

BHAGWAN THADANI | MUMBAI

Please send your letter to the info@dailypioneer.com. In not more than 250 words. We appreciate your feedback.

Patriotism should not become a memory test

Granting *Vande Mataram* a status at par with the National Anthem is a significant symbolic step, but it also raises a fundamental question: are we prepared to meet the standard we seek to impose?

A revealing exercise would be to ask political leaders to sing both *Vande Mataram* and *Jana Gana Mana* independently and consecutively, without prompts. The results could provide an unexpectedly honest measure of preparedness. Extending the same exercise to the wider population might be equally revealing. The proportion able to sing both correctly may prove surprisingly modest. This is not an argument against patriotism or either national song. Rather, patriotism should encourage participation, not become a test of rote memorisation. Before making such observance mandatory across the country, the government should first ensure that citizens understand, learn and can confidently sing both national compositions. National symbols command the greatest respect when they unite people voluntarily rather than become instruments of compulsion. India should therefore focus on building familiarity and understanding first, and prescribing obligation later. True patriotism is strengthened by informed participation, not enforced performance.

RS NARULA | PATIALA

Netanyahu faces a tough electoral battle

Recent opinion surveys suggest that Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu could face a difficult battle in the elections scheduled for October 2026. His policies on Gaza, along with Israel's military presence in Syria and Lebanon, were initially expected to strengthen his position as the leader Israel needed after the October 2023 Hamas attack. However, recent concessions reportedly made under pressure from the United States and the international community appear to have affected his standing. Former army chief Eizenkot has reportedly emerged as a strong challenger in several surveys and is only a few seats away from enabling his alliance to secure a parliamentary majority. For Netanyahu, the stakes are particularly high. His political legacy is closely tied to the Gaza war, while his ongoing graft case adds another layer of pressure. He is therefore likely to use every available political and diplomatic avenue to strengthen his position before the elections. The Gaza conflict could remain central to his strategy, particularly because public opinion in Israel remains deeply shaped by the October 2023 attacks and subsequent war.

If tensions escalate or Israel adopts more aggressive measures, the coming months could prove especially volatile, with both domestic politics and the regional conflict influencing each other.

YASHASWI BAIRAGI | UJJAIN

More MPs do not mean better governance

The proposal to substantially increase the strength of the Lok Sabha to 850 raises an important question beyond the arithmetic of political representation: will more MPs necessarily mean better governance? The concern becomes sharper when Parliament itself struggles with effective functioning. With nine Bills reportedly passed without adequate debate during the current session, merely increasing representation may not improve legislative scrutiny, accountability or governance. Parliament first needs greater seriousness in debate, scrutiny and oversight. If funds already allocated are delayed, underused or spent without sufficient scrutiny, additional expenditure should not automatically be justified. Any expansion of the Lok Sabha must therefore be examined through public accountability and fiscal prudence.

More MPs would mean recurring expenditure on salaries, allowances, staff, offices, accommodation, security and parliamentary infrastructure. The effectiveness of government delivery also depends heavily on States in areas such as education, healthcare, policing, agriculture, water, sanitation and local development. Greater representation should ultimately produce greater efficiency, not simply a larger Parliament.

BRIJ BHUSHAN GOYAL | LUDHIANA

The next phase of India’s digital payments revolution

UPI has given India one of the strongest digital institutions of the twenty-first century. The challenge now is not merely to celebrate its remarkable success, but to deepen it through complementary institutions that make digital finance an integral part of everyday economic life



ASHUTOSH KUMAR THAKUR

'Institutions are the rules of the game in a society.' Nobel laureate Douglass C. North made this deceptively simple observation while explaining why some nations prosper and others struggle. Economic progress, he argued, is rarely the result of technology alone. It depends on institutions that reduce uncertainty, build trust and make everyday transactions easier. India's digital payment revolution is perhaps the finest contemporary illustration of this principle. The country's greatest innovation has not been a smart-phone application. It has been the creation of a new institutional architecture for moving money.

Few countries have transformed the everyday act of payment as rapidly as India. Since its launch in 2016, the Unified Payments Interface has altered the financial behaviour of millions of citizens. It now processes more than 20 billion transactions every month and accounts for nearly half of all real-time payment transactions in the world. In a remarkably short period, UPI has become one of India's most successful digital public goods, admired by governments, multilateral institutions and central banks alike.

These achievements deserve recognition. They also invite a more difficult question. Has India reached the limits of its digital payments revolution, or is it merely completing its first phase?

The answer lies beyond transaction volumes. Despite UPI's spectacular success, cash continues to account for a significant share of household spending, particularly outside metropolitan India. Most UPI transactions are of low value, reflecting impressive inclusion but also revealing that digital payments have yet to dominate larger everyday commercial activity. India has solved the problem of scale. The next challenge is to achieve depth by embedding digital payments more comprehensively into transport, credit, commerce and international finance.

This is where the experiences of Japan, the United Kingdom and Singapore become instructive. None offers a template to copy. Each demonstrates how strong institutions evolve by solving the next problem rather than celebrating the previous achievement.

Japan's experience reminds us that payment systems become powerful when they become invisible. The Suica card began as a transport ticket for Tokyo's railway network. Over time, it evolved into a universal payment instrument accepted at convenience stores, restaurants, vending machines and neighbourhood retailers. Millions of commuters developed the habit of making digital payments not because they consciously embraced technology, but because technology quietly simplified everyday life.

That insight has particular relevance for India. Every day, millions of Indians travel by metro, suburban railways and city buses. Yet urban transport payments remain fragmented across cities, with different cards, tokens and ticketing systems coexisting. The National Common Mobility Card was conceived to address precisely this challenge by creating a single interoperable platform for mobility payments. Its progress, however, has been slower than originally envisioned.

A genuinely universal mobility payment system would do far more than improve urban transport. It would make digital payments an effortless daily habit for millions of commuters. Japan demonstrated that transport is not merely a public service. It is one of the most effective gateways to building a cashless economy. Significantly, Japan itself is now preparing to accept UPI at merchant outlets through collaborations between NPCI and NTT Data, reflecting the growing convergence between two countries that have approached digital payments from different directions.

If Japan teaches the importance of habit, the United Kingdom demonstrates the value of regulatory courage.

Open Banking in Britain did not emerge because banks voluntarily embraced competition. It emerged because regulators concluded that entrenched institutions had insufficient incentives to innovate. By requiring major banks to share customer data securely through standardised application programming interfaces, subject to customer consent, policymakers



DOUGLASS C NORTH REMINDED US THAT INSTITUTIONS DETERMINE THE LONG-RUN PERFORMANCE OF ECONOMIES BECAUSE THEY SHAPE INCENTIVES, REDUCE UNCERTAINTY AND BUILD TRUST

Ashutosh Kumar Thakur is a writer and columnist based in Bengaluru. He writes on literature, society, politics, business and South Asian cultural histories for leading publications

created an entirely new ecosystem of financial services. Consumers gained greater control over their financial information, while fintech companies found space to innovate without compromising trust.

India's Account Aggregator framework rests on a similar philosophy. It allows individuals to share financial information securely and with explicit consent across banks and financial institutions. The framework has expanded rapidly and represents one of the world's most sophisticated consent-based financial data architectures.

Yet the real challenge lies ahead. Adoption remains uneven across smaller banks, cooperative institutions and rural financial networks. The businesses that stand to benefit most from easier access to formal credit, including small enterprises, self-employed workers and gig economy participants, often remain outside the system's reach. The lesson from Britain is that digital public infrastructure must be accompanied by consistent regulatory execution. Institutions become transformative only when participation is broad rather than selective.

Singapore offers a different lesson, one centred on simplicity. Its SGQR system unified multiple payment platforms into a single QR code that could be used by consumers regardless of their preferred payment application or bank. For merchants, particularly small businesses, the complexity of managing multiple payment systems disappeared almost overnight. The elegance of the reform lay not in inventing new technology but in eliminating unnecessary friction.

India's Bharat QR embodies much the same philosophy in principle. It is an interoperable acceptance solution designed to work across UPI, RuPay, Visa and Mastercard, giving merchants a single QR-based route for receiving payments rather than forcing them to manage different payment-specific codes. In practice, however, many neighbourhood merchants continue to display multiple QR codes linked to different payment providers. Technical failures, inconsistent customer support and uneven merchant awareness continue to weaken confidence, particularly in smaller towns. Singapore's experience illustrates that interoperability is not merely a technical standard. It is a governance objective requiring continuous implementation and monitoring.

India has already begun extending its payment architecture beyond national borders. The UPI-PayNow linkage with Singapore has demonstrated how inexpensive and instantaneous cross-border transfers can replace slower and more expensive conventional channels. UPI is now operational in several countries, while Japan's planned acceptance of UPI represents another important milestone. These developments point towards a larger strategic possibility. India can move beyond exporting technology and begin shaping the architecture of international retail payments, particularly across the Global South.

The broader lesson emerging from these three countries is not that India has fallen behind. On the contrary, India has established one of the world's most successful digital payment ecosystems in less than a decade. What distinguishes mature institutions, however, is their capacity to evolve. Scale creates opportunity, but institutional depth sustains leadership. The coming decade should therefore focus less on counting transactions and more on expanding their economic significance. Digital payments should seamlessly integrate with public transport, credit delivery, small business finance, cross-border commerce and government services. Success should increasingly be measured not simply by the number of payments made but by the range of economic activity those payments enable.

India's digital payment revolution has already changed how money moves. Its next phase should change how the economy functions.

Douglass C North reminded us that institutions determine the long-run performance of economies because they shape incentives, reduce uncertainty and build trust.

Why RBI is betting on plastic in a UPI economy



AARUSHI SHANKAR

The Reserve Bank of India's (RBI) latest currency experiment may seem counterintuitive at first glance in an economy rapidly digitising on the back of real-time payment rails. The central bank, through its printing arm Bharatiya Reserve Bank Note Mudran Private Limited (BRBNMPL), has floated a Global Expression of Interest for 68,000 reams of polymer substrate, with 34,000 reams earmarked for `10 notes and another 34,000 reams for `20 notes. This global tender has been the central bank's most decisive move yet in a long-debated pilot rollout of plastic banknotes. This may seem like an over-engineered solution to a problem that digital payments already solve, but on the surface, it's not an unthinkable move for market observers. India is the world's largest player in the real-time digital transactions space, with the Unified Payments Interface (UPI) processing over 24,000 crore transactions annually and the Central Bank Digital Currency (e-Rupee) expanding its footprint. Why spend regulatory bandwidth and capital on upgrading physical banknotes when paper cash seems to be on a path towards structural decline? The answer lies in a nuanced understanding of cash velocity, life-cycle economics and the continuing reality of India's vast informal economy.

The economic case for polymer is entirely based on longevity, where the velocity of money is highest. The traditional cotton-pulp notes, especially the lower denominations of `10 and `20, are subject to constant wear and tear. Paper notes rapidly wear out in tropical humidity and rough treatment due to daily use. The RBI spent `5,101 crore in FY2023-24, `6,373 crore in FY2024-25 and `4,875 crore in FY2025-26 on security printing of currency. This was done to collect, shred and reprint billions of soiled paper notes to maintain its Clean Note Policy. Polymer substrate has an upfront production premium over traditional paper; however, its structural durability changes the cost equation over time. Polymer notes last much longer, so the break-even point is reached after a few years of deployment. On a multi-year horizon, fewer print runs translate directly to lower recurring bills for paper procurement, lower overhead for security printing, and lower transport and destruction costs. In addition, polymer banknotes enable the RBI to incorporate advanced security features such as transparent windows, metallic numerals, shadow images and complex optical effects that are very difficult for counterfeiters to reproduce with normal printing equipment.



Why cash coexists with the UPI surge

The core phenomenon of monetary macroeconomics: the divergence between payment transaction velocity and the base stock of money. Rapid digital adoption has not replaced physical cash; rather, the two channels show complementarity. This structural need for cash is evident from the recent monetary data. While setting records in terms of the volume of UPI transactions, the country's Currency in Circulation (CIC) crossed the historic level of `40 lakh crore, recording a strong rise of 11.9 per cent in FY26, which is its fastest growth pace since FY21. This is evident graphically from the upward-sloping CIC graph. The trend is explained by the fundamental dichotomy of functions, where UPI takes care of high-frequency, low-value transactions on a daily basis, and cash acts as the main store of value and precautionary fund. Important factors responsible for the growth of cash include an increase in nominal GDP, economic activity, income growth in the informal and rural segments, and high interest rates, which lead to increased precautionary saving.

Geopolitical safeguards and cultural lessons

The global tender parameters rolled out by the RBI reveal sharp parallels drawn from past international rollouts and India's geopolitical scenario:

- Cultural Sensitivity: The tenders obligate suppliers to state explicitly that there is absolutely no animal tallow or animal DNA present in the substrate. The requirement is related directly to the public relations issue that the Bank of England faced in 2016 due to the presence of small traces of tallow in the new £5 polymer banknotes, which led to strong protests from religious organisations and vegans.
- Geopolitical Boundaries: Procurement requirements include strict security conditions whereby suppliers should ensure total separation from any sites located in China or Pakistan, as well as ensure that they use no raw materials whatsoever from these countries.

Operational friction and global benchmarks

However, despite these benefits, switching to polymer presents operational challenges. Polymer-based notes are more slippery and have a static charge that may cause them to get stuck in automatic note-counting devices and ATMs. There will be a need for commercial banks to adjust their automatic sorting machinery to prevent mistakes in dispensing cash. Moreover, the special Biaxially Oriented Polypropylene (BOPP) polymer substrate is mostly supplied by foreign sources. However, over 50 central banks have provided clear empirical benchmarks:

- Australia: In 1988, it was the first to adopt polymer notes commemoratively, before fully mandating them over 1992-96. The Reserve Bank of Australia realised net financial savings of nearly \$1 billion over 25 years from reduced reprint costs.
- United Kingdom & Canada: Switching to polymer in both countries resulted in substantial drops in counterfeiting, as well as a reduction in the life-cycle carbon footprint relative to traditional paper currency. The Bank of England found its £5 note had a 16 per cent lower impact and its £10 note an 8 per cent lower impact, while the Bank of Canada found a 32 per cent reduction in global warming potential.

A pragmatic middle path

This measure taken by the RBI, where it decided to confine its pilot project to only the `10 and `20 notes, is indeed an astute move that will ensure no risk is involved. In this way, there is no need for a costly attempt to modify all high-denomination banknotes, but rather to focus on the most circulated notes where the value is best in relation to the lifespan of these notes. While the UPI system gradually gains momentum by handling micro-transactions in the major cities, physical cash plays a critical role in ensuring that financial inclusion, transaction privacy and economic security are achieved for millions of people in rural India. Modernising the physical infrastructure of low-denomination banknotes is not a replacement for digital transactions but rather a complement to them.

The writer is a Research Consultant at the Economy & Trade vertical at Chintan Research Foundation



RAHUL KAUSHIK

inary success against armed Naxalism. But the defeat of an armed insurgency does not automatically mean the disappearance of the ideological ecosystem that sustained it.

For decades, armed Naxalism did not survive merely because cadres operated from forests. Every insurgency needs an ecosystem: narratives that legitimise violence, networks that amplify those narratives, organisations capable of mobilising resources, and intellectual voices willing to portray attacks on the constitutional state as revolutionary justice. The armed Naxal was visible. He carried a weapon, occupied territory and attacked the state openly. That made the threat identifiable and ultimately easier to confront.

The dimagi Naxal is harder to confront precisely because there is no uniform or gun by which he can be identified.

The ideological battle can take place in universities, activist networks, cultural organisations, publications and sections of civil society. The problem is not criticism of the government. Criticism is indis-

pensible to democracy. The problem begins where intellectual activism crosses into legitimising political violence, deliberately spreading hostility towards the nation and its constitutional institutions, or providing material, organisational or propaganda assistance to violent or unlawful movements. This distinction is essential. Otherwise, "dimagi Naxals" becomes an indiscriminate political label rather than a description of a genuine security and ideological challenge.

Another dimension of this ecosystem deserves scrutiny. Certain activist organisations and advocacy networks have repeatedly placed themselves at the forefront of movements directed against major decisions of elected governments. Participation in an anti-government protest is, by itself, neither illegal nor anti-national. Indeed, peaceful protest is a democratic right.

The legitimate question arises when political mobilisation intersects with opaque financing, foreign funding, coordinated misinformation, unlawful activity or networks associated with extremist causes.

This is precisely why the financial architecture surrounding advocacy organisations matters. Where organisations receive substantial funding from abroad while simultaneously participating in campaigns intended to influence India's political and social environment, the Indian state has both the right and the responsibility to demand complete transparency regarding the origin, destination and utilisation of that money.

It is equally important not to collapse all such organisations into one category. Thousands of civil-



society organisations perform legitimate humanitarian, educational and social work. The case for scrutiny must therefore rest on evidence of financial or legal violations rather than ideological disagreement. There is also a political dimension to this ecosystem.

Opposition parties frequently find themselves supporting the same protests and campaigns championed by activist organisations opposed to government policies. That convergence does not, by itself, prove an organisational or financial nexus. But it does help explain the political resistance that often follows attempts to regulate these networks: activist groups can generate narratives, mobilisation and institutional pressure that coincide with the political objectives of parties seeking to challenge the government.

The relationship can therefore become mutually reinforcing even without a formal alliance. Activist networks provide intellectual arguments, litigation, campaigns and street mobilisation; opposition parties can provide political amplification and parliamentary legitimacy. Where their objectives converge, each strengthens the reach of the other. This is where the Foreign Contribution (Regulation) Act (FCRA) assumes importance.

The 2020 amendments substantially tightened India's foreign-funding architecture. They prohibited recipients of foreign contributions from transferring such funds onwards to other organisations, reduced the permissible ceiling for administrative expenditure from 50 per cent to 20 per cent, strengthened identification requirements and required foreign contributions to enter through a designated FCRA account at the State Bank of India's New Delhi Main Branch.

These changes made the movement of foreign money considerably more traceable.

Earlier, a complicated chain of transfers between organisations could make it difficult to establish precisely where foreign contributions ultimately went and for what purpose they were used. Greater transparency disrupts precisely the kind of opaque ecosystem within which illegitimate political or extremist activity can potentially hide. The government should strengthen this framework further where regulatory gaps remain.

The government's success against armed Maoism illustrates the difference between the two challenges. An armed movement can be defeated geographically; an ideological movement reproduces itself intellectually. For years, sections of the ideological ecosystem surrounding radical movements have portrayed the Indian state as inherently oppressive and undeserving of allegiance. Universities are particularly important here. They must remain places where governments, ideologies and institutions can be questioned. But intellectual freedom cannot mean freedom from intellectual challenge. Ideas that romanticise rev-

olutionary violence, excuse terrorism or portray India's fragmentation as liberation must be confronted through scholarship, debate and facts.

The same principle applies across civil society, media, culture and academia.

India therefore needs something considerably more sophisticated than another security crackdown. The support system of violent extremism must be dismantled wherever evidence establishes its existence, while the ideological arguments sustaining extremism must be defeated openly.

Financial networks require transparency. Illegal activity requires prosecution. Foreign funding requires scrutiny. Propaganda requires rebuttal. Universities require genuine intellectual pluralism rather than domination by any single ideological tendency. And political parties, irrespective of ideology, must recognise a fundamental distinction: opposing the government is entirely legitimate; weakening the constitutional state is not.

The armed Naxal sought to weaken India with the gun. The ideological extremist can pursue the same objective through narratives, networks, institutions and the radicalisation of young minds.

India has demonstrated that it can defeat the first. Prime Minister Modi's warning about the "dimagi Naxal" is ultimately a warning that victory against insurgency will remain incomplete unless India also develops the intellectual confidence, financial transparency and institutional vigilance necessary to dismantle the ecosystem from which extremism repeatedly regenerates itself.

The writer is a commentator on socio-political issues

From guns to narratives: India’s next Naxal challenge

Your Trusted Management Advisory

www.transglobeadvisors.in

Order Order

States can’t create blockades in elephant corridors: SC



The Supreme Court on Monday directed the Ministry of Environment, Forests and Climate Change (MoEFCC) to conduct a nationwide survey to check if any state has constructed obstacles or created blockades in elephant corridors, saying it was unacceptable.

A bench of Chief Justice Surya Kant and Justices Joymalya Bagchi and V Mohana made it clear that states cannot construct obstacles in the pathways of elephants to prevent loss of crops and livelihoods.

“Construction of any kind of obstacle or creating blockades in elephant corridors is not acceptable. We are very clear that there cannot be obstacles in the way of wildlife. Elephant herds have a practice of travelling long distances. No state can say that just because crops are getting destroyed, they will have to construct obstacles on their path,” the bench said.

Justice Bagchi said the practice of using fireballs and spikes in West Bengal is prevalent because the elephants come from Nepal and through West Bengal they go to Jharkhand and other states.

CJI Kant said in the Yamuna Nagar area of Haryana there are elephants and from there they travel to Uttarakhand and Himachal Pradesh.

“No state can block their path,” the CJI said. (PTI)

Old TGI cards unaffected by new law: Govt tells SC



The transgender identity cards issued before the enactment of the Transgender Persons (Protection of Rights) Amendment Act, 2026, will continue to remain valid and will not be affected by the new law, the Centre told the Supreme Court on Monday.

A Transgender Identity (TGI) card provides official recognition of a person's self-identified gender and can be used to support changes to their name and gender across official records. The Government's transgender portal specifically states that it enables changes to name and gender in official documents.

“I have taken instructions. The TGI ID cards issued earlier will continue to operate subject to the outcome (on the petitions),” Solicitor General Tushar Mehta told a bench comprising Chief Justice of India Surya Kant and justices Joymalya Bagchi and V Mohana during the hearing of a batch of petitions challenging the 2026 amendment.

The amendment has been challenged, among other grounds, for taking away the right to self-identification of gender that was recognised under the Transgender Persons (Protection of Rights) Act, 2019.

There were around 15 petitions challenging the validity of the amended law.

The Solicitor General also said that the Centre will file its response to the petitions. (PTI)

No CCTV or eyewitness needed in dowry cruelty case, Delhi court says

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
n New Delhi

A Delhi court has refused to discharge a man facing prosecution for allegedly subjecting his wife to dowry harassment and cruelty, saying that such offences are often committed within the four walls of a house and may not have eyewitnesses or CCTV camera footage.

Additional Sessions Judge Parveen Singh was hearing a revision petition filed by Sunil Sharma challenging an order directing framing of charges against him under the law relating to cruelty by husband or his relatives and the Dowry Prohibition Act.

In the order dated August 13, the court said, “As regards the contention that there is no medical evidence to support the claim of the complainant that she was beaten by her husband, I find that at the stage of framing of charges, the veracity of the



statement of the complainant is not to be tested for corroboration with medical evidence or any other evidence.”

The court said that at the stage of framing charges, it was only required to see whether the material on record disclosed a prima facie case and the veracity of the complainant's allegations was not to be tested against medical or other corroborative evidence.

Sharma's wife had alleged



SC relief to Rahul in DA case

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
n New Delhi

In a major relief to Rahul Gandhi, the Supreme Court on Monday asked the Allahabad High Court not to proceed with a case involving allegations of disproportionate assets against the Congress leader.

The top court also asked the CBI and the ED not to file any report in pursuance of the directions of the high court in the case lodged against the Leader of Opposition in Lok Sabha. A bench comprising Chief Justice Surya Kant and Justices Joymalya Bagchi and V Mohana took note of the submissions of senior advocate Kapil Sibal, appearing for Gandhi, and issued notices to Karnataka resident S Vignesh Shishir, who filed the plea in the high court, the CBI and the ED.

The bench was hearing a plea filed by Gandhi against the high court order.

It directed the high court to defer the next hearing before it till the next date of hearing in the Supreme Court.

“This is absolutely unknown to law. This is a



witch-hunt process which is not recognised by law. This is most unfortunate. Attempts after attempt are being made by this very petitioner,” Sibal said at the outset. He questioned the locus of Vignesh Shishir to file a petition in the high court. He also did not disclose his credentials, Sibal said. “May I only say, the CBI has done nothing except verifying the complaint,” the senior lawyer said.

Additional Solicitor General SV Raju, appearing for the central probe agencies, said they have no role in the case so far, and if the complaint discloses commission of cognisable offences, then it is very serious.

“We are not concerned with that. Suppose somebody commits murder, etc.,

police do not need permission. But what appears to us is, subject to the assistance provided to us from both sides, if the court wants to issue a direction, it is expected to follow the principle of natural justice,” the CJI said.

Shishir, who had moved the high court against Gandhi, appeared online and opposed Gandhi's plea against the high court order.

“This is a simple pre-FIR stage case. The accused doesn't have any right to be heard in the pre-FIR stage,” he said.

“Facts may be right, facts may be wrong. But if the facts are right, it's a gross case to use the court's jurisdiction,” Sibal said.

“The other thing is these are sealed cover procedures. How

do newspaper reports happen? It's a sealed cover procedure. The judges should have asked how it came in newspapers,” Sibal asked.

“If it is so serious, why has your agency kept quiet? Do you need a direction from the court. Have you taken any suo motu action? No, right?” Justice Bagchi asked the law officer representing the probe agencies.

Expressing dissatisfaction with the CBI's response, the Allahabad High Court's Lucknow bench on July 20 directed the agency's senior officer to personally file a fresh affidavit detailing the progress made in the probe into allegations of disproportionate assets against Gandhi.

The high court had also observed that if, during the course of its inquiry, the ED comes across material and documents indicating any illegality, it would be free to proceed further in accordance with law.

The high court was hearing the plea that sought an investigation by the CBI and the ED into allegations of disproportionate assets against the Congress leader.

UP judge hands down 22 deaths in four months

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
n Muzaffarnagar

In the last four months, the court of Additional District and Sessions Judge Ravi Kumar Diwakar has delivered verdicts in 10 cases, resulting in 22 individuals being sentenced to death. Government lawyer Kuldeep Kumar told PTI on Monday that three individuals were sentenced to death in the lawyer Sameer Safi murder case on April 6, 2026.

Four people were sentenced to death on April 28, one on May 20, and two on June 20. In July, one received a death sentence on July 2, two on July 6, and four on July 17. In August, one person was sentenced to death on August 12, and four more on August 13.

Kumar stated that all 22 individuals convicted in these 10 cases were sentenced to death over the last four months. The offences included the murder of a lawyer, the murder of a home guard, highway robbery, and other murder cases.

On August 12, the court sentenced a man to death for the abduction and murder of a



wood trader for ransom nearly 27 years ago. The convict, Shahnawaz, was fined 1.10 lakh after being found guilty of the abduction and murder of Saleem in 1999. On August 13, a fast-track court in Muzaffarnagar handed down death sentences to four individuals in a 12-year-old murder case.

Judge Diwakar also imposed a fine of 1.70 lakh on the convicts, Ramvir, Rajiv, Rahul, and Harender Kumar, after they were found guilty of murdering Pawan Kumar.

The accused had entered Pawan's house and opened fire due to an old enmity, in an incident that occurred in Bhabhisa village in Shamli district on July 14, 2014.

Nuclear liability cap: SC seeks Govt's stand on compensation

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
n New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Monday asked the Centre to clarify whether courts are precluded from granting fair and just compensation under the SHANTI Act in case of a nuclear accident.

A bench of Chief Justice Surya Kant and Justices Joymalya Bagchi and V Mohana said it was issuing limited notice and also asking the Centre to clarify whether there was any conflict of interest in appointing members to the regulatory body under the SHANTI Act.

The top court was hearing a plea filed by a group of petitioners, including professors and scientists, led by former bureaucrat EAS Sarna. It submitted that the 2025 Act violated fundamental rights under Article 14, 19 and 21 of the Constitution.

Advocates Prashant



Bhushan and Neha Rath, appearing for the group, said the law caps the liability in case of any accident.

CJI Kant said there was too much apprehension and pointed out that even if Parliament has capped the liability of operators, it does not preclude the court from granting fair and just compensation. He said Parliament has passed the bill to incentivise the project proponent and bring investment.

Bhushan submitted that it was like allowing operators to cut corners on safety.

The bench asked the Centre to clarify its position on appointment of members of the Atomic Energy Regulatory Body (AERB) under section 17 (4) of the SHANTI Act on the recommendation of the search and selection panel constituted by the Atomic Energy Commission.

Bhushan said the Atomic Energy Commission is responsible for running atomic power stations in the country and it cannot recommend members to the regulatory body, which is a conflict of interest.

Cauvery row: SC tells Karnataka to comply with water release order

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
n New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Monday asked the Karnataka Government to ensure compliance of the Cauvery Water Management Authority's (CWMA) direction on the release of Cauvery water to Tamil Nadu.

While the Tamil Nadu Government claimed before the apex court that the CWMA's direction was not being complied with, the Karnataka Government said the picture being projected was “extremely incorrect”. The Cauvery Water Regulation Committee (CWRC) had directed Karnataka to release 12,000

cusecs of water daily to Tamil Nadu for 15 days from August 12. The CWMA subsequently upheld the decision.

On Monday, the Tamil Nadu Government's plea seeking directions to the Karnataka Government for immediate release of the water to it came up for hearing before a bench of Justices Vikram Nath and Sandeep Mehta.

“We feel that let this matter be posted after a week so that the further status regarding the release may be placed before the court,” the bench said. It posted the matter for August 24. “Ensure compliance of the CWMA directions,” the bench said. Senior advocate CS Vaidyanathan, appear-



ing for Tamil Nadu, told the bench that the CWMA's direction was not being complied with and the state was unable to release water to farmers.

“They (Karnataka) have started releasing water for irrigation in Karnataka, and Tamil Nadu has not been receiving water,” he said. “As of now, they have 76 per cent

live storage in the reservoir and they have hardly released,” he added.

The bench asked the Karnataka Government, “Why are you not releasing?”

Senior advocate Shyam Divan, appearing for Karnataka, replied that the picture being projected before it was “extremely incorrect in

every material respect”.

“This is an extremely severe distress year and when you have an extremely severe distress year as in the present case, there is a mechanism and a machinery for the purposes of balancing,” he said. As far as the Cauvery basin is concerned, Divan said, there is enormous deficit and the CWMA is alive to the situation and has issued directions.

According to the first direction, Karnataka was required to ensure release of 3,500 cusecs of water for 15 days till August 11, he said.

Divan also referred to the subsequent direction to release 12,000 cusecs of water daily for 15 days from August

12, and placed the data before the bench. He said releasing 12,000 cusecs was very difficult for Karnataka, but instructions have been issued to ensure that this level is maintained.

Divan said the flow was low during the first three-four days but Karnataka will make it up in next few days. The Tamil Nadu Government had earlier said the state was not getting its due share of Cauvery water in a rain deficient year.

The Joseph Vijay led-state Government on August 3 approached the apex court seeking directions to the Karnataka Government for immediate release of the water.

CBI files charge sheet in Twisha Sharma case

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
n New Delhi

The CBI has filed a charge sheet against Samarth Singh and Giribala Singh, the husband and mother-in-law of former actor and model Twisha Sharma, who was found dead under suspicious circumstances at her marital home in Bhopal on May 12, officials said on Monday.

In the charge sheet filed before a special court in Bhopal, the CBI has alleged that both Samarth and Giribala, a former district judge, inflicted mental cruelty on Twisha, leaving her no option but to take her own life, officials said.

They said the agency levelled allegations of abetment to suicide on the mother and son while keeping the probe into claims of dowry demands and alleged dowry death open.

The CBI has given factual details about the cruelty inflicted on Twisha and who



did what to her, including the mental harassment she was subjected to. All of that made it clear that she was left with no option, Twisha's bother Ashish Sharma told reporters. Twisha's family had accused Samarth and Giribala of mental abuse, physical violence, and dowry-related torture.

The former actor Twisha, who married Samarth last December, was found hanging at her marital home on May 12. It was alleged in the FIR that Samarth had taken her to AIIMS Bhopal,



where he claimed that she hanged herself at home at 10.20 pm.

The doctors at AIIMS informed the police that she was brought dead to the hospital, after which a medico-legal case was registered, the FIR said.

After the initial police investigation and a second autopsy ordered by the Madhya Pradesh High Court to clear critical doubts and address the family's allegations of lapses in the first performed by AIIMS Bhopal, the CBI took over the probe and



arrested Samarth and Giribala. The second autopsy was conducted on May 24 by a four-member team from AIIMS Delhi in Bhopal.

In their statements, Twisha's family has alleged that she was tormented by her in-laws, who were not satisfied with the dowry paid at the time of the wedding on December 9, 2025.

They levelled allegations of mental torture and domestic violence, which allegedly pushed the 33-year-old former model and actor to take the extreme step.

Wings for Bharat

Why technical and operational drone training is India's next great skilling frontier — for its youth and its veterans



SK
VASUDEVA

It is widely believed and understood that India has missed the Industrial revolution, though it led the world in the IT Sector, and during Y2K, India arrived almost suddenly on the world stage. However, India is far behind in the semiconductor business, and computing hardware sector. Interestingly India and USA have decades ago established the IIT's & IIM's which have nurtured and given the world the best technical and managerial skills to the world.

Hence it is ironical that India has not benefited by that real input to any business and economy which is Human Skills and Training.

Having made the above statement, it is critical to note that while India has taken steps in the Drone sector to boost the growth in this sector, and make India as the DRONE HUB of the world, it has to similarly nurture the skills and human talent to service this sector.

Why Drones? Reason being like Cellular technology has been the Big Disruptor in Telecommunications, Drones will be in the Logistics and Mobility sector. Besides Drones is the environmentally friendly means of mobility.

A decade ago, a drone in India was a curiosity — a hobbyist's toy grounded, more often than not, by a police complaint. Today it is a farming tool, a firefighting asset, a surveying instrument, a border sentry and, increasingly, a career. The distance India has travelled on drones in ten years is remarkable. The distance it still has to travel on training the people who will fly, fix, command and build them is the subject of this piece.

The turning point is easy to date. On 27 January 2023, more than a thousand drones lit up the sky over Vijay Chowk in New Delhi in a single choreographed show, a piece of public theatre that did more to signal official ambition than any policy document could. Within months, the Drone Rules of 2021 had already begun replacing a slow, manual clearance regime with an automated one. What has followed since is not a single dramatic leap but a steady accumulation of infrastructure, incentive and, finally, institution-building — of which the training question is

the newest and least resolved chapter.

A technology ahead of its workforce

India's drone market was valued at roughly \$470 million in 2025 and is forecast to reach \$1.39 billion by 2030, growing at nearly 24 per cent a year.

That growth is not confined to any one sector. Agriculture uses drones for crop spraying and monitoring under the Kisan Drone and Nam0 Drone Didi programs. Infrastructure and mapping projects use them under SVAMITVA, which has digitised more than ten crore rural land parcels. Logistics firms use them for last-mile delivery trials. Defense and security agencies, the fastest-growing segment of all at a projected 26 per cent annual growth, use them for surveillance, reconnaissance and, increasingly, counter-drone defense.

Government policy has pushed hard to make this possible. The Production — Linked Incentive scheme has channeled crores toward domestic drone and component manufacturing, at a subsidy rate reserved for no other industry. The Drone Rules of 2021 replaced a thicket of manual approvals with a Digital Sky platform that authorises routine flights almost instantly. Drone Shakti has backed start-ups offering Drone-as-a-Service. Every one of these initiatives assumes a workforce capable of building, flying, maintaining and commanding these machines safely.

That workforce does not yet exist at the scale the policy requires.

This is the gap that determines whether India's drone ambitions remain a policy document or become an industry. Closing it requires more than manufacturing incentives. It requires institutions that can turn interested young people, and experienced but under-utilised former soldiers, into certified, competent, employable drone professionals — in the cockpit, in the workshop, and in the control room. There is also a strategic dimension that goes beyond jobs. Drones and counter-drone systems have become instruments of national security in their own right, visible in every recent conflict from Eastern Europe to South Asia's own border skirmishes. A country that trains only enough people to fly agricultural spraying drones, while depending on imported expertise for defense-grade UAV operation and maintenance, will find itself strategically exposed the moment it needs that capability at scale and speed. Training pipelines built today are, in a real sense, a slower-moving but



equally important companion to the PLI scheme's manufacturing push — both aimed at the same underlying goal of *Atmanirbhar Bharat* in the air.

Why training, specifically, is the bottleneck

Flying a drone commercially in India is not casual. A Remote Pilot Certificate issued under the Directorate General of Civil Aviation is mandatory for anyone operating a drone above the smallest, hobbyist category, and it demands ground instruction in air law, meteorology, navigation and airframe systems, followed by supervised practical flying hours and a certifying examination. This is, in a sense and structure, closer to a private pilot's license than to a video-game skill, and it is meant to be.

The reason is straightforward: a drone that fails, strays or is misused is not merely an expensive loss. It is an aircraft in shared airspace, a potential hazard to people and property on the ground, and, in border and defense contexts, a potential security incident. A country building an economy around tens of thousands of these machines cannot afford to train the people who operate them casually.

Technical training and operational training are, in fact, two distinct disciplines, and a serious drone academy has to deliver both. Technical training covers the engineering underneath the machine: aerodynamics, propulsion, battery and payload systems,



airframe maintenance, and increasingly the software and AI systems that govern autonomous flight. Operational training covers what happens once the aircraft is in the air: mission planning, airspace coordination, emergency procedures, sensor and payload operation, and — in defense and security applications — the tactics of using a drone, or defeating one, under real operational pressure. A pilot who can fly but cannot diagnose a propulsion fault is only half-trained. An engineer who can build a drone but has never flown one under a real mission profile is only half-trained in the other direction. The strongest institutions teach both together.

A properly built curriculum, in other words, does not end at the Remote Pilot Certificate. It extends into simulator — based emergency handling, so a student has already lost control of a virtual aircraft in a dozen different failure modes before ever risking a real one; into hands-on maintenance so a graduate can strip, inspect and rebuild the propulsion and

India protects its neem better than its DNA

Section 2(c) of the Biological Diversity Act protects every living thing in India except Indians.

The law that might fix it closes in nine months



Your DNA is written in a chemical alphabet of four letters, three billion of them in a row. In one gene that builds the heart, twenty-five of those letters may be missing. The gap is old, passed from parent to child for thousands of years. Four to eight of every hundred people of South Asian origin carry it — perhaps a hundred million of us. Indian scientists found it, reporting in *Nature Genetics* in 2009 that carriers were seven times likelier to develop serious heart-muscle disease. For over a decade that was the answer.

In 2020 the answer changed. Researchers looked again, using far larger DNA databases and two big groups of heart patients — one over three-quarters European and five per cent South Asian. The missing letters, they concluded, were not the danger. The risk came from a rarer change sitting beside them. That is science doing its job. But notice where the work happened. **Whoever holds the data decides what is true about your body.**

The most valuable unseen data on earth

About 87 of every hundred participants in the world's large genetic studies are of European descent. Europeans are nine in a hundred of humanity. South Asians are a quarter of the world and under two in a hundred of the data.

That is not merely unfair. It breaks the machinery. An AI system learns by being shown millions of examples; the examples are its training data, the finished system a model. A model shown mostly one kind of person becomes a doctor who has only ever practised in one town — confident, experienced, wrong about everyone else.

You see it in a prescription. Whether a standard dose of warfarin protects or harms you depends on genes that differ between Indians and Europeans, and between one Indian community and the next. You see it in a lab report, in the verdict called a variant of uncertain significance: the laboratory has found something unusual in your DNA and cannot say if it matters. Patients who are not of European descent receive that blank answer far more often, because the reference libraries hold too few people like them. One of us spends her working days at exactly that junction.

The uncertainty is not in the patient. It is in the library.



Now the uncomfortable part. For centuries most Indian communities have married within themselves. Whatever one thinks of that history, it left a mark: India is not one population but thousands of small ones, each grown from a limited number of ancestors, each concentrating its own rare inherited differences. Geneticists have always hunted for this — it is why Iceland and Finland have been studied so heavily. And it obeys a rule that governs all information: what is rare tells you more than what is common. Being told the sun rose teaches nothing. Being told it snowed in Chennai teaches a great deal.

The scarce ingredient in AI today is not computing power or capital. It is examples the machine has never seen. By that measure India is the last great unexplored territory on earth.

The price has already been tested

In March 2025 the American company 23andMe went bankrupt, and its most valuable asset turned out to be fifteen million saliva samples. They were auctioned for \$305 million — about 2,600 crore, or roughly 1,700 a person. Nobody broke the law. Everybody had signed something. The fifteen million were not in the room.

Meanwhile the serious money has moved to models and the data that feeds them. In March 2026 Eli Lilly expanded a deal with the AI firm Insilico Medicine worth up to \$2.75 billion, near 24,000 crore. In February 2026 Merck signed with the Mayo Clinic

to pour patient records and genetic data into its own AI. Britain's UK Biobank sold four global drugmakers a nine-month head start on its genome data before wider release, and charges for access. The pattern is constant. Samples are the ingredients; the model is the recipe. The money goes to whoever owns the recipe.

We have fought this war before and won

Here is what makes India's silence so strange. No country on earth has thought harder about this question. We simply thought about it for plants.

When an American patent claimed turmeric for wound healing, India challenged it and the US patent office revoked it in 1997. When a neem-based fungicide was patented in Europe, India fought for a decade and the patent fell. When a Texas company claimed basmati, India contested that too. We built the Traditional Knowledge Digital Library so no one could patent what our grandmothers already knew. We pushed the principle into international law through the Convention on Biological Diversity and hosted its conference in Hyderabad.

Then we wrote it into our own statute. The Biological Diversity Act, 2002 established that inherited biological wealth belongs to the communities that carry it, that outsiders must seek permission before taking it, and that benefits must flow back. It created the National Biodiversity Authority in Chennai, state boards, and more than 31,000 Biological Management Committees — village-level bodies with a statutory voice over what leaves their soil. It is, by any measure, one of the most sophisticated things India has given the world.

And we wrote ourselves out of it

Read Section 2(c). Biological resources are defined as plants, animals and micro-organisms, their genetic material and by-products - **"but does not include human genetic material."** A neem tree in a Tamil Nadu village has a statutory guardian. The people living under it do not. Parliament amended this Act as recently as 2023 and did not revisit the exclusion.

The result is an absurdity nobody has named. India's most valuable biological resource is the only one outside the framework India built to protect biological resources.

And our other law does not fill the gap. The Digital Personal Data Protection Rules were notified in November 2025, but most substantive obligations begin only on 13 May 2027

- nine months from now. Unlike Europe's law, ours creates no special category for genetic information, and it leaves a broad opening for research. It rests, besides, on a foundation that does not fit: one person consenting for one person's information. Your DNA is a photocopy of your parents and a preview of your children. And what makes it valuable to a model is not you at all — it is the pattern shared across your community. Nobody can consent on behalf of a community. No Indian law lets a community consent at all.

Meanwhile GenomeIndia has read 10,000 whole genomes from 83 communities, stored at Faridabad, with a stated target of ten million. NITI Aayog's July 2026 roadmap projects biology-based industries worth \$691 billion by 2035, near 60 lakh crore, with a 50,000 crore fund behind it. The agreements that will govern all of it are being drafted now.

What should happen in the next nine months

This is not a case for hoarding, and the objection deserves an answer. Benefit-sharing did not shut down plant research; it structured it. The world still uses Indian biological resources — it now asks first. The same is achievable here, and Indian patients need what global science can build from this data.

Three things. **Extend the framework we already have.** Either amend Section 2(c) or build a parallel access-and-benefit-sharing regime for human genetic data under the Department of Biotechnology. The architecture exists; only the definition excludes us.

Classify genetic data as sensitive under the DPDP Rules before May 2027, with insurers and employers barred by statute. The window is open now and will not reopen soon.

Give communities a seat. More than 31,000 Biological Management Committees already sit across this country, doing precisely this job for seeds and plants. Extending their remit is cheaper than inventing anything.

Twenty-five letters. A hundred million carriers. We went to war over turmeric on behalf of people who never knew their inheritance was being taken. Those same people are still waiting for us to notice they are worth more than the plants in their fields.

Nishant Sahdev is a physicist at the University of North Carolina at Chapel Hill and a columnist on AI, infrastructure and global systems and Debarati Das is a BSc Microbiology student at Adamas University and was a summer research intern under Sahdev

From prediction to action: AI rewrites supply chains

As geopolitical disruptions multiply, agentic AI could help supply chains anticipate disruptions and act faster



RAJESH
SETH

The disruption in the Strait of Hormuz is a stark reminder of how quickly geopolitics can become a supply-chain crisis. Shipping traffic through the strategic waterway has fallen dramatically from normal levels, with energy supplies, freight costs, shipping schedules and sourcing decisions all affected. For supply-chain managers, the challenge is no longer simply to know what has happened, but to anticipate what could happen next, and act before disruption cascades through the network.

This is where the next generation of artificial intelligence could change supply-chain management. The evolution is moving from traditional analytics to predictive AI, then generative AI and now agentic AI: systems that can reason towards a goal, plan a sequence of actions and execute tasks with limited human intervention. The distinction is important. Traditional AI might flag a likely shortage; an AI agent could analyse inventory, supplier availability and logistics options, recommend a response and, within pre-authorised boundaries, initiate the required action.

Connecting predictions with operational decisions

Consider what this could mean during a disruption such as Hormuz. An AI agent could continuously monitor geopolitical developments, shipping movements, supplier information and inventory levels; identify which shipments or plants are at risk; evaluate alternative routes or suppliers; calculate cost and service implications; and present the supply-chain manager with an actionable response. The manager remains accountable, but the machine compresses hours of data gathering and analysis into minutes.

Amazon offers a glimpse of this direction. Its supply-chain operations already use AI for demand forecasting,



delivery-location accuracy and

intelligent robotics. In 2026, Amazon also launched Amazon Supply Chain Services, making its logistics network and AI forecasting capabilities available to other businesses. Its forecasting models help optimise inventory placement by predicting what customers will want, where and when. The significance is not simply automation; it is the growing ability to connect prediction with operational decisions.

Agentic AI in Supply Chain systems

An especially instructive example comes from Singapore, where AWS and A*STAR's Advanced Remanufacturing and Technology Centre co-developed a Logistics AI Agent. The agent can aggregate information from ERP, transportation, warehouse and customer systems, provide natural-language answers and support actions such as shipment updates and purchase-order interventions. AWS says the system can eliminate up to 50 per cent of manual lookup and reconciliation work. This illustrates a critical advantage of agentic AI: instead of forcing a manager to move between multiple systems, the agent can reason across fragmented information and turn it into an operational response.

Global logistics companies are also moving in this direction. DHL has deployed agentic AI for shipment booking and data enrichment, automating more than 70 manual data fields and reporting a 40per cent productivity gain in one

application. It has also introduced AI-powered item identification that uses a photograph of a shipment to generate a customs-compliant description, improving data quality and reducing clearance delays.

The importance of resilience

India is not a bystander. Delhivery has introduced an AI-agent-powered autonomous transport management system to automate

freight procurement, shipment planning, execution and invoice reconciliation. It has also launched an AI-driven customer-support agent. These developments suggest that agentic AI is moving beyond experimentation into core logistics processes in India.

Yet the emergence of agentic AI should not be confused with fully autonomous supply chains. AI is only as good as the data, processes and systems surrounding it. Poor master data, fragmented IT systems and weak process discipline cannot be solved simply by adding an AI layer. More importantly, not every decision should be delegated to a machine.

That shift matters because resilience increasingly depends on speed. In a volatile environment, a company that detects a disruption ten hours earlier can secure capacity, reroute cargo or activate an alternative supplier before competitors do. Agentic AI therefore has the potential to turn resilience from a periodic contingency exercise into a continuous capability, provided humans establish clear rules for what an agent may decide, what it must recommend, and what always requires approval.

Please read the complete article online at dailypioneer.com

The author is an alumnus of IIM Ahmedabad and Professor of Practice at IILM University, Gurugram with an interest in AI, Technology and Strategy

Trump terms Saudi-Turkiye-Pak defence pact big, bold step

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
n Washington/Islamabad

US President Donald Trump has termed the Saudi Arabia-Turkiye-Pakistan defence agreement a “big, bold and important first step” towards defending themselves in a “more meaningful way”.

Signed in Makkah on August 7, the pact establishes a framework for collective deterrence and stipulated that an armed attack on any one of the three countries would be considered an attack on all three.

The agreement was signed by Saudi Crown Prince Mohammed bin Salman, Turkish President Recep Tayyip Erdogan and Pakistan Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif.

Sharif on Monday lauded Trump’s “kind words” on the tri-nation defence agreement, saying that Islamabad would continue to work in ensuring its defence and the wider region. Trump, in a post on his



Trump waves to the media as he walks from Marine One to his limousine upon his arrival at the Ellipse just outside of the White House (AP)

Truth Social network, said, “Very happy to see that Saudi Arabia, Turkey, and Pakistan have recently, and finally, signed the Mecca Joint Defence Agreement. It shows how the West Asis is coming together, and how countries will finally be able to defend themselves in a more meaningful way.”

“Congratulations to the Great Leadership of the three Nations mentioned. THIS IS A BIG, BOLD, AND IMPORTANT

FIRST STEP - WOW,” Trump wrote. Sharif, in a post on X, said, “Deeply appreciate President Donald Trump’s kind words of support on the signing of the Makkah Joint Defence Agreement.”

“Together with the brotherly Kingdom of Saudi Arabia and the Republic of Turkiye, Pakistan will continue to play a constructive role in ensuring the defence of our own countries as well as the entire

region.” Days after the agreement was signed, India said it is assessing the implications of it through the point of view of its own national security as well as regional peace and stability. “India remains fully committed to safeguarding its national interests and will take all necessary measures in this regard,” External Affairs Ministry Spokesperson Randhir Jaiswal said in a press briefing in New Delhi on August 11.

A new strategic alliance between Turkey, Pakistan and Saudi Arabia was finalised after nearly a year of negotiations, Reuters reported.

The conflict has heightened instability across the region, including attacks by Iran-backed Houthi rebels, prompting the three nations to deepen defence cooperation.

Under the pact, each country will contribute distinct capabilities. Pakistan will provide military personnel and defence manufacturing support.

Iran working to finalise Strait of Hormuz agreement with Oman

ASSOCIATED PRESS n Dubai

Iran said on Monday it is working to finalise a joint statement with Oman on a plan to manage the transit of ships through the Strait of Hormuz. Fully reopening the waterway to commercial shipping has been a key demand of the United States, but it remains unclear whether the deal will meet Washington’s criteria.

The announcement came as the 60-day negotiating period to find a peace deal between the US and Iran was expiring, with no word of an extension and both sides seemingly as far apart as they were two months ago.

Iranian Foreign Affairs spokesperson Esmail Baghaei told reporters in Tehran that “an understanding has been reached regarding the map of the transit route.”

He did not elaborate, but details that have previously emerged suggest the deal would reopen the strait with ships entering through a route close to Iran and exiting through a route close to Oman. Ships would transit without paying fees or tolls during the interim period.

The US has sought an acceptable deal on opening the strait before ending its blockade of Iranian ports and it was not clear whether this would meet Washington’s expectations. Iran effec-



A woman mourns during the funeral of Hezbollah member Ali al-Haj Hassan, his wife and four children who were killed the previous day by an Israeli airstrike, in the southern suburb of Beirut, Lebanon (AP)

tively closed the strait — through which roughly one-fifth of the world’s traded oil supplies passed before the war — after Israel and the US attacked the country on February 28.

Baghaei conceded the talks with Oman have gone slowly, “but we had planned, and still plan, to finalise the understanding in the form of a package: the map plus a joint statement.”

His comments came as a 60-day deadline for finding an agreement to end the war expired, with no signs of a deal between the US and Iran.

Kushner meeting with Netanyahu

West Asia negotiator Jared Kushner, US President Donald Trump’s son-in-law, was holding meetings with Israel’s Prime

Minister Benjamin Netanyahu, the day after he had talks with Hamas chief Khalil al-Hayya in Egypt on disarmament.

The meetings with Netanyahu came after the Israeli leader rejected a 15-point, US-backed road map to move the truce deal forward in Gaza.

Hamas says it has agreed to the road map, which includes disarmament, and the group is urging mediators and the US-created Board of Peace to “compel” Israel to sign on as well.

But Israel, which under the road map must withdraw from Gaza, says Hamas must fully disarm before any Israeli withdrawal will occur.

Israeli troops occupy about 60 per cent of the strip and Netanyahu has previously threatened to advance further. (AP)

Belgian wildfire approaches Germany despite rain

ASSOCIATED PRESS
n Sourbrodt

One of Belgium’s biggest ever wildfires blazed out of control Monday even as cooler weather and rain eased conditions for firefighters, while in Greece a fire briefly flared up near the main airport on the outskirts of Athens.

Europe is sweltering through one of its hottest and driest summers on record, which a recent study said was fuelled by climate change.

Belgium’s King Philippe interrupted his summer vacation to visit emergency services fighting the wildfire in the eastern High Fens, about eight kilometres from the German border, as it spread



east after moving into a pine forest on Sunday.

The fire in Liege province has burned an estimated 30 square kilometres, leaving blackened trees and smoldering ground. The scent of wood smoke drifted through the fog-drenched forest early on Monday. Dozens of firefighters were aided by aircraft sent from Norway, Sweden, Germany and the Netherlands and local police with drones monitoring the fires after a much-welcomed cold front brought overnight rain.

KEY CORP LIMITED

CIN No.-L65921UP1985PLC007547
Regd. Office-16/16-A, Civil Lines,Kanpur - 208001
email: keycorppltd@gmail.com | Ph. No. 8604627809

NOTICE OF EXTRA-ORDINARY GENERAL MEETING,
E-VOTING AND E-VOTING INFORMATION

NOTICE is hereby given that an Extra-ordinary General Meeting (“EGM”) of Members of **Key Corp Limited** (the “Company”) will be held on **Tuesday, September 8, 2026 at 11:00 A.M. (IST)** through Video Conferencing/ Other Audio-Visual Means (“VC/OAVM”) facility, to transact the business as set-out in the Notice convening the EGM (“Notice”) in compliance with the applicable provisions of the Companies Act, 2013 (“Act”), and Rules made thereunder and the SEBI (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015 (“SEBI Listing Regulations”), read with MCA’s General Circular No. 20/2020 dated 05.05.2020, General Circular No.02/2022 dated 05.05.2022. General Circular No. 10/2022 dated 28.12.2022, General circular No. 09/2023 dated 25.09.2023 and General circular No. 09/2024 dated 19.09.2024 and SEBI Circulars, without the physical presence of the Members at a common venue, to transact the business as set-out in the Notice. Notice has been sent on **Monday, August 17, 2026**, through E-mail to those Members whose E-mail address are registered with the Company or Registrar and Share Transfer Agent (“RTA”) or Company or their respective Depository Participants (“DP”) in accordance with the MCA Circulars read with SEBI Circulars. The Notice is also available on the website of the Company (www.keycorppltd.com), Stock Exchange (www.bseindia.com) and Central Depository Services (India) Limited (CDSL) (www.evotingindia.com). In compliance with the provisions of Section 108 of the Act read with the Companies (Management and Administration) Rules, 2014, Regulation 44 of the SEBI Listing Regulations, Secretarial Standard-2 issued by the Institute of Company Secretaries of India and the MCA Circulars, the Company has engaged the services of CDSL to provide the Members with the facility to cast their vote electronically through Remote E-Voting (prior to EGM) and E-Voting (during the EGM) on resolution set forth in the Notice.

The cut-off date for the purpose of ascertaining the eligibility of Members to avail e-voting facility will be on **Tuesday, September 01, 2026** (“Cut-off date”). The voting right of Members shall be in proportion to the equity shares held by them in the paid-up equity share capital of the Company as on the Cut-off date. A person, whose name appears in the Register of Members or list of Beneficial Owners maintained by the Depositories as on the Cut-off date, shall only be entitled to join the EGM, avail the remote e-voting facility and e-voting during the EGM. A person who is not a Member as on the Cut-off date should treat this Notice for information purposes only.

Remote e-voting shall commence on **Friday, the 04th September, 2026 at 09:00 A.M. (IST)** and shall end on **Monday, the 07th September, 2026 (IST)**. During this period, Members may cast their vote electronically. Thereafter, the remote e-voting module shall be disabled by CDSL for voting. Members who would have cast their vote by remote e-voting prior to the EGM may also participate in the EGM through VC/OAVM facility but shall not be entitled to cast their vote again through e-voting facility available during the EGM. Further, only those Members who have not cast their vote on the resolution through remote e-voting and are otherwise not barred from doing so, shall be eligible to vote through e-voting system during the EGM.

Once the Member cast vote on a resolution, Member shall not be allowed to change it subsequently. Detailed procedure/ instructions for remote e-voting, joining the EGM, registration of e-mail address, obtaining login details and e-voting during the EGM are provided in the Notice.

Any person, who acquires share(s) and becomes a Member of the Company after the electronic dispatch of Notice and holds shares as on the Cut-off date, may obtain the Login ID and Password by following the instructions as mentioned in the Notice or by sending a request at helpdesk.evoting@cdslindia.com. However, if a person is already registered with NSDL or CDSL for remote e-voting, then existing User ID and Password can be used to cast vote as per instructions provided in the Notice.

If you have not registered your e-mail address with the Company/RTA/DP, you may please follow the below instructions:

1. For Physical shareholders - Please provide necessary details like Folio No., Name of Shareholder, scanned copy of the Share Certificate (front and back), PAN (self attested scanned copy of PAN card), AADHAR (self attested scanned copy of Aadhar Card) by Email to www.keycorppltd.com.

2. For Demat shareholders - Please update your Email Id & Mobile No. with your respective Depository Participant (DP)

3. For Individual Demat shareholders – Please update your Email Id & Mobile No. with your respective Depository Participant (DP) which is mandatory while e-Voting & joining virtual meetings through Depository.

In case you have any queries or issues regarding e-voting, you may refer the Frequently Asked Questions (“FAQs”) and e-voting manual available at www.evotingindia.com, under help section or write an email to helpdesk.evoting@cdslindia.com or contact Mr. Rakesh Dalvi, Sr. Manager, Central Depository Services (India) Limited, A Wing, 25th Floor, Marathon Futrex, Mafatlal Mill Compounds, N.M. Joshi Marg, Lower Parel (East), Mumbai - 400013 or call at toll free no. 18002109911.

By Order of the Board
(G.D. MAHESHWARI)
Executive Director

Place: Kanpur
Date: 17.08.2026

LOST & FOUND

I Have Lost Original DDA Fifth & Final Demand Letter, NOC For Electric & Water, Possession Slip, General Power of Attorney/Special Power of Attorney/ Dt. 04.09.1992 In The Name of Vishnu Kumar Sureka, & Agreement To Sell & Purchase Etc., Dt. 04.09.1992 In The Name of Quality Synthetic Industries Ltd. In Respect of Flat No.1633, Sector-B, Pocket-1, Vasant Kunj, New Delhi-110070
FIR-L.R. No. 538211/2026 Dt. 14.08.2026

Any Person (s) claiming any right/ Interest having any objection or found in Possession of Original Documents. May Write/Contact with above named Person at above Address/Phone No. 9718323400 within 10 days from the date of Publication of this Notice.
Date: 18.08.2026
Place: New Delhi

PUBLIC NOTICE

I, Purneti Swati W/o Narendra Kumar Purneti R/o WZ-138/1, Naraina Village, Ring Road, Delhi-110028 declare that name of mine and my husband have been wrongly written as Swati Purneti and Narendra Kumar P respectively in my minor daughter namely Purneti Sakshi, aged 14 years in her birth certificate Regd. No. DCB 21412012.The actual names of mine and my husband are Purneti Swati and Narendra Kumar Purneti respectively.

Public Notice
This is to inform the general public that Mrs. Sushila is the Possessor of the Plot No. C-60, area measuring 49 Sq. Yds. i.e. 3282 Sq. Mtrs., out of Kharsa no. 467 & 468, Situated at Ram Park, Village Loni, Pargana & Tehsil Loni, District Ghaziabad. She is in possession through Regd. GFI in Blood Relation. ATS and Will dated 08.09.2026 as GPA doc. no. 2120 executed by Mr. Gaurav in favour of Mrs. Sushila in respect of said plot. Mrs. Sushila intends to transfer the ownership of above said Plot by way of Sale Deed to Mr. Sanju and Mr. Mitthesh Devi. Subsequently, Mr. Sanju and Mr. Mitthesh Devi are in the process of mortgaging the said plot with SMFG India Home Finance Co. Ltd. Any objections or concerns regarding this transaction should be raised within a period of 7 days from the date of this public notice. Any objections submitted after the completion of this 7-days period will not be considered binding with respect to the said property or the interests of our client. If anyone wishes to raise an objection, please do so on or before the stipulated period. For legal advice, Mr. Varun: North (Advocate & Legal Consultants) at Office No. 11, 1st Floor, Building No. A-44/A, Sector-16, Noida, Uttar Pradesh-201301 (Landline)-91012-04499711, e-mail: accounts@lvnort.in

The Pioneer

Classified

CHANGE OF NAME

I, Rameshri, Mother of- JC-472909H Sub Naval Singh, R/o- Vill/ Po- Mehchana, Dist- Gurgaon- 122504, have changed my name from Rameshri to Rameshwari, vide affidavit dated 17/08/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.
I, Salammal A, W/o- No. 14865778K NK/SHT Moorthi V, R/o- Vill- Gevarankottai, Po- Bandarahalli, Teh- Karimangalam Dist- Dharmapuri, Tamil Nadu- 635123, have changed my name from Salammal A to Salammal Moorthi, vide affidavit dated 17/08/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.
I, Soumya W/o- No.15217161P Hav(Opr) Gopu Anantharamulu, R/o- Vill & PO- Kolanoor, Teh- Odela, Dist- Karimnagar, Telangana- 505162, have changed my name from Soumya to Gopu Soumya, vide affidavit dated 17/08/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.
I, Divya Verma W/o Shri Pradeep Verma R/o Flat No- 201, 11/67, Krishna Home, Sec-3, Rajender Nagar, Sahibabad, Ghaziabad, Uttar Pradesh 201005 do hereby change my name savita kumari to divya verma for all future purposes.

I, Gaurav Tyagi, S/o Sh. Rajinder Tyagi, R/o D-7/A, Street No- 9, West Jyoti Nagar, Near Guru Harkrishan Public School, Gokal Pur, PO: Gokal Puri, DIST: North East Delhi, Delhi-110094, do hereby solemnly affirm that in my daughter's school record and other documents her name wrongly mentioned as Devanshi instead of Devanshi Tyagi. Both Devanshi Tyagi & Devanshi is one and same person. With Affidavit No. **IN-DL77513818784611Y.**
I, Gaurav Tyagi, S/o Sh. Rajinder Tyagi, R/o D-7/A, Street No- 9, West Jyoti Nagar, Near Guru Harkrishan Public School, Gokal Pur, PO: Gokal Puri, DIST: North East Delhi, Delhi-110094, do hereby solemnly affirm that in my daughter's school record and other documents her name wrongly mentioned as Anukriti instead of Anukriti Tyagi. Both Anukriti & Anukriti Tyagi is one and same person. With Affidavit No. **IN-DL77514547249410Y.**
I, Mahender, Father of- No.3213412M Nk Gajender, R/o- Mana Patti, Aurangabad, Teh- Hodal, Dist- Palwal, Haryana- 121105, have changed my name from Mahender to Mahender Singh, vide affidavit dated 17/08/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

SR NO	NAME OF DEPARTMENT	NAME OF WORK NOTICE TENDER	OPENING DATE CLOSING DATE	AMOUNT / EMD (APPROX.) IN RUPEES	WEBSITE OF THE DEPARTMENT	NODAL OFFICER/CONTACT DETAILS/EMAIL
1	PWD B&R, KARNAL	UP-GRADATION OF CHC TO 50 BEDDED HOSPITAL AT TARAORI DISTT. KARNAL (PDG. HVAC ONLY)	15.08.2026 24.08.2026	138.48 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	01842265696 pwd-eeed-karnal@hry.nic.in
2	PWD B&R, KARNAL	CONST. OF 100 BEDDED MCH BUILDING IN THE CAMPUS OF CIVIL HOSPITAL IN SONIPAT (PDG. MGP AND ALLIED MATERIAL WORK)	14.08.2026 26.08.2026	750.77 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	01842265696 pwd-eeed-karnal@hry.nic.in
3	PANCHAYATI RAJ,AMBALA	HGVY CONSTRUCTION OF IPB STREET FROM HIGHWAY TOWARD KHERA MANDIR AT VILLAGE SHAHZADPUR BLOCK SHAHZADPUR DISTT. AMBALA	14.08.2026 20.08.2026	13.44 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	0171-2551368 prexeeng.amb@hry.nic.in
4	PANCHAYATI RAJ, REWARI	CONSTRUCTION OF GRAM SACHIVALAY AT VILLAGE BERLI KHURD BLOCK JATUSANA DISTRICT REWARI	14.08.2026 20.08.2026	60.13 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	9466112077 xenpr.rwr@gmail.com
5	FOREST DEPARTMENT, HISAR	11 FOREST BLOCK WISE TENDER FLOATED BY HISAR FOREST DIVISION FOR CAMPA & STATE SCHEME PLANTATION WORKS IN HISAR, HANSI AND ADAMPUR RANGE UNDER JURISDICTION OF HISAR FOREST DIVISION.	15.08.2026 21.08.2026	522.61 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	9992222537 dfohisar.t@gmail.com
6	PUBLIC HEALTH ENGINEERING,HISAR	ENHANCING THE FUNCTIONING AND OPERATIONAL EFFICIENCY OF THE STP 40 MLD RISHI NAGAR HISAR (JAL HI AMRIT INITIATIVE) + 1 WORKS	CLOSING DATE 25.08.2026	166.81 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	01662-247033 eephisar@gmail.com
7	IRRIGATION & WATER RESOURCES DEPARTMENT HARYANA, SIRSA	RE-CONSTRUCTION OF W/C CROSSING AT RD 83600 OF MANGALA DIRECT MINOR. + 1 WORKS	CLOSING DATE 20.08.2026	2.97 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	01666235721 xenghagar@gmail.com
8	FOREST DEPARTMENT, BHIWANI	TENDER FOR BAWANI KHERA BLOCK MAINTENANCE OF PLANTS CAMPA SCHEME & 16 OTHER WORKS	04.08.2026 19.08.2026	740.24 LACS	www.haryanaeprocurement.gov.in	01664-242430 dfo.bhiwani@yahoo.com
FOR FURTHER INFORMATION KINDLY VISIT www.etenders.hry.nic.in						RO 48288-I-27-7

NORTHERN RAILWAY

E-TENDER NOTICE

Sr. Divisional Electrical Engineer/Traction Distribution, DRM's Office, State Entry Road, New Delhi for & on behalf of President of India, invites open e-tender for the under noted work:

1 Name of Work with its location

Provision of Model OHE in TRD Depots at TKD, PTNR, GHM, MDNR, MUT, SMQL & GZB over Delhi Division.

2 Approx. Cost of work

Rs. 33,12,347.21/-

3 Earnest Money Deposit

Rs. 66,300/-

4 E-Tender Bid Online Submission Period

25.08.2026 (00:00 Hrs.) to 08.09.2026 (15:00 Hrs.)

5 E-Tender Bid Submission End Date & E-Tender Open Date & Time

08.09.2026 (15.00 hrs.)

6 Fund Allocation

07041032

7 Website particulars where complete details of tender documents can be seen

www.ireps.gov.in

E-Tender No.: 26-TRD-NDLS-2026-27 Dated: 17.08.2026 2846/2026

SERVING CUSTOMERS WITH A SMILE

SOUTH CENTRAL RAILWAY

Follow us on @SCRailwaysIndia
Details of the Tender Notices of S.C. Railway can be seen on our website: www.scr.indianrailways.gov.in

TENDER NOTICE No. : 107_DRM_W_HYB_26
Dated : 14-08-2026.

On behalf of the President of India, Divisional Railway Manager/ Works, Hyderabad Division, South Central Railway, Secunderabad invites Open Tenders for the following works through e-procurement upto to 15:00 hours of 07-09-2026.

Tender No. : 107_DRM_W_HYB_26.
Name of the work : Hyderabad division : MUE-SC-DHNE section : Reconditioning of worn out CMS Crossings, worn out Stock rails/ Tongue rails of Points and crossings by Robotic welding. Approximate Value Rs. : 52,57,153/- Earnest Money Deposit Rs. : 1,05,200/-
For further details visit the website www.ireps.gov.in

Divisional Railway Manager / Works / Hyderabad.

TENDER NOTICE

Senior Divisional Electrical Engineer/Maintenance/Hyderabad acting for and on behalf of The President of India invites E-Tenders against following Tenders Closing date 10-09-2026, 15:00. Bidders will be able to submit their original / revised bids up to closing date and time only. Manual offers are not allowed against this tender, and any such manual offer received shall be ignored.

Sl. No. : 1. Description of work : Tender No. : 27-GSU-26-27-Sr.DEE-M-HYB : Hyderabad Division :- GATI SHAKTI : Malakagiri Yard re-modelling : Provision of down loop line and two (02) additional lines - Electrical Arrangements.
Approximate Cost (Rs.) : Rs.69,75,746/- Earnest Money Deposit (Rs.) : Rs.1,39,500/- Completion period : 12 Months. Date of Closing : 10-09-2026.

Sl. No. : 2. Description of work : Tender No. : 28-OEW-26-27-Sr.DEE-M-HYB : Hyderabad Division :- Replacement of Coda Life Completed AC Plants in Dialysis Centre, Rail Kalarang, Rail Nilayam Auditorium.
Approximate Cost (Rs.) : Rs.4,58,21,205/- Earnest Money Deposit (Rs.) : Rs.9,16,400/- Completion period : 12 Months. Date of Closing : 10-09-2026.

Sl. No. : 3. Description of work : Tender No. : 29-OSW-26-27-Sr.DEE-M-HYB : Hyderabad Division :- 1) Construction of Running Room 20 Beds Capacity at MLY Electrical Arrangements. 2) General Electrical Arrangements for Relay Hut to accommodate Signalling Interlocking equipment of Automatic Block Signalling (ABS) Model Works in IRISST.
Approximate Cost (Rs.) : Rs.74,99,913/- Earnest Money Deposit (Rs.) : Rs.1,50,000/- Completion period : 12 Months. Date of Closing : 10-09-2026.

Website particulars : www.ireps.gov.in

Notice Board Location where complete details of tender can be seen : Office of the Sr.DEE/M/HYB, Hyderabad Bhavan, Secunderabad - 500071.

Sr. Divisional Electrical Engineer, A665 (M), Hyderabad.

For further tender conditions / details and for downloading the tender documents, Please visit website at <https://www.ireps.gov.in> or www.scr.indianrailways.gov.in

PROSPECT

Thought-provoking journey of Indus Cities to Harsha's Empire

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE

New Delhi

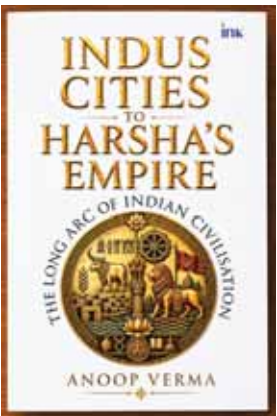
Civilisations rarely develop in straight lines. They evolve through encounters, conflicts, intellectual debates and institutional change.

In *Indus Cities to Harsha's Empire: The Long Arc of Indian Civilisation*, Anoop Verma explores ancient India through this expansive lens, tracing nearly three millennia from the Indus Valley Civilisation to the age of Emperor Harsha.

Across almost 500 pages, Verma moves beyond a conventional chronology of dynasties and battles to examine what he sees as the evolution of the Indian civilisational mind.

The Vedic corpus, Upanishadic thought, Buddhism and Jainism, the epics, the Mauryan and Gupta periods, and the rise of regional powers are presented as interconnected stages in a continuing intellectual and cultural process.

A major strength of the book is its interdisciplinary approach. Archaeology, scripture, philosophy, literature and political history are brought together to examine enduring questions about authority, morality, social order and the relationship between the individual and the cosmos.



The transition to the Vedic world, the philosophical transformation represented by the Upanishads, and the emergence of Buddhism and Jainism demonstrate that ancient Indian thought developed through debate rather than simple continuity.

Similarly, the Ramayana and Mahabharata are treated as repositories of ethical and political dilemmas rather than merely literary or religious texts.

The Mauryan section effectively contrasts the pragmatic statecraft of the Arthashastra with Ashoka's emphasis on dharma and public welfare.

The Gupta period, meanwhile, is presented less as an isolated "golden age" than as a period of cultural and intellectual synthesis.

Chhattisgarh Governor flags off 6 REC-supported mobile medical units worth `7.21 cr

Under the CSR initiative of REC Limited, Governor of Chhattisgarh, Ramen Deka, flagged off six Mobile Medical Units (MMUs), worth `7.21 crore, at Lok Bhawan, Chhattisgarh, on August 15, 2026.

The flag-off ceremony was held in the presence of Satyaban Sahoo, Chief Project Manager (CPM), Regional Office Raipur, REC Limited, along with officials from REC Limited and the Indian Red Cross Society (IRCS), Chhattisgarh.

Through this CSR initiative, REC Limited aims to bridge healthcare gaps and strengthen last-mile healthcare delivery in underserved areas of Chhattisgarh, bringing essential services closer to communities.

The initiative reflects REC Limited's commitment to inclusive and sustainable development and contributes to the vision of a healthier and more inclusive Viksit Bharat.

(PNS)

Govt to announce banking reform panel soon: FM

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE

New Delhi

Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman on Monday said the Government would soon constitute a high-level panel on 'Banking for Viksit Bharat' to draw up a blueprint to create lenders capable of meeting the financing needs of a developed India.

In this year's Budget, the finance minister had proposed a high-level committee on 'Banking for Viksit Bharat' to comprehensively review the sector and align it with India's next phase of growth.

Addressing the two-day PSB Confluence, Sitharaman said, "The intensive discussions of today and tomorrow come at a time we expect the announcement on the high-powered committee to look into banking for Viksit Bharat. Sooner, the committee will be announced."

She expressed hope that the deliberation at the two-day meeting would provide substantive material for the committee also to look at.

"So the committee would probably have that material before them even as they deliberate. And even as they deliberate, to give us their thoughts and also the recommendations which will help us to clearly understand where the committee wants India to go towards Viksit Bharat and in that the role of banks," she said. Emphasising



(From left to right): RBI Executive Director R Lakshmi Kanth Rao, SBI Chairman Challa Sreenivasulu Setty, Union Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman, DFS Secretary Sanjay Lohiya and others during the inaugural session of the two-day 'PSB Confluence' (PSB Manthan) ideation conclave in New Delhi on Monday

that the Viksit Bharat goal of 2047 is actually not too far away, she said, "Your NPAs are at the lowest ever Indian banking has seen, and therefore there cannot be a better position of strength with which you can take on reforms."

"I propose setting up a high-level committee on 'Banking for Viksit Bharat' to comprehensively review the sector and align it with India's next phase of growth, while safeguarding financial stability, inclusion and consumer protection," she had said in the Budget speech on February 1.

Speaking at Monday's event, Financial Services Secretary Sanjay Lohia said it is imperative for public sector banks to sustain the current momentum, especially as

competition is becoming sharper. "Technology is reshaping business models, customer experiences are evolving, and new areas of economic activity are emerging rapidly," he said.

Therefore, State-owned banks must continue to strengthen their competitiveness, growth within the domestic financial landscape, and against evolving global benchmarks, he said.

"This will require the institutions to anticipate opportunities, deepen sectoral expertise, and continuously adapt their capabilities, products and business models," he said.

"Financial institutions also have an important role where specialised expertise and financing structures can complement the scale and reach of banks," he said.

YEIDA board meeting: Revenues surge 90% as projects gain pace

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE

Noida

The 92nd Board Meeting of the Yamuna Expressway Industrial Development Authority (YEIDA) held on Monday. The meeting reviewed the Authority's financial figures and approved several important development projects.

In the financial year 2025-26, receipts up to 31 July stood at `974.37 crore, while in 2026-27 the same figure rose to `1,853.74 crore — an increase of 90.25 per cent. Under the industrial/mixed land scheme, state receipts totalled `1,195.99 crore. Expenditure also increased to `3,690.64 crore.

Key decisions include the establishment of a medical college on



500 acres in Sectors 13 and 14, a university/township on 480 acres in Sector 14, 36 acres in Sector 34, and a modern international stadium on 50 acres in Sector 23B. An international bus stand has also been proposed in Sector 23B near Noida Airport.

In Sector 6, approval was

granted for a Taiwan-based industry/Taiwan City on 300 acres and a Pharmaceutical Formulation Manufacturing Cluster on 100-125 acres.

The cluster will operate as per GMP standards and is expected to develop the Yamuna Expressway region into a leading pharma manufacturing hub. A medical device park with FDA-compliant testing facilities and a technical expert committee will also be set up.

In addition, the construction of a culvert on the service road in Village Agra and a proposal to revise land rates for farmers were approved. These decisions are aimed at promoting industrial growth, investment and employment generation.

IDFC FIRST Bank earns first international credit rating



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE

Mumbai

IDFC FIRST Bank has announced that S&P Global Ratings has assigned the bank its inaugural international investment-grade issuer credit ratings of 'BBB-' long-term and 'A-3' short-term, with a Stable Outlook.

Commenting on the rating, Sudhanshu Jain — Chief Financial Officer and Head Corporate Centre, said, "We are delighted to receive our first international investment grade Rating from S&P with a Stable Outlook. We view this rating as an important milestone in our progress. The investment-grade rating is expected to enhance the Bank's standing with global investors and financial institutions, support access to international funding markets, facilitate Standby Letter of Credit (SBLC) lines, strengthen foreign currency funding at the Bank's GIFT City International Banking Unit, support mobilisation of FCNR(B) deposits, and deepen correspondent banking and cross-border trade finance relationships."

UPSIDA steps up industrial infrastructure development

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE

Lucknow



Balkar Singh

Under the leadership of Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath, the Uttar Pradesh State Industrial Development Authority (UPSIDA) is continuously working towards strengthening and expanding industrial infrastructure facilities across the State in effective implementation of the Government of Uttar Pradesh's policies relating to industrial development and investment promotion.

In line with the objective of making Uttar Pradesh a 1 trillion economy, UPSIDA is committed to providing better infrastructure facilities in industrial areas and creating a conducive environment for investment and industries. In this regard, the Chief Executive Officer of UPSIDA, Balkar Singh Ji, conducted a comprehensive site inspection of the Surajpur Industrial Area on Monday.

During the inspection, he reviewed the infrastructure facilities available in the industrial area, the ongoing and proposed infrastructure development works, and the arrangements related to the smooth functioning of industrial units.

The Chief Executive Officer obtained information from the concerned officers regarding the

progress of various development and maintenance works and directed that all works be completed within the stipulated timeline, as per prescribed standards and with high quality.

He made it clear that any laxity in the quality and timely completion of development works would not be acceptable.

The Chief Executive Officer directed that the annual maintenance works in the industrial area be expedited, with particular emphasis on ensuring regular and proper cleaning of drains, maintenance of parks, beautification, and effective execution of landscaping-related works.

He stated that ensuring a clean, well-maintained and better environment in industrial areas is extremely important not only for the smooth functioning of industrial units but also from the perspective of promoting investment.

POWERGRID wins PMIS Partner Company Award

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE

Gurugram

Power Grid Corporation of India Limited (POWERGRID), a Maharatna PSU under Ministry of Power was conferred with PMIS Recognition of Partner Company Award under the category 'Innovation in Exit Pathways' on Friday, 14th August 2026.

The award was received by Yatindra Dwivedi, Director (Personnel) along with BK Mundu (ED-HRD) and team from Pallavi Jain Govil, Secretary (MCA) in the presence



of Anshuman Patnaik, Additional Secretary and D Balamurugan, Joint Secretary in the ceremony held by Ministry of Corporate Affairs at India Habitat Centre, New Delhi.

To provide better employment opportunities, POWERGRID has facilitated in coordination with Sector Skill Council ie Power Sector Skill Council (PSSC), uploaded the details of all PMIS interns, who have undergone training in POWERGRID, in the Rozgaar portal of PSSC and all the agencies working in the field of power transmission have been informed suitably about the exit pathways.

verka		
THE PUNJAB STATE COOPERATIVE MILK PRODUCERS FEDERATION LTD. SCO 153-155, SECTOR 34-A, CHANDIGARH-160022, EPABX NO. 0172-5041812,66		
Notice Inviting Tender		
www.verka.coop		
Tenders are hereby invited for the purchase and supply of following items:-		
Sr. No.	Name of Work/Item	Period/Tentative Qty
1.	For Verka Mohali Dairy a) Annual rate contract for the purchase of Nitric Acid (technical grade)(53%-54%). b) Hiring of insulated & refrigerated vehicles with different capacities for supply of Verka milk and milk products. (no's. of vehicles may increased or decreased)	Annual 75 No's
2.	For Verka Hoshiarpur Dairy a) Engaging for labour contractor for outsourced job i.e. Ghee/butter filling in different pack size, Milk/Lassi/ Dahi pouch/ matka/ cup filling, milk reception, can/ tray washing SMP/WMP packing etc. city supply loading, packing material unloading, milk products loading and unloading. b) Operation, repair and maintenance of pouch packing machine (milk, dahi & lassi) including coding on pouches photo sensor. c) e-Tender for the providing plant operators for operation of power plant (02 no's) and ghee plant (02) and CIP technician (04).	
3.	For Verka Sangrur Dairy Hiring of commercial insulated/ refrigerated vehicles for transportation of packed milk and fresh milk products. (For two years with extension up to one year).	Insulated 1.7 ton-2 no's, 3.0 ton-4 no's, 4.0 ton-6no's, 5.0 ton-1 no. Refrigerated 3.0 ton-1 no.
4.	For Verka Gurdaspur Dairy Gurdaspur to Udhampur route refrigerated vehicle for supply of milk & milk products.	02 years/ 09 MT
5.	For Verka Ferozepur Dairy Hiring of insulated road milk tankers for transportation of mixed milk from Milk Chilling Centres Milk Union Ferozepur to other Verka Milk Unions:- a) Capacity 10KL. b)Capacity 10KL.	04 No's 03 No's
6.	For Verka Ludhiana Dairy a) Hiring of :- i. Vehicles (Tempo) for transportation of milk through cans. ii. Powder Plant for conversion of Liquid milk into SMP (skimmed Milk Powder). iii. Insulated road milk tankers for transportations of milk from Verka Ludhiana Dairy to other sister unions, hired powder plant (& vice-versa) within and outside states etc. (capacity > 10 MT-30 MT). b) E-tenders are invited for sale of the unserviceable material for :- i. One Time sale basis. ii. Annual rate contract basis.	03 No's Annual One Job
7.	For Verka Cattle Feed Plant, Chania-ke-Banger a) Transportation of Verka Cattle Feed and mineral feed supplement to various stations in the state of Punjab. b) Rate Contract of Advertisement material. i. Flex Board ii. Flex Banner iii. Glow Sign Board iv. Canopy v. Standoes vi. Gum sheet stickers vii. Dangles	Annual One year
NOTE: 1. For complete details regarding above tender (NIT), please visit our website i.e. www.verka.coop & e Tendering portal i.e. eproc.punjab.gov.in. 2. Corrigendum, if any, will be uploaded on website only.		
General Manager (Purchase)		
1018/12/2026-27/14322		

DAILY SUDOKU

5 6 4 9 8 3

9 3 5

4 7

4 6 5

2 6 8 4

4 1 2

5 7

8 3 9

9 3 4 2

DIFFICULTY RATING: ★★★★★

HOW TO SOLVE IT

Sudoku is a logic puzzle where you fill a 9×9 grid so that numbers 1 to 9 appear once in every row, column, and 3×3 box, using elimination and logical deduction—no maths involved.

SOLUTION (17.8.26)

5 9 2 9 3 6 7 4 1
9 3 1 7 4 8 2 5 6
6 4 7 2 1 5 8 9 3
2 6 4 1 5 9 3 8 7
8 1 5 3 6 7 9 2 4
7 9 3 4 8 2 1 6 5
1 2 6 8 7 4 5 3 9
3 5 8 6 9 1 4 7 2
4 7 9 5 2 3 6 1 8

DOUBLE CROSSWORD

TUESDAY | AUGUST 18, 2026

1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8

9 10 11 12 13 14 15 16

17 18 19 20 21 22 23

24 25 26 27 28 29 30 31

ACROSS

1 This can be dynamite! (5)
6 Dump at the roadside (5)
9 Oscar and I slink around in something waterproof (7)
10 Pretend the head of government's in a fine mess! (5)
11 A clever sort of angle (5)
12 Unreliable supporter of hushaby baby (5)
13 Such clothes seem unsuited to indoor use (4,3)
15 Supplied from the safe deposit (3)
17 This lets me out (4)
18 The bird on the wharf (6)

DOWN

2 Jack may be in it (TV, that is) (3,3)
3 In bed, a senior officer can be very persuasive (6)
4 Semi-royal relatives? (3)
5 Berkshire's rugged coast! (5)
6 Graphic illustration of a city in a poor light (7)
7 A measure used in plainchant (4)
8 It presumably has sharp bows (6)
12 Tough as Cassidy? (5)
13 Widow's associates killed by the gardener (5)
14 Bolt a plate while it's hot (5)
15 The head of the family isn't weak (5)

19 It's said to be dismissive (5)
20 Some children, going to church, get pretty wet! (6)
22 Formerly a hundred in a single container (4)
24 Outfit used in Morse transmissions? (3)
25 Inclusive, potentially penetrative (7)
26 Keep shop (5)
27 One sportingly replaced? (5)
28 The kid with the can (5)
29 Dream I'm involved with a fabulous female! (7)
30 Name a favourite piece of verse (5)
31 Approaches a cunning snare (5)

16 Welsh welfare centre in a colourful setting (5)
18 Out of the flood centre, a stick will float (5)
19 Go everywhere while the cat's in a state of rest (7)
21 Live, yes, amid the wild deer! (6)
22 The legitimate position Edison could have been in (6)
23 Vaguely recall where the wine is (6)
25 First among ministers (5)
26 Only a share, but it could be mistaken for the lot! (4)
28 The Boar's Head takes in a lot of wine (3)

SOLUTION (17.8.26)

ACROSS
3 Steps
8 Lj-the
10 Rhine
11 Noo
12 Belle
13 Carry on
15 VIL-L-E-T
18 Tea
19 Defile
21 Retreat
22 Lair
23 Tilt
24 Be-late-d
26 Br-ewer
29 Gen
31 Sh-rew
32 Pens-l-on
34 Sa-Ved
35 Fra
36 Adder
37 Cle-rik
38 Reels
DOWN
1 Final
2 Short-r
4 The-N
5 P-rivet
6 Sheaf
7 Angel
9 Tor
12 Boarder
14 Ye-T
16 Li-Vi-d
17 Tenth
19 Dain-aged
20 Clubs
21 Rid-er
23 Tensely
24 Be-Ware 2
5 Ten
27 R-H-oda
28 Wester
30 Hoary
32 Peel
33 Ire

HISAR SPINNING MILLS LIMITED

9TH K.M. STONE, HISAR BHIWANI ROAD,
V.P.O. DABRA, HISAR - 125005
CIN-L17112HR1992PLC031621, PAN-AAACH3754M
Tel - 01662-297005, Email- hsm12000@rediffmail.com
Website : www.hisarspinningmills.com

STATEMENT OF UNAUDITED FINANCIAL RESULTS FOR THE QUARTER ENDED 30TH JUNE, 2026

The Un-audited Financial Results of Hisar Spinning Mills Limited ("the Company") along with the Limited Review Report of the Statutory Auditors of the Company for the quarter ended 30th June, 2026 have been reviewed by the Audit Committee and approved by Board of Directors of the Company at their Meeting held on 14th August, 2026, in terms of Regulation 33 of SEBI (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015.

The aforementioned financial results along with the Limited Review Report of the Statutory Auditors thereon are available on the website of BSE Limited (BSE) (www.bseindia.com) and on the Company's website at https://www.hisarspinningmills.com/images/pdf/Hsm1%20Results_30.06.2026.pdf

The same can also be accessed by scanning the QR Code provided above:

By Order of the Board of Directors
for Hisar Spinning Mills Limited

Sd/-

(Anurag Gupta)

Managing Director

DIN: 00192888

Date: 14.08.2026
Place: Chandigarh

 BRIEFLY

East Bengal drub Rajshahi Stars of Bangladesh in AFC Women’s Champions League



Ghanaian attacking midfielder Olivia Anokye scored a brace as East Bengal drubbed Rajshahi Stars FC of Bangladesh 4-0 to begin their AFC Women’s Champions League Preliminary Round campaign in style here on Monday.

Anokye struck in the ninth and 38th minutes, while India internationals Astam Oraon (26th) and Soumya Guguloth (71st) netted once each to wrap up a dominant victory.

East Bengal next face Guam’s Rovers FC on Thursday and hosts Sabah FA on Sunday. Only the group winners will qualify for the group stage of the main tournament.

East Bengal started strongly and were 1-0 up with Anokye stroking home a penalty despite the best efforts of goalkeeper Rupna Chakma. The IWL champions extended their lead when Rimpa Haladar floated a cross beyond Rupna, with Sulanjana Raul reacting quickest at the back post to cut back the ball for Anokye to grab her second of the day.

Rajshahi regrouped after the break, but even though they offered more resistance, they had only one long-range strike from Monika Chakma, which Panthoi Chanu Elangbam saved. The Moshal Girls played the patient game with the advantage in their hands, capitalising on a defensive mistake to add to their scoreline, with Sulanjana playing Soumya through to slot it home.

(PTI)

Colombia defender Jhon Lucumi moves to Juventus



Colombia defender Jhon Lucumi signed for Juventus on Monday for 19.5 million euros (\$22.6 million) after impressing at the World Cup.

Juventus said the 28-year-old center back had signed a four-year contract and the fee paid to Serie A rival Bologna could rise above 22 million euros (\$25.5 million) with performance bonuses.

Lucumi played almost every minute of Colombia’s five games at the World Cup, where the team conceded just one goal, in an opening 3-1 win over Uzbekistan.

Colombia lost in the round of 16 to Switzerland in a penalty shootout, after a 0-0 draw where Lucumi’s header struck the bar in extra time. He was substituted ahead of the shootout. Lucumi played four years at Bologna, including in the Champions League two seasons ago, having first arrived in Europe to join Genk in Belgium.

Juventus plays in the Europa League this season after a sixth-place finish in Serie A.

(AP)

Indian women’s team eyes big win over South Africa

MONA PARTHSARATHI
n Amstelveen

High on confidence after holding Olympic silver medalists and world No. 4 China to a draw, India will look to strengthen their bid for a top-two finish in Pool D when they face South Africa in their second Women’s Hockey World Cup match here on Tuesday.

India, ranked ninth in the world, produced a disciplined display to secure a 2-2 draw against a fancied Chinese side in their tournament opener. The result has given them a valuable point and put them in a good position to qualify for the second round.

England currently lead Pool D following their 4-0 win over South Africa, with China and India next in the standings, while South Africa are fourth.

For the semifinal race the top two teams from each pool will be divided into two



groups (E and F) of four teams each. Each team will play matches against the opponents they did not face in the first round.

A team’s result in the first round against the progressing team from its pool will be carried forward in second

round. It means that India and China will not play each other if they reach the second round and their one point each from the draw will be carried forward.

For India, Tuesday’s game is, therefore, an opportunity to put themselves firmly in

control of their qualification hopes. A win over 18th-ranked South Africa would not only boost their chances of finishing in the top two but also provide momentum ahead of their final pool game.

“We don’t have to worry

about the other teams’ positions, but we need to maintain this momentum in the upcoming matches while avoiding complacency,” coach Sjoerd Marijne said after the China game.

India showed plenty of promise in their opening match. Drag-flicker Deepika converted a penalty corner and also earned another, while World Cup debutants Sunelita Toppo, Ishika and Shilpi Dabas displayed composure well beyond their experience.

Navneet Kaur, who was named Player of the Tournament at the World Cup Qualifiers, has also carried her impressive form into the tournament and will be one of India’s key attacking threats.

However, Marijne knows there is room for improvement, particularly in possession and ball retention.

India controlled the opening quarter and went into half-time with a 2-1 lead,

but their intensity dropped after the break. They sat deeper in the third quarter, allowing China to take control and eventually find the equaliser.

“We scored a penalty corner and a field goal, but I’m not happy with the third quarter. We need to work on ball possession and ball retention. The team must have felt relieved after the draw in the first match,” Marijne said.

South Africa’s 0-4 loss to England means they will enter the contest under pressure, but India will not be taking their lower-ranked opponents lightly.

The Indian team’s best finish at the World Cup came at the inaugural edition in 1974, when they finished fourth under captain Ajinder Kaur.

Their fourth-place finish at the Tokyo Olympics under Marijne had raised hopes of another strong showing on the global stage.

(PTI)

This is probably my last year in football, says Cristiano Ronaldo

ASSOCIATED PRESS n Riyadh

Cristiano Ronaldo says this Saudi Pro League season is likely to be the last of his professional career.

The 41-year-old superstar’s contract with Riyadh club Al-Nassr, signed in December 2022, expires next June, and he has told Vogue magazine that another is unlikely.

“This is probably my last year of football, and I want to leave a spectacular legacy,” Ronaldo said.

The Portugal forward, who has scored 976 career goals, married long-time partner, Georgina Rodriguez, earlier this month.

“I have my future all mapped out,” he said. “I have so many things to keep me busy that to tell you just one thing is hard. Because football could leave a big hole, you have to fill your time in various ways, not just one.

“And also have more fun, travel more, watch and play padel, which I really like, and continue to enjoy what I’ve earned — what we’ve earned. Because after all, it’s been 25 years with a lot of sacrifice.”

The 2026-27 SPL season is Ronaldo’s 25th as a professional. During his career, he has won five Ballon d’Or awards and five UEFA



Champions League titles.

Ronaldo’s 28 league goals last season helped Al-Nassr become champion of Saudi Arabia in May to secure his first trophy since arriving in Riyadh, and a first league title for the club since 2019.

After returning from his wedding, he missed Al-Nassr’s first game of its title defense on Saturday, watching from the sidelines as it opened with a 3-0 win over Al-Fateh. “Cristiano is here today, and he is always present with us,” Al-Nassr coach Ange Postecoglou said after the game.

Ronaldo could play against

Al-Diriayah in the King’s Cup on Tuesday.

“The most important thing now is recovery, especially as we have only two days after this match,” former Tottenham Hotspur and Nottingham Forest coach Postecoglou said.

Ronaldo’s comments came days after long-time rival Lionel Messi revealed that, following his father’s death, he may soon retire.

“I don’t know how to carry on,” Messi, 39, said. “I used to just play football, and now I’m really not sure if I’ll carry on doing it for much longer.”

SAUMJOYOTI S CHOUDHURY
n New Delhi

Badminton has become as much a mental game as it is physical, said reigning European women’s singles champion Kirsty Gilmour as she compared the modern playing style to a game of chess.

She said badminton has evolved over the years to become a sport in which mental fortitude plays as big a role as physical tenacity.

“There is a man-to-man match happening and there is also a chess game happening at the same time. Just trying to stretch one area and open up another area. I am really working on the mental side of my game along with physical side, which has become crucial,” the world number 35 Scottish shuttler said.

Gilmour crashed out of the World Championships after losing to fifth seed Han Yue of China 22-20 13-21 13-21 in the opening round that began here on Monday.

Describing the ongoing event as markedly better than the India open held at the same venue earlier this year, the 32-year-old Gilmour said she was pleased to see



the availability of sanitary napkins in women’s washrooms. This is Gilmour’s 10th appearance at the world event since her debut in 2013.

“I think it’s great. We plan as much as we can for that but sometimes our bodies have different ideas and plans, different hormones. So I think just we have toilet rules, we should have sanitary products as well.

“I am very proud to come from Scotland because it is the first country in the world to make it mandatory for public places to have sanitary products. I would really love to see uptake here and in other countries,” she said. She is quite pleased with

the upgraded arrangements for the ongoing mega-event. The India Open was marred by images of pigeon poop on playing courts and the spotting of a monkey in the spectator stands. Adding to the chaos was Delhi’s poor air quality and the freezing conditions inside the venue.

Stung by the criticism that came from players as well as observers of the game, the Sports Authority of India (SAI) along with the Badminton Association of India (BAI) carried out renovation of the Indira Gandhi Indoor Stadium.

Gilmour said the drift is an issue in the ongoing event but it is the same for all shuttlers.

(PTI)

Praggnanandhaa draws with Aronian; remains joint 2nd

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
n St Louis (USA)

India’s R Praggnanandhaa played out another draw with GM Levon Aronian in the sixth round of the Sinquefeld cup, part of the Grand Chess tour.

The Indian GM remained in joint second spot with 3.5 points with just three rounds remaining.

Wesley So of United States remained in sole lead on four points that saw just one decisive game out of a possible five in the \$475,000 prize money tournament. For the record, Wesley drew with Maxime Vachier-Lagrave of France. GM Praggnanandhaa, along with Vachier-Lagrave and German Vincent Keymer shares the second spot while the American trio of top seed Fabiano Caruana, Sevan



Samuels and Aronian are sharing the fifth spot on three points each.

Anish Giri of Holland is next in queue with World Championship contender

Javokhir Sindarov of Uzbekistan while Dutchman Jorden van Foreest is in last spot with just a sole point in his bag. Praggnanandhaa tried his best to complicate

matters against Aronian but the former Armenian was quite up to the task in defending a tricky middle game. The Indian at a point lost two pawns in the middle but made a.

Anish Giri was the lone winner of the day at the expense of Foreest. The former launched a decisive middle game attack on the black king and succeeded when his compatriot collapsed one more time.

Results round 6: Anish Giri (Ned, 2.5) beat Jorden Van Foreest (Ned, 1); Maxime Vachier-Lagrave (Fra, 3.5) drew with Wesley So (Usa, 4); Sevan Samuels (Usa, 3) drew with Vincent Keymer (Ger, 3.5); R Praggnanandhaa (Ind, 3.5) drew with Levon Aronian (Usa, 3); Javokhir Sindarov (Uzb, 2.5) drew with Fabiano Caruana (Usa, 3).

Premier League is back and uncertainty pervades start of post-Guardiola era

STEVE DOUGLAS
n London

The post-Pep Guardiola era is getting underway in English soccer amid uncertainty and upheaval - not just at Manchester City but across the whole of the Premier League.

Get this: Heading into the new top-flight season beginning Friday, nine clubs have new permanent managers - an unprecedented number at the start of an English top-flight campaign. At age 33, Fabian Hürzeler is the fifth longest-serving coach in the Premier League ... and he has been at Brighton for just two years.

The biggest vacuum needing to be filled is at City, following the departure of

Guardiola after 10 record-breaking years in charge. Good luck following that, Enzo Maresca — especially after the team’s lamentable performance in the Community Shield loss to Arsenal on Sunday. Among the other top clubs with new coaches are Liverpool (Andoni Iraola), Chelsea (Xabi Alonso) and Newcastle (Matthias Jaissle) — all of which competed in the Champions League last season.

Heck, it makes Roberto De Zerbi — appointed by Tottenham on March 31 to escape relegation — and Michael Carrick - installed as interim manager at Manchester United for the second half of last season - seem like veritable



veterans.

It also makes Arsenal, the reigning champion, appear a haven of stability as Mikel Arteta goes into his seventh full season at the helm as by far the league’s longest-serving manager.

Yet, there’s a big question mark hanging over the Gunners, too: Will there be a

hangover after winning the league for the first time in 22 years?

The non-stop roller coaster that is the Premier League begins in earnest Friday night when Arsenal hosts promoted Coventry, which has a compelling backstory of its own after being out of the big time for 25 years.

(AP)

Mission Olympics: How PVL is helping Indian volleyball create its own pathway

SANSKRITI GAUBA
n Panjim

India’s growing franchise volleyball ecosystem and dedicated Under-21 tournaments are creating a clearer pathway for young players to progress from the grassroots to the professional game and eventually the senior national team, with the ultimate ambition of Olympic qualification.

The recently-concluded inaugural Guardians Trophy, organised by Goa Guardians, brought together Under-21 players from across the country, giving them an opportunity to compete at franchise level and showcase their talent to coaches and scouts.

Goa Guardians coach Viral Shah believes sustained investment in youth is essential for India’s long-

term prospects. “The future of India is in these players. If we don’t give them exposure and teach them at this level, then the future of Indian volleyball will suffer. This is the level where we can work with them and build them,” Shah told PTI.

The tournament also exposed youngsters to players from different regions, helping them adapt to different cultures, languages and playing styles.

“Players from South, North, East and West are all here. Every culture, behaviour and playing style is different. When they stay together, they learn and communicate. Our aim is to bring them together and build a team,” Shah added.

For the players, the objective is to use these opportunities to



develop their skills and earn a senior India call-up.

Hyderabad Black Hawks U-21 captain Deepak, who led his side

to the inaugural Guardians Trophy title, said his immediate focus was on continuing his development.

“We have to develop our game

further. I want to come to India and play for the senior team,” he said.

Deepak began playing volleyball in his village at the age of 10 or 11, inspired by his grandfather and father, who were also spikers.

Goa player Suraj said the expanding league structure was giving youngsters more opportunities to compete and learn.

“Volleyball is getting a lot of attention in India. There are a lot of leagues and new platforms. There is U-21 for the youth, there are nationals, there is the league and there is PBL,” he said.

He also highlighted the value of playing alongside experienced athletes.

“We get to learn a lot. There are senior players in our team, so we get experience from playing with

them. We gain confidence. It is very good,” Suraj said.

Yogesh Kumar, a Goa player and retained player of Mumbai Meteors in the Prime Volleyball League, believes the growth of youth tournaments could eventually strengthen India’s international prospects.

“If the youth players progress, they will represent India very well at the senior level. That’s why our Indian team can qualify for the Olympics,” Yogesh said. He said the Guardians Trophy also provided a platform for young players to be noticed.

“Every team has an Under-21 player and every team has seen them. Players can be picked from here. It was a very good opportunity for us,” he said.

The tournament’s significance

extends beyond the competition itself. The trials conducted by the franchise teams have widened the pool of players competing for opportunities, while academies and grassroots programmes are providing a more sustained development structure.

Prime Volleyball League CEO Joy Bhattacharjya said the creation of such pathways was central to the league’s long-term vision.

“For the last four years, the Prime Volleyball League has been conducting the main tournament and we have seen a lot of interest from kids and young players. Then the Goa Guardians took this important decision to have a youth Under-21 tournament and invite all the teams to bring their own squads,” Bhattacharjya said.

(PTI)

India lead on Day 3 of first Test against Sri Lanka

G UNNIKRISHNAN
n Galle

Indian bowlers met an unexpected obstacle in centurion Sonal Dinusha but the Manav Suthar-led unit carried enough grunt to establish a sizable 178-run lead over Sri Lanka on the third day of the first Test here on Monday.

Sri Lanka were bowled out for 284 in their first innings as Suthar (4/76) and Ravindra Jadeja (3/57) led India's attack with skill and verve. Once the hosts were reduced to 99 for five at lunch, thanks to the early brilliance of left-arm spinner Suthar, the end seemed imminent for them.

But Dinusha, who made a crafty maiden international hundred of 100 off 168 balls, and the seasoned Niroshan Dickwella (80, 115b) added 146 runs off 216 balls for the sixth wicket to keep the rampaging Indian bowlers at bay. They added 116 runs in the second session without losing a wicket.

Unlike their top-order colleagues, Dickwella and Dinusha were not in a hurry, showing a lot of judiciousness in shot selection on a still good to bat pitch.

Sweep was a preferred mode of scoring for both the batters against Indian spinners, and the two Lankans displayed good skills from



dispatching the balls from the stump line.

Dickwella, whose selection kicked up a lot of furore in local cricketing circles, reached his 50 off 67 balls, while his younger partner was much slower in reaching the little landmark in 92 balls. However, Dickwella, who was dropped on 20 by KL Rahul at slip off Suthar, had a momentary lapse of concentration, edging pacer Prasidh Krishna to Rishabh Pant behind the stumps, a few minutes into the final session of the day.

However, Dinusha carried on and reached his hundred in 167 balls, but fell leg before to Jadeja in the very next ball.

The Dinusha-Dickwella alliance was a study class in remarkable temperament and adequate technique while facing up to skillful spinners.

But the same cannot be said about the other batters

in the Lankan top-order, who played with hard hands and drove away from body to get caught in awkward positions. In the first session, the Indian bowlers led by left-arm spinner Suthar discovered immaculate lines to tear through the Sri Lankan top-order.

India resumed from overnight 460 for 9, and added only a couple of runs to finish their first essay on 462. The Lankans needed a solid start for a strong pursuit of that total and they received anything but that.

Lead pacer Mohammad Siraj struck with his second delivery of the innings to deal an early jolt to the Lankans.

Nishan Fernando, who was impressive for SLC XI in the warm-up match, could not handle Siraj's away swing and bounce, snicking him to Devdutt Padikkal at first slip. At 0/1, the Lankans

were on the back foot immediately, and their lot never really improved in the subsequent overs.

Suthar was at the forefront of the tormentors gang, generating lovely flight, dip and turn to trouble the batters.

The young spinner got into the act with his very first delivery, finding a faint outside edge from veteran Dinesh Chandimal, which nestled in the safe palms of Rishabh Pant.

Lahiru Udara and Kamindu Mendis, two batters averaging over 50 in Test cricket, looked solid, and the latter even clattered Prasidh Krishna for a pulled six. Udara also appeared not much troubled as he pulled and cut Suthar for a couple of boundaries.

But Suthar fetched the breakthrough eventually, as Udara's feeble swish off him went straight to Yashasvi Jaiswal at gully. Suthar was exceptional as he found turn consistently bowling above 85 kmph. Mendis would count himself a bit unlucky as an uppish push off Kuldeep Yadav stuck in the stretched hands of a diving Shubman Gill. Jadeja too found himself in the wicket-takers' list with the scalp of Lankan skipper Dhananjaya de Silva (21), who feathered the left-arm spinner to Rahul at slip. (PTI)

Brazil's India visit is a spectacle, but is it the right priority?



SHAKYA MITRA

When Brazil step onto the field against India in Kolkata in the first week of October, Indian football will witness one of its most glamorous occasions. Five-time world champions, arguably the most celebrated national team in football history, will finally play on Indian soil in what promises to be a memorable evening for supporters.

For a country where generations have grown up supporting Brazil despite never having any geographical or cultural connection with the South American giants, it is an event of enormous significance. Kolkata, perhaps India's most football-passionate city, is the ideal venue.

Yet beneath the excitement lies a question that cannot be ignored. At a time when Indian football is desperately trying to arrest its decline, is a high-profile friendly against Brazil really the priority?

India were scheduled to play in the inaugural FIFA Asean Cup that runs between September 24 and October 4 where they were drawn to face Indonesia, Malaysia and Singapore, ranked much closer to India's 138th than 5th ranked Brazil. Due to this fixture clash with Brazil, the All India Football Federation has decided to withdraw the national team from the ASEAN Cup.

There is, of course, immense value in hosting a team of Brazil's stature. Indian football has welcomed legends before. In 1977, Pele came to play with his New York Cosmos team in Kolkata. But in more recent times when legends such as Pele and Diego Maradona came, they were largely ceremonial visits. Rarely have Indian supporters had the opportunity to watch one of football's greatest national teams actually play in India.

The closest comparison remains the 2011 international friendly between a full-strength Argentina and Venezuela in Kolkata. Lionel Messi was on the pitch, the stadium was packed and the atmosphere was electric. While Argentina dominated the game and Messi pulled the strings, even setting up the winning goal, it was clear to those who witnessed the game that it was not



played at the same intensity as a competitive international. That is the nature of elite football today.

Any international friendly played during the European club season comes with obvious limitations. Players are released because FIFA regulations require clubs to do so, but their employers remain Europe's biggest clubs. No manager or player wants to risk a serious injury in a fixture that carries little competitive importance.

That uncertainty becomes even more relevant when considering Brazil's current squad. Although the Seleção appointed at the 2026 FIFA World Cup by exiting in the Round of 16, they remain one of football's biggest attractions. With Neymar no longer part of the national setup, Real Madrid forward Vinicius Júnior has become Brazil's biggest global star. Given both Brazil's immense popularity in India and Real Madrid's enormous following, he would undoubtedly be the biggest draw for spectators.

But Real Madrid enter a season in which they are under pressure to reclaim both La Liga and the UEFA Champions League after two trophyless years. It is difficult to imagine the Spanish giants being particularly enthusiastic about one of their most valuable players going all out in what is effectively an exhibition match. Beyond the football, there is an even bigger issue.

What exactly is the long-term objective behind bringing Brazil to India?

Reports suggest the event could cost in the region of ₹60-70 crore. Some amount of that expenditure will undoubtedly be recovered through sponsorships, broadcasting revenue and ticket sales. But Indian football has lived with limited financial resources for decades, and every major expenditure naturally raises questions about prior-

ities. Could the same investment have produced greater long-term returns if channelled into grassroots football, coaching education, youth academies, infrastructure or player development? These remain legitimate questions.

It is equally important that the match remains accessible. While Kolkata deserves an occasion of this magnitude, they must ensure that the game's traditional supporters are not priced out, those who've followed Brazil and Indian football for decades.

India are currently ranked 138th in the FIFA rankings and, more importantly, failed to qualify for the next AFC Asian Cup. Those realities cannot be masked by one glamorous evening against Brazil. The national team's immediate objective should be climbing the international rankings and becoming consistently competitive in Asia once again.

None of this is to suggest that hosting Brazil is a mistake. On the contrary, it is a sign that India, one of the world's largest football-consuming markets, has the ambition to think big. The country should aspire to host football's biggest names.

If Brazil's visit is part of a broader vision that includes sustained investment in grassroots football, stronger youth development and regular exposure to top-quality international opposition, it could prove to be a landmark moment. If, however, it ends as a stand-alone spectacle, remembered only for packed stands and television ratings, Indian football may have celebrated a historic occasion while overlooking the far greater task that lies ahead.

The author is a sports management consultant with over a decade of experience in sports promotion and development. His work across both the private and government sectors gives him a well-rounded view of India's sports ecosystem

David Warner to feature in WCL Season 3



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
n New Delhi

The third season of World Championship of Legends (WCL) starting October 3 will feature former Australian opener David Warner alongside stars of yesteryear such as Yuvraj Singh, Wayne Bravo and AB de Villiers to name a few, organisers stated in a release. The tournament is scheduled to be held from October 3-18. India Champions won the first season against Pakistan Champions, while South Africa Champions won the second season.

"Following two record-breaking seasons, WCL 2026 will have more star power, more intensity, more national pride and more unforgettable cricketing moments. The third season has already added Bangladesh Champions to the tournament," the release stated. "The WCL Season 3 promises some bigger names joining the squad, which includes the continuation of stars like Yuvraj Singh, AB de Villiers, DJ Bravo, Shahid Afridi and Moeen Ali, with the addition of more stars like David Warner and Mahmudullah Riyadh," the release stated.

Smriti's willpower, Harmanpreet's big shots stand-out factors: Perry

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
n Mumbai

Smriti Mandhana's "incredible willpower" and a "super-strong mind" and India skipper Harmanpreet Kaur's tenacity are the qualities of the Indian superstars that stand out to her, said Australia legend Ellyse Perry on Monday. Perry hailed Smriti's approach to the game and said she has got all the qualities.

"What makes Smriti so successful? Her amazing skill," Mandhana told JioHotstar.

"She has got incredible willpower and a super-strong mind. The way she approaches the game, the way she prepares, the way she knows herself, the way she thinks about things, and the way that she likes challenges. She's got it all."

Talking about Harmanpreet, the veteran all-rounder said, "Harman, I think her greatest strength is her tenacity. She's a great competitor, and when she's going, she hits some of the biggest shots in the women's game."

Perry also gave a thumbs-up to the inaugural ICC Women's Champions Trophy, which will be held next year.

"It is another great opportunity for the women's game and for all the teams competing,"



Perry said.

"From my perspective, it's a new event, so it's always exciting to be a part of something like that and a new spot on the calendar, which will be great for everyone."

"You want to play every game well. This tournament will be physically and mentally a huge challenge, and preparing for those matches, everyone is going to have to be spot on. But the mindset remains the same; you just want to win every game."

Perry said her vast experience in the game has helped in her evolution and growth as a person.

"You just naturally evolve as you grow as a person. Over the many years, there have been a number of different experiences, things to learn, people to work with, and new avenues to explore."

"Incrementally, as that happens, you add new things or change the way

you do things. Often, they're only small changes, but over a long period of time, there's always something new or a way to learn more," she added. Perry said the landscape of women's cricket has changed since she began playing and there is a lot that senior players can learn from younger ones.

"The landscape of women's cricket is really different these days. You walk into a very different environment as a young professional, but those girls are so well prepared for that," she said. "So I don't think there is any one piece of advice. It is probably just as much as they would learn from current players, I learn from them. They have got a different experience, a different energy and a different way of going about things. So, it is just about supporting each other and having a really open mind to learn from each other," Perry added.

Babar Azam in doubt for start of desperation Test series in England

FOSTER NIUMATA
n Leeds

Two teams desperate for success meet when England and Pakistan begin a three-test series on Wednesday in Leeds. Neither has won a series of two tests or more in almost two years. England's last such triumph was in December 2024 in New Zealand. Pakistan's last was in October that same year at home against England. Since then there's been mainly suffering.

England's Ashes series in Australia unravelled in less than 11 days. England was blown away as coach Brendon McCullum overestimated and underprepared his side, and captain Ben Stokes lost faith in Bazball.

England had a chance to wipe the slate clean but McCullum and Stokes stayed.



In June, Stokes over-celebrated a win against New Zealand achieved on a trashy Lord's pitch and was suspended, and the no-nonsense Kiwis ruthlessly came from behind and took the series. McCullum was sacked as the test coach, while Stokes retired after a selfish last grasp at glory in Nottingham.

Doubts about England's leadership succession planning emerged when the captaincy was given to Joe Root ahead of test vice-captain and white-ball skipper Harry Brook, who was endorsed by

Stokes. Babar Azam was given a second stint as Pakistan captain. Shan Masood was sacked after Pakistan was swept in Bangladesh 2-0 in May and equalled its worst losing streak overseas at seven consecutive tests.

Babar, steady but unambitious as captain, thrives with the responsibility with a batting average above 50. His team lost a record eighth straight test last month in the Caribbean but they ended the streak two weeks ago against the West Indies in Port of Spain to bring some confidence to England.

However, Babar is a doubt for Headingley due to a hand injury received in the West Indies and again in a three-day warmup match last week. He will be a game-day decision, fast bowler Mohammad Abbas said on Monday. (AP)

England's Jack Whaley wins US Amateur



DAN GELSTON
n Ardmore (Oklahoma)

Jack Whaley of England used double gloves, needed an umbrella, was stung by a wasp at rainy Merion Golf Club and still pushed through the inconveniences to cap a tremendous tournament and hold off Jay Leng Jr to win the US Amateur on Sunday.

Whaley should keep the rain jacket.

The 22-year-old English amateur golfer from Doncaster gets to soak up the spoils that come with winning amateur golf's greatest prize. With skies finally clear on the rain-slogged course, Whaley sank his final putt to clinch the 36-hole final 4 and 3 and hugged it out with his caddy — his father, Andy. Whaley's mother ran out to join them for a family embrace while Andy gripped the famed wicker basket flagstick.

Whaley broke down in tears as he held the Havemeyer Trophy and dedicated the win to his father, who never stopped encouraging his son to play, even as he kept missing cuts as a teenager. "I don't think anything's going to top this," Whaley said.

Whaley made a rapid rise from NAIA star to Florida State to amateur champion and now has an exemption into the 2027 US Open, and the 2027 British Open at St. Andrews and the Masters should he remain an amateur. He wore his Florida State Seminoles cap and team colors for the championship round. He even gets a Tiger Woods medal. (AP)

Indian men's hockey team loses to England in World Cup

MONA PARTHSARATHI
n Amstelveen (The Netherlands)

Defensive lapses proved costly as India went down 2-4 to England in their second pool match of the men's Hockey World Cup here on Sunday, leaving the Harmanpreet Singh-led side needing to avoid a defeat against arch-rivals Pakistan in their clash on Wednesday. India, who had beaten Wales 3-1 in their opening match, staged a strong comeback to lead 2-1 at half-time in the Pool D match, but were completely outplayed in the third quarter, conceding two goals, before world No. 3 England added another in the final quarter.

Nicholas Bandaruk scored twice for England (14th and



55th minutes), while Stuart Rushmere (39th) and Henry Croft (43rd) were the other scorers for the winners.

Harmanpreet Singh (17th) and Dilpreet Singh (25th) scored India's goals.

England lead Pool D with two wins from two matches, while India are second with three points. Pakistan, who

drew with Wales earlier in the day, are third with one point, with Wales — also on one point — at the bottom.

India will need to either beat or draw Pakistan in their final pool match on Wednesday to qualify for the second round. A loss against Pakistan, will, however, knock India out of the tournament. (PTI)

Sindhu eases into second round, Jolly-Gayatri advance in BWF World Championships

SAUMJOYOTI S CHOUDHURY
n New Delhi

Two-time Olympic medalist PV Sindhu began her bid for a historic sixth BWF World Championships medal on a rousing note, outclassing Ireland's Sophia Noble in straight games to cruise into the women's singles second round here on Monday. Seeded ninth, the five-time World Championships medallist Sindhu made light work of Noble, winning 21-7, 21-11. The Indian has two bronze medals, two silver medals and a gold, which she had won in 2019, to her name.

A semifinal appearance at the ongoing marquee event



would assure her of at least a bronze and make her the first player in World Championships history to win six medals.

Only two other players

have won five World Championships medals — China's Lin Dan, who has five men's singles gold, and compatriot Zhao Yunlei, who won three mixed doubles

and two women's doubles titles. Sindhu toyed with her less-fancied opponent from the outset, wrapping up the contest with ease in 29 minutes.

She dominated from start to finish, making her opponent struggle to cover the court with her experience and patient game plan, drawing unforced errors from Noble to race 11-2 lead at the break in the first game before pocketing it comfortably. Sindhu, however, faced resistance in the second game as Noble upped her game to stay neck-and-neck with the Indian before Sindhu used her experience to go into the break with a 11-8 lead. (PTI)